

U.S. Metro Economic Health Report

50 Metropolitan Statistical Areas

Percentile-Based Composite Scoring · 8 Metrics · BLS & FRED Data
85% Employment / 15% Housing · June 2026

TOP PERFORMERS

#1	A+	Raleigh	76.9
#2	A+	Atlanta	73.5
#3	A+	Kansas City	70.9
#4	A+	Charlotte	68.8
#5	A	Nashville	67.5
#6	A	Austin	65.2
#7	A	Hartford	63.8

MARKETS UNDER PRESSURE

#50	D	Jacksonville	22.1
#49	C-	Richmond	29.6
#48	C-	Minneapolis	30.6
#47	C-	Riverside	30.8
#46	C-	Louisville	30.9
#45	C	Sacramento	34.3
#44	C	Grand Rapids	34.5

GRADE DISTRIBUTION

A+ / A / A-	10 cities
B+ / B / B-	22 cities
C+ / C / C-	17 cities
D	1 cities

Data sources: U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics (BLS) · Federal Reserve Economic Data (FRED)
Unemployment, CLF Growth, Earnings, Employment, Weekly Hours sourced from BLS LAUS / SAE.
Building Permits from Census Bureau via FRED. Days on Market from Realtor.com / FRED.

Scoring methodology: percentile ranking across all 50 metros.
Full methodology: SCORING_README.md
Pipeline runs weekly via GitHub Actions.

Full Rankings

All 50 Metropolitan Statistical Areas · Sorted by composite score · June 2026

#	METRO	GRADE	SCORE	UNEMP.	WAGE YOY	EMP. YOY	CLF YOY	DOM
1	Raleigh Raleigh-Cary	A+	76.9	3.0%	+4.1%	+2.0%	+0.9%	46 days
2	Atlanta Atlanta-Sandy Springs-Roswell	A+	73.5	2.8%	+5.2%	+0.2%	+0.9%	50 days
3	Kansas City Kansas City	A+	70.9	3.3%	+8.0%	-0.0%	+0.2%	43 days
4	Charlotte Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia	A+	68.8	3.5%	+2.1%	+1.1%	+0.2%	47 days
5	Nashville Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin	A	67.5	3.0%	+5.8%	+0.3%	+0.0%	52 days
6	Austin Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos	A	65.2	3.4%	+6.8%	+0.6%	+0.5%	56 days
7	Hartford Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford	A	63.8	2.7%	+1.5%	+1.9%	+2.8%	25 days
8	Cincinnati Cincinnati	A	63.2	3.1%	+4.2%	+0.3%	-1.1%	36 days
9	Pittsburgh Pittsburgh	A-	62.7	3.5%	+6.3%	-0.4%	+1.4%	45 days
10	Salt Lake City Salt Lake City-Murray	A-	62.7	3.6%	+4.3%	+1.3%	-1.1%	45 days
11	Las Vegas Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas	B+	58.8	5.1%	+5.6%	+2.0%	+0.9%	51 days
12	Dallas Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington	B+	58.6	3.8%	+2.4%	+0.5%	+0.4%	48 days
13	Birmingham Birmingham	B+	55.9	2.4%	-1.2%	+0.7%	-1.0%	54 days
14	San Diego San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad	B	54.7	4.1%	+6.8%	+0.6%	-1.5%	39 days
15	San Francisco San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont	B	54.2	3.9%	+6.7%	+0.3%	-2.4%	32 days
16	Seattle Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue	B	54.1	5.1%	+7.4%	+0.1%	-1.2%	36 days
17	Philadelphia Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington	B	53.7	3.9%	-0.4%	+0.1%	+1.0%	36 days
18	Tampa Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater	B	53.6	4.7%	+6.9%	+0.1%	+0.0%	67 days
19	Los Angeles Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim	B	53.3	4.8%	+4.8%	+1.8%	-1.6%	47 days
20	New York New York Newark-Jersey City	B	53.0	4.2%	+5.7%	+0.4%	-0.1%	42 days
21	San Jose San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara	B	52.8	3.7%	0.0%	+1.3%	-1.2%	29 days
22	Houston Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands	B	52.3	4.3%	+1.9%	+0.2%	-0.1%	49 days
23	Orlando Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford	B	50.8	4.5%	+2.8%	+1.1%	+1.1%	70 days
24	Columbus Columbus	B-	49.5	2.8%	+3.3%	+0.2%	-1.4%	33 days

#	METRO	GRADE	SCORE	UNEMP.	WAGE YOY	EMP. YOY	CLF YOY	DOM
25	Cleveland Cleveland	B-	49.0	3.4%	-0.6%	+0.6%	+1.8%	55 days
26	Memphis Memphis	B-	48.9	4.1%	+6.2%	-0.1%	-0.9%	58 days
27	St. Louis St. Louis	B-	48.3	3.6%	+1.8%	-0.5%	+0.0%	42 days
28	Denver Denver-Aurora-Centennial	B-	46.8	3.5%	+0.7%	-0.2%	-2.2%	43 days
29	Miami Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach	B-	46.4	3.9%	+7.3%	-0.2%	+0.3%	79 days
30	Virginia Beach Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk	B-	46.1	3.5%	+6.8%	-0.7%	-1.1%	33 days
31	Fresno Fresno	B-	46.1	8.1%	+4.2%	+1.7%	-0.2%	52 days
32	Phoenix Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler	B-	45.5	3.8%	+3.3%	+0.6%	-2.5%	60 days
33	Providence Providence-Warwick	C+	43.6	4.3%	+3.5%	+0.6%	+1.7%	30 days
34	Chicago Chicago-Naperville-Elgin	C+	41.3	4.9%	+4.3%	+0.1%	-2.6%	33 days
35	Indianapolis Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood	C+	41.2	2.6%	+0.5%	-0.7%	-0.8%	42 days
36	San Antonio San Antonio-New Braunfels	C+	39.7	3.8%	+1.6%	+0.0%	+0.1%	57 days
37	Baltimore Baltimore-Columbia-Towson	C+	39.2	4.3%	+4.9%	-0.7%	+0.0%	33 days
38	Oklahoma City Oklahoma City	C	37.2	3.6%	+6.2%	-1.0%	-3.0%	49 days
39	Boston Boston-Cambridge-Newton	C	36.6	3.9%	+3.7%	-0.4%	+2.9%	25 days
40	Milwaukee Milwaukee-Waukesha	C	36.3	3.7%	+1.5%	-0.9%	-0.6%	32 days
41	Washington DC Washington-Arlington-Alexandria	C	35.9	3.9%	+4.8%	-2.9%	-2.5%	30 days
42	Detroit Detroit-Warren-Dearborn	C	35.6	4.4%	+2.3%	-0.9%	-0.1%	38 days
43	Portland Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro	C	35.3	4.8%	+6.2%	-2.9%	-1.6%	47 days
44	Grand Rapids Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood	C	34.5	3.6%	+3.0%	-0.1%	-7.0%	30 days
45	Sacramento Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom	C	34.3	4.5%	+1.1%	+0.4%	-1.7%	41 days
46	Louisville Louisville-Jefferson County	C-	30.9	4.0%	+2.3%	-0.8%	-1.4%	38 days
47	Riverside Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario	C-	30.8	4.9%	+5.4%	+0.0%	-2.2%	56 days
48	Minneapolis Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington	C-	30.6	3.8%	+0.5%	-0.4%	-0.9%	34 days
49	Richmond Richmond	C-	29.6	3.4%	+3.0%	-0.5%	-0.9%	36 days
50	Jacksonville Jacksonville	D	22.1	4.8%	+1.2%	-0.4%	-0.5%	59 days

Raleigh

Raleigh-Cary

A+

EXCELLENT

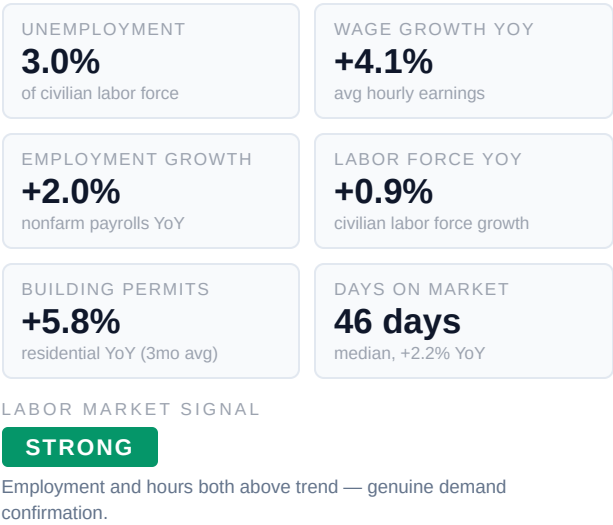
76.9th percentile

Rank 1 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Raleigh-Cary metro area has earned an overall grade of A+ with a composite score of 76.9th percentile, ranking it among the top US metros. This city's economic character is largely defined by its exceptional labor demand, with a composite score of 8.63, and its strong office economy, with a professional worker share of 4.48. The labor demand is driven by a 2.02% year-over-year employment growth rate and a 1.762% deviation in weekly hours above its own trend.

Labor Demand

The combination of a 2.02% employment growth rate and a 1.762% increase in weekly hours signals a genuine demand expansion in the Raleigh-Cary metro area. This indicates that the city is experiencing a surge in job creation, with hours worked above the trend, suggesting a strong and growing economy. The labor demand composite score of 8.63 further reinforces this notion, placing the city in the top tier.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Raleigh-Cary stands at 3.00%, which is relatively low and indicates a tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is smaller, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent. The 80th percentile rank for unemployment suggests that the market has some slack, but it is still relatively tight.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Raleigh-Cary is 4.09%, which is moderate and near the median. This suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively, and worker purchasing power is increasing. The moderate wage growth rate may help businesses balance their labor costs with the need to attract and retain talent.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living percentile rank of 80th, Raleigh-Cary is relatively affordable compared to its peers, particularly given the PSF of \$220/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$38.03/hr. The city's affordability, driven by a -1.4% year-over-year decrease in PSF, makes it an attractive location for talent without requiring significant wage premiums. This can be a major advantage for businesses looking to attract workers.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Raleigh-Cary is growing at a rate of 0.90% year-over-year, indicating an expanding workforce supply. This growth suggests that the city has a structural advantage in terms of hiring capacity, as the labor pool is increasing. Businesses can tap into this growing labor force to meet their staffing needs.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Raleigh-Cary has increased by 5.85% year-over-year, signaling an expansion in housing supply. This growth in permits suggests that the city is likely to see an improvement in affordability and an increase in the availability of housing for workers, making it easier for businesses to attract and retain talent.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Raleigh-Cary is 46 days, with a 2.2% year-over-year increase. This suggests a relatively competitive market, but one that is still accessible for workers relocating to the city. The moderate days on market indicate a balanced market, neither extremely hot nor cold, which can help businesses plan their relocation and hiring strategies.

Office Economy

With a professional worker share of 4.48, Raleigh-Cary has a deep and talented pool of office workers, placing it in the top tier. This makes the city an ideal location for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, which require specialized knowledge-economy talent. However, it may be less suited for industries with more industrial or logistics-oriented workforces.

The Raleigh-Cary metro area offers businesses a unique combination of strong labor demand, a growing labor force, and a relatively affordable cost of living, making it an attractive location for investment. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the potential for a tight labor market to drive up wages and make hiring more competitive, which could impact business costs and profitability.

Atlanta

Atlanta-Sandy Springs-Roswell

A+

EXCELLENT

73.5th percentile

Rank 2 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand		72
25% weight		
Unemployment		88
20% weight		
Wage Growth		66
15% weight		
Cost of Living		67
12% weight		
Labor Force YoY		80
10% weight		
Bldg. Permits		64
10% weight		
Days on Market		64
5% weight		
Office Economy		78
3% weight		

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT 2.8% of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY +5.2% avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH +0.2% nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY +0.9% civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS +10.5% residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET 50 days median, +6.4% YoY
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL STRONG Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Atlanta-Sandy Springs-Roswell metro area has earned an overall grade of A+ with a composite score of 73.5th percentile, ranking it among the top US metros. The city's economic character is largely defined by its strong labor demand, with a composite score of 5.82, and its low unemployment rate of 2.80%, which signals a tight labor market. These metrics, combined with a labor force growth rate of 0.86%, indicate a city with a robust and expanding workforce.

Labor Demand

The city's employment growth rate of 0.21% and weekly hours deviation of +1.222% from its own trend suggest genuine demand expansion, as hours are running above trend during a period of job growth. This combination signals that the labor market is experiencing organic growth, driven by increasing demand for workers. The labor demand composite score of 5.82, ranking in the 72nd percentile, further supports this assessment.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 2.80% indicates a very tight labor market, ranking in the 88th percentile. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is limited, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent. The tight labor market also implies upward pressure on wages, as workers have more bargaining power.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of 5.22% is above average, ranking in the 66th percentile. This signals that labor costs for employers are rising, but workers are also experiencing increased purchasing power. The moderate to fast wage growth rate suggests that businesses should factor in rising labor costs when considering relocation or expansion in this city.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of 5.36, based on \$199/sqft and \$37.13/hr, and a percentile rank of 67th, the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers. The fact that the PSF is rising by 0.5% YoY, albeit slowly, means that the city's affordability is not rapidly deteriorating. This affordability advantage can help attract talent without requiring significant wage premiums, making it an attractive location for businesses.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is growing at a rate of 0.86% year-over-year, ranking in the 80th percentile. This indicates that the workforce supply is expanding, providing businesses with a growing pool of potential employees. The positive labor force growth rate suggests that hiring capacity is increasing, making it easier for businesses to find the talent they need.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is +10.47%, ranking in the 64th percentile. This signals that housing supply is expanding, which should improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce. The increase in building permits suggests that the city is investing in its future housing needs, reducing the risk of a supply squeeze and making it more attractive to relocating workers.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 50 days, with a year-over-year increase of 6.4%. This suggests that the housing market is normalizing, with homes taking slightly longer to sell. However, with a percentile rank of 64th, the market is still relatively competitive, and relocating workers may face challenges in finding available housing.

Office Economy

The city's professional and office worker share is 3.36, ranking in the 78th percentile. This indicates a deep talent pool, making it an attractive location for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors. The city's strong office economy suggests that it is well-suited for knowledge-intensive industries, but may be less suitable for industrial or logistics-dominant businesses.

The Atlanta-Sandy Springs-Roswell metro area offers businesses a unique combination of a strong labor market, low unemployment, and a growing workforce, making it an attractive location for relocation or expansion. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the potential for upward pressure on wages due to the tight labor market, which may increase labor costs for employers.

Kansas City

Kansas City

A+

EXCELLENT

70.9th percentile

Rank 3 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand		40
25% weight		
Unemployment		86
20% weight		
Wage Growth		98
15% weight		
Cost of Living		92
12% weight		
Labor Force YoY		72
10% weight		
Bldg. Permits		92
10% weight		
Days on Market		14
5% weight		
Office Economy		28
3% weight		

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT 3.3% of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY +8.0% avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH -0.0% nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY +0.2% civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS +67.4% residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET 43 days median, -8.5% YoY
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL SQUEEZE Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Kansas City boasts an overall grade of A+ with a composite score of 70.9th percentile, ranking it among the top US metros. The city's economic character is largely defined by its top-tier unemployment rate of 3.30% and exceptional wage growth of +7.97% year-over-year. These metrics signal a highly competitive labor market with strong worker purchasing power.

Labor Demand

Kansas City's employment growth rate is -0.03% year-over-year, combined with a +0.421% deviation in weekly hours from its own trend. This combination suggests a slight survivor squeeze, where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles. The labor demand composite score of 3.84 places the city near the median, indicating a relatively stable labor market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Kansas City is 3.30%, ranking it in the top tier at the 86th percentile. This tight labor market implies that businesses may face challenges in hiring, with upward pressure on wages. Companies looking to staff up in Kansas City should be prepared to offer competitive compensation packages.

Wage Growth

Wage growth in Kansas City is a notable +7.97% year-over-year, placing it in the top tier at the 98th percentile. This rapid wage growth signals rising labor costs for employers, but also strong worker purchasing power. Businesses should factor in increasing labor costs when considering Kansas City as a location.

Cost of Living

Kansas City's cost of living is relatively affordable, with a percentile rank of 92nd and a price-to-salary ratio of \$199/sqft to \$36.17/hr, resulting in a ratio of 5.50. The city's affordability advantage can attract talent without requiring significant wage premiums, making it an attractive location for businesses.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Kansas City is growing at a rate of +0.25% year-over-year, placing it above average at the 72nd percentile. This expanding labor force supply indicates a positive trend for hiring capacity, with a growing pool of potential workers available.

Building Permits

Residential building permits in Kansas City are increasing by +67.43% year-over-year, ranking it in the top tier at the 92nd percentile. This surge in permits suggests that housing supply is expanding, which should improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce.

Days on Market

The current median days on market in Kansas City is 43 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -8.5%. This relatively fast market, ranked in the bottom tier at the 14th percentile, may pose challenges for relocating workers, as homes are selling quickly.

Office Economy

Kansas City's professional and office worker share is below average, ranking at the 28th percentile. While the city has a notable presence of professional roles, it is not as deep as other metros, making it less suited for tech, finance, or consulting headquarters, but still viable for other business types.

In conclusion, Kansas City offers businesses a unique combination of a tight labor market, rapid wage growth, and relatively affordable cost of living. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the highly competitive labor market, which may drive up labor costs and pose challenges in hiring and retaining top talent.

Charlotte

Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia

A+

EXCELLENT

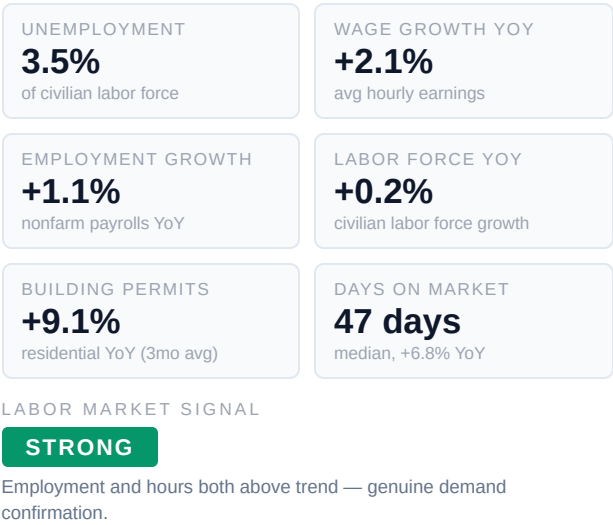
68.8th percentile

Rank 4 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia metro area has earned an overall grade of A+ with a composite score ranking in the 68.8th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with a composite score in the top tier at the 88th percentile, driven by a 1.08% year-over-year employment growth rate and a 0.846% deviation in weekly hours above its own trend. The combination of these metrics signals genuine demand expansion, indicating a healthy and growing job market.

Labor Demand

The Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia metro area has seen a 1.08% year-over-year employment growth rate, paired with a 0.846% deviation in weekly hours above its own trend, resulting in a top-tier labor demand composite score. This combination signals genuine demand expansion, indicating that the city is experiencing a period of job growth with increasing hours worked. This is a positive sign for businesses looking to expand or establish operations in the area.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia stands at 3.50%, ranking in the 72nd percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market. With an unemployment rate below the national average, businesses may face challenges in finding available talent, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract top candidates. This tight market also suggests that workers may have more bargaining power, potentially driving up labor costs.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia is 2.06%, ranking in the 28th percentile, indicating relatively slow wage growth. This moderate pace of wage growth may help keep labor costs in check for employers, but it also means that workers may not see significant increases in their purchasing power. As a result, businesses may need to consider other benefits or incentives to attract and retain top talent.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of \$221/sqft to \$37.49/hr, and a year-over-year decrease of 1.8% in PSF, Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia ranks in the 76th percentile for affordability. This means that the city is relatively more affordable compared to its peers, making it an attractive location for businesses looking to relocate or expand without needing to offer significant wage premiums to offset high living costs. The decreasing PSF relative to wages is a key driver of this affordability.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia has grown by 0.17% year-over-year, ranking in the 70th percentile, indicating a slowly expanding workforce supply. While this growth is modest, it suggests that the city's labor pool is not contracting, providing a stable foundation for businesses looking to hire and expand their operations. However, the slow pace of growth may limit the availability of new talent in the market.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia has increased by 9.08% year-over-year, ranking in the 60th percentile, indicating an expansion of housing supply. This growth in building permits suggests that the city's housing market is likely to become more affordable in the future, making it easier for workers to relocate and for businesses to attract talent. The increasing supply of housing also reduces the risk of a housing shortage constraining workforce growth.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia is 47 days, with a year-over-year increase of 6.8%, ranking in the 74th percentile. This indicates a relatively slow and accessible market for workers relocating to the city, giving them more time to find suitable housing. The rising days on market also suggests a healthy normalization of the housing market, rather than a demand-driven slowdown.

Office Economy

With an office and professional worker share ranking in the 82nd percentile, Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia has a deep talent pool suited for tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions. The city's strong office economy makes it an attractive location for businesses in these sectors, but it may be less suited for industries with more industrial or logistics-oriented workforces. The high percentile rank indicates a significant competitive advantage in attracting and retaining knowledge-economy talent.

The Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia metro area offers businesses a unique combination of strong labor demand, a relatively affordable cost of living, and a deep talent pool in the office and professional sectors. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers to factor in is the relatively tight labor market, which may drive up labor costs and require competitive wages to attract top talent.

Nashville

Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin

A

VERY GOOD

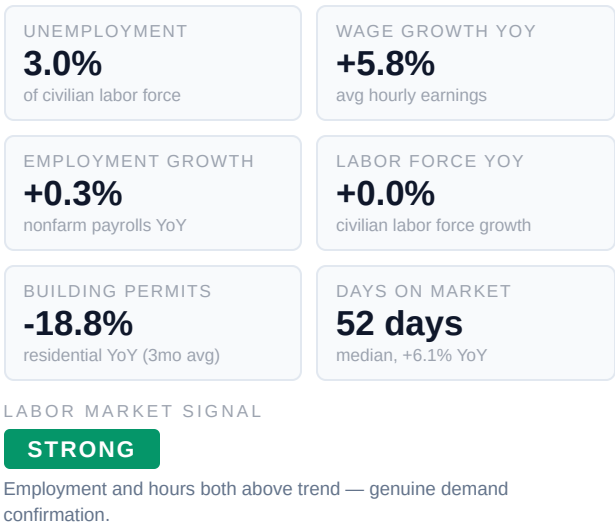
67.5th percentile

Rank 5 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin has earned an overall grade of A, ranking in the 67.5th percentile among 50 US metros, with a strong labor demand and a deep office economy talent pool defining its current economic character. The city's labor demand composite score of 6.01 and office/professional worker share of 3.74, ranking in the 82nd and 88th percentiles respectively, highlight its robust job market and specialized workforce. With employment growth of 0.28% YoY and weekly hours 1.321% above trend, Nashville's economy is characterized by genuine demand expansion.

Labor Demand

Nashville's employment growth rate of 0.28% YoY, combined with weekly hours 1.321% above trend, signals a genuine demand expansion, indicating that the city is adding jobs and workers are putting in more hours than usual. This combination suggests a strong and growing labor market, where businesses can find the talent they need to expand. The labor demand composite score of 6.01, ranking in the 82nd percentile, further reinforces this assessment.

Unemployment

The city's unemployment rate of 3.00% indicates a relatively tight labor market, ranking in the 74th percentile. This means that businesses may face challenges in finding available workers, and wage pressure may be higher as a result. With a tight labor market, companies may need to offer competitive salaries and benefits to attract top talent.

Wage Growth

Nashville's year-over-year wage growth rate of 5.81% is relatively fast, ranking in the 74th percentile. This rapid wage growth may lead to rising labor costs for employers, but it also means that workers have increasing purchasing power, which can benefit local businesses. As wages continue to grow, companies may need to adjust their compensation packages to remain competitive.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of 7.32, based on \$263/sqft and \$35.91/hr, Nashville ranks in the 57th percentile, indicating a near-median affordability level. The fact that PSF is falling by 0.8% YoY relative to wages is a positive sign for affordability. This means that the city is relatively affordable for talent, and businesses may not need to offer significant wage premiums to attract workers from other areas.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Nashville is growing at a rate of 0.02% YoY, ranking in the 64th percentile. While this growth rate is relatively slow, it still indicates that the workforce supply is expanding, albeit gradually. This slow growth may pose some challenges for businesses looking to hire, but it also suggests that the labor market is not overheating.

Building Permits

The city's residential building permits have decreased by 18.82% YoY, ranking in the 22nd percentile. This sharp decline suggests that housing supply is tightening, which may lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce. As the supply of new housing units slows, businesses may need to consider the potential impact on their employees' ability to find affordable housing.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Nashville is currently 52 days, with a 6.1% YoY increase. This indicates a relatively slow market, ranking in the 60th percentile. For workers relocating to the city, this means that they may have a more accessible and less competitive housing market, with more time to find a suitable home.

Office Economy

Nashville's office economy is deep and specialized, with an office/professional worker share of 3.74, ranking in the 88th percentile. This makes the city an attractive location for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, which require a highly skilled and knowledgeable workforce. However, it may be less suited for industries with more industrial or logistics-oriented workforces.

In conclusion, Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin offers businesses a strong labor market, a deep office economy talent pool, and a relatively affordable cost of living. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the tightening housing supply, which may lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce, highlighting the need for businesses to consider the potential impact on their employees' ability to find affordable housing.

Austin

Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos

A

VERY GOOD

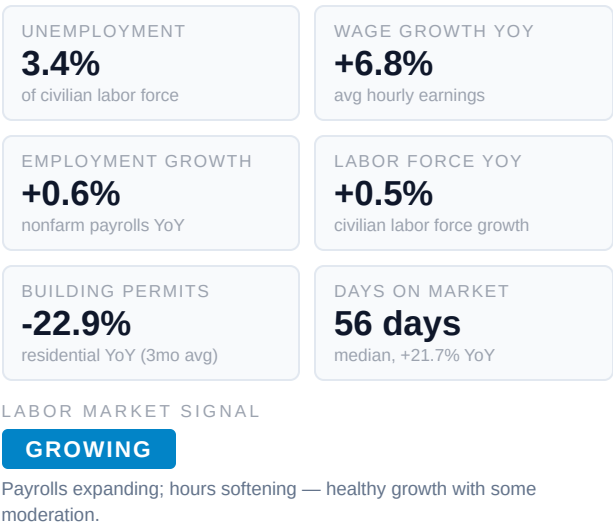
65.2th percentile

Rank 6 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos metro area has earned an overall grade of A, ranking in the 65.2th percentile among 50 US metros, with a composite score driven significantly by its top-tier wage growth and cost of living metrics. Specifically, the city's wage growth of +6.75% year-over-year and its cost of living ratio of \$240/sqft to \$37.61/hr, which has decreased by 8.1% year-over-year, stand out as defining characteristics. These metrics suggest a city with a strong economy and attractive affordability.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos is +0.63% year-over-year, combined with a -0.498% deviation in weekly hours from its own trend, indicating a near median labor demand composite score of 4.68. This combination signals a moderate expansion in job numbers but with hours worked slightly below the city's own trend, suggesting some level of genuine demand but not at an accelerated pace. The labor market is thus characterized by steady, albeit not spectacular, growth.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos stands at 3.40%, placing it in the 66th percentile, which indicates a tighter labor market. This tightness implies that businesses may face challenges in hiring due to the lower availability of workers, potentially leading to upward pressure on wages. For a business trying to hire in this market, being competitive with salary offerings will be crucial.

Wage Growth

With a year-over-year wage growth rate of +6.75%, Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos experiences fast wage growth, ranking it in the 86th percentile. This rapid wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, which can be a challenge for businesses but is beneficial for workers' purchasing power. Employers will need to factor in these increasing labor costs when considering operations in this metro area.

Cost of Living

The cost of living in Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos, with a PSF of \$240/sqft versus \$37.61/hr earnings, resulting in a ratio of 6.38, and an 8.1% year-over-year decrease in PSF, places it in the top tier for affordability, ranking in the 94th percentile. This high affordability ranking means the city has a significant talent attraction advantage without needing wage premiums, making it an attractive location for businesses looking to relocate or expand.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos has grown by +0.54% year-over-year, ranking in the 78th percentile. This positive growth rate indicates that the workforce supply is expanding, which is a favorable condition for businesses looking to hire, as it

suggests a growing pool of potential employees.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is -22.85%, placing it in the bottom tier. This significant decline suggests that the housing supply is tightening, which could lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce. This trend may signal potential risks for businesses reliant on a readily available and affordable housing stock for their employees.

Days on Market

Homes in Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos currently sit on the market for a median of 56 days, with a year-over-year increase of 21.7%. This increase in days on market, ranking in the 72nd percentile, indicates a slowing market, which can be beneficial for workers relocating to the area as it becomes less competitive. However, in the context of a strong job market, this slowing could also signal a healthy normalization rather than demand erosion.

Office Economy

With an office and professional worker share composite score of 4.28, ranking in the 92nd percentile, Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos boasts a deep talent pool suited for tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions. This makes the city an ideal location for businesses in these sectors but less suited for those in industrial or logistics-dominant economies.

In conclusion, Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos offers businesses a unique combination of strong wage growth, high affordability, and a deep professional talent pool, making it an attractive location for certain industries. However, the significant decline in building permits and its implications for future housing affordability and workforce accommodation pose a considerable risk that decision-makers should carefully consider when evaluating this metro area for business relocation or expansion.

Hartford

Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford

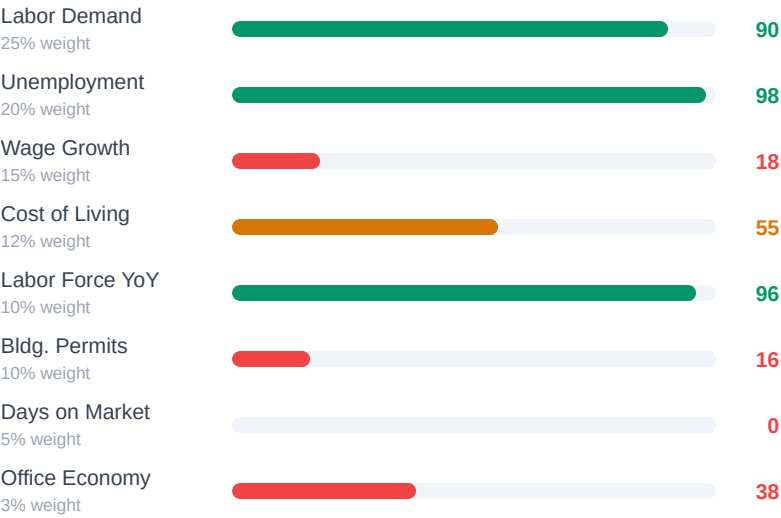
A

VERY GOOD

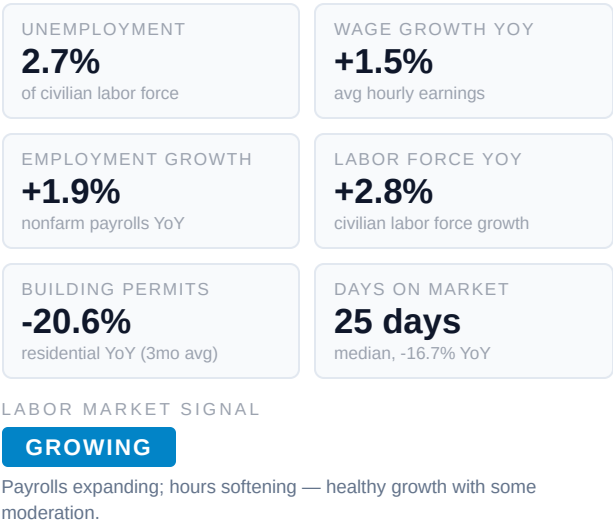
63.8th percentile

Rank 7 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford metro area has earned an overall grade of A, ranking in the 63.8th percentile among 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its strong labor demand and low unemployment rate, at 2.70%. The city's labor demand composite score of 6.66, combining a 1.88% employment growth rate and a -0.272% weekly hours deviation, signals genuine demand expansion. These metrics define the city's current economic character, with a tight labor market and growing workforce.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of 1.88% and weekly hours deviation of -0.272% indicate that the city is experiencing genuine demand expansion, with jobs being added and hours worked being slightly below trend. This combination suggests that the labor market is strong, with employers hiring more workers and maintaining a stable workload. The labor demand composite score of 6.66, ranking in the 90th percentile, further reinforces this assessment.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 2.70% is extremely low, ranking in the 98th percentile, indicating a very tight labor market with little slack. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is limited, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent. The low unemployment rate also suggests that workers have strong bargaining power.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of 1.48% is relatively slow, ranking in the 18th percentile, indicating that labor costs are not rising rapidly. This may be beneficial for employers, as it keeps costs under control, but it also means that workers may not have strong purchasing power. The slow wage growth may be a concern for businesses that rely on consumer spending.

Cost of Living

The city's cost of living, with a PSF of \$254/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$39.73/hr, resulting in a ratio of 6.39, is near the median, ranking in the 55th percentile. This means that the city is moderately affordable, which can be a talent attraction advantage, as workers may not require significant wage premiums to maintain their standard of living. The fact that PSF is falling by 1.6% YoY is a positive sign for affordability.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is growing at a rate of 2.77% year-over-year, ranking in the 96th percentile, indicating that the workforce supply is expanding rapidly. This is a positive sign for businesses, as it means that there will be a larger pool of potential workers to hire from, making it easier to find talent. The growing labor force also suggests that the city is attractive to workers.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits is -20.59%, ranking in the 16th percentile, indicating that housing supply is tightening. This may lead to future affordability concerns and make it more challenging for workers to find housing, potentially affecting workforce accommodation. The decline in building permits is a concern for businesses that rely on a growing and accessible workforce.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 25 days, with a year-over-year decline of 16.7%, ranking in the 0th percentile. This means that the housing market is highly competitive, with homes selling quickly, which can make it challenging for relocating workers to find housing. The fast-paced market may require businesses to offer relocation assistance or other incentives to attract talent.

Office Economy

The city's professional and office worker share is 2.32, ranking in the 38th percentile, indicating that the talent pool is not particularly deep. This means that the city may be less suited for businesses that require a large number of specialized office workers, such as tech or finance companies. However, the city may be more attractive to businesses with industrial or logistics-oriented operations.

The Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford metro area offers businesses a strong labor market, low unemployment, and a moderately affordable cost of living, making it an attractive location for companies looking to hire and grow. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the tightening housing supply, which may lead to future affordability concerns and affect workforce accommodation, potentially offsetting the city's other advantages.

Cincinnati

Cincinnati

A

VERY GOOD

63.2th percentile

Rank 8 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand		46
25% weight		
Unemployment		94
20% weight		
Wage Growth		54
15% weight		
Cost of Living		71
12% weight		
Labor Force YoY		32
10% weight		
Bldg. Permits		72
10% weight		
Days on Market		92
5% weight		
Office Economy		40
3% weight		

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT of civilian labor force 3.1%	WAGE GROWTH YOY avg hourly earnings +4.2%
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH nonfarm payrolls YoY +0.3%	LABOR FORCE YOY civilian labor force growth -1.1%
BUILDING PERMITS residential YoY (3mo avg) +16.9%	DAYS ON MARKET median, +9.1% YoY 36 days
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL GROWING Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Cincinnati earns an overall grade of A, ranking in the 63.2th percentile among 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its low unemployment rate of 3.10% and a strong building permits growth of +16.86% YoY. These two metrics most define the city's current economic character, suggesting a tight labor market and an expanding housing supply. The city's labor demand composite score of 4.60, although near median, is influenced by a modest employment growth rate of +0.30% YoY.

Labor Demand

Cincinnati's employment growth rate of +0.30% YoY, combined with a weekly hours deviation of -0.124% from its own trend, signals a moderate labor demand expansion, rather than a strong one, as hours are not running significantly above trend. This suggests that while jobs are being added, the existing workforce is not being overly stretched, indicating genuine demand rather than a survivor squeeze. The labor demand composite score of 4.60 reflects this balanced situation.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Cincinnati is 3.10%, placing it in the top tier with a 94th percentile rank, indicating a very tight labor market with little slack. This tight market implies that businesses may face challenges in hiring, potentially leading to upward pressure on wages. For a company looking to expand or relocate, this means being prepared to offer competitive compensation packages to attract top talent.

Wage Growth

With a year-over-year wage growth rate of +4.25%, Cincinnati experiences moderate wage increases, ranking near the median at the 54th percentile. This rate of wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not at an alarming rate, while workers benefit from increasing purchasing power. This balance is crucial for businesses to manage labor costs effectively while ensuring worker satisfaction.

Cost of Living

Cincinnati's cost of living, with a PSF of \$195/sqft and an average hourly earnings of \$35.36, resulting in a ratio of 5.51, places it in the 71st percentile in terms of affordability. This means the city is more affordable than many of its peers, offering a talent attraction advantage without necessitating significant wage premiums. The modest increase in PSF of +1.0% YoY, however, suggests that affordability might slightly decrease over time.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Cincinnati is shrinking at a rate of -1.12% YoY, indicating a contracting labor supply. This negative growth rate poses a structural headwind for hiring, as the pool of potential workers is decreasing. Businesses looking to expand in Cincinnati will need

to consider strategies to attract workers from other areas or invest in workforce development programs.

Building Permits

With a +16.86% YoY increase in residential building permits, Cincinnati is experiencing an expansion in housing supply. This growth in permits signals developer confidence in the market and suggests that future affordability and workforce accommodation are likely to improve. As housing supply increases, it may help mitigate some of the pressures from a tight labor market by making the city more attractive to potential residents.

Days on Market

Homes in Cincinnati are currently sitting on the market for a median of 36 days, with a +9.1% YoY increase in days on market, placing it in the top tier with a 92nd percentile rank. This indicates a slower market that is more accessible for relocating workers, as they have more time to find suitable housing. The rising DOM suggests a healthy normalization of the housing market, making it less competitive for buyers.

Office Economy

Cincinnati's professional and office worker share, with a composite score of 2.38, ranks in the 40th percentile, indicating a moderately deep talent pool. This suggests that the city is suited for businesses that require a mix of professional and other skills, though it may not be as ideal for tech, finance, or consulting firms that rely heavily on a deep knowledge-economy talent pool.

In conclusion, Cincinnati offers businesses a unique blend of a tight labor market, moderate wage growth, and an expanding housing supply, making it an attractive location for companies looking to balance labor costs with access to a skilled workforce. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the shrinking labor force, which may necessitate innovative recruitment and retention strategies to overcome the challenges of a contracting workforce supply.

Pittsburgh

Pittsburgh

A-

GOOD

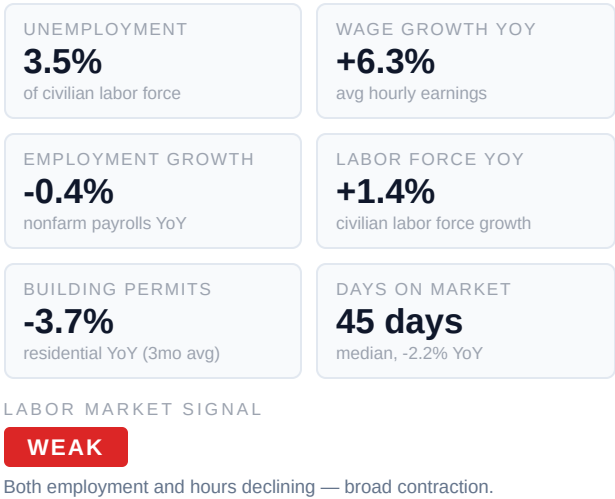
62.7th percentile

Rank 9 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Pittsburgh earns an overall grade of A- with a composite score ranking at the 62.7th percentile among 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its strong wage growth, with a year-over-year increase of 6.34%, and its low unemployment rate of 3.50%, which ranks in the 78th percentile. These metrics suggest a competitive labor market with rising labor costs.

Labor Demand

Pittsburgh's employment growth rate is -0.43% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating -0.173% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, indicating that the city is not adding jobs at a significant rate and hours are below trend. This scenario may lead to a survivor squeeze, where remaining workers absorb the load of eliminated roles.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Pittsburgh is 3.50%, ranking in the 78th percentile, which indicates a tight labor market with low unemployment. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is smaller, and may need to offer higher wages to attract talent. The tight market implies more wage pressure for employers.

Wage Growth

Pittsburgh's year-over-year wage growth rate is 6.34%, ranking in the 82nd percentile, which is considered fast. This rapid wage growth implies rising labor costs for employers, but it also means that workers have increased purchasing power. As a result, businesses may need to adjust their budgets to accommodate higher labor costs.

Cost of Living

Pittsburgh has a cost of living score that ranks in the 82nd percentile, with a PSF of \$172/sqft and an average hourly earnings of \$33.65/hr, resulting in a ratio of 5.11. This indicates that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers. The affordability of Pittsburgh means that businesses can attract talent without needing to offer significant wage premiums to offset high living costs.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Pittsburgh is growing at a rate of 1.38% year-over-year, which is in the 90th percentile. This expansion in labor force supply implies that the city has a growing pool of potential workers, making it easier for businesses to hire and expand their operations. The increasing labor force is a positive sign for businesses looking to grow in the area.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Pittsburgh has decreased by 3.72% year-over-year, ranking near the median. This decline in permits suggests that the housing supply is not expanding at a significant rate, which may lead to future affordability concerns and challenges in

accommodating a growing workforce. The decrease in building permits is a potential risk for businesses that rely on a growing and affordable housing stock.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Pittsburgh is 45 days, with a year-over-year decrease of 2.2%. This indicates a relatively fast-paced market, where homes are selling quickly. For workers relocating to the city, this means that they may face a competitive housing market, making it challenging to find and secure a home.

Office Economy

Pittsburgh's office economy ranks near the median, with a composite score of 2.44. This suggests that the city has a moderate depth of professional talent, making it suitable for businesses that require a mix of office and non-office workers. However, it may not be the best fit for businesses that rely heavily on specialized professional or tech talent, as other cities may offer a deeper pool of such workers.

In conclusion, Pittsburgh offers businesses a unique combination of strong wage growth, low unemployment, and a relatively affordable cost of living. However, the city's declining building permits and competitive housing market pose a risk to businesses that rely on a growing and affordable housing stock, making it essential for decision-makers to factor in these constraints when considering Pittsburgh as a location.

Salt Lake City

Salt Lake City-Murray

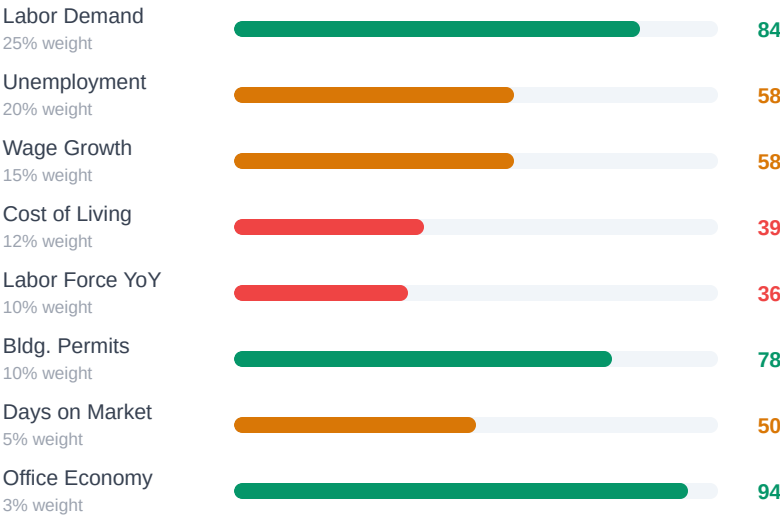
A-

GOOD

62.7th percentile

Rank 10 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Salt Lake City-Murray metro area has an overall grade of A- with a composite score ranking at the 62.7th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with an 84th percentile ranking, and its deep professional talent pool, ranking at the 94th percentile. The labor demand composite score of 6.12, driven by a +1.33% employment growth rate and -0.047% weekly hours deviation, signals genuine demand expansion.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of +1.33% and weekly hours deviation of -0.047% indicate that the city is experiencing genuine demand expansion, with more jobs being added and hours running slightly below trend. This combination suggests that the labor market is robust, with employers hiring and workers having more opportunities. The top-tier ranking of 84th percentile for labor demand composite score reinforces this assessment.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 3.60% ranks at the 58th percentile, indicating a near-median level of slack in the labor market. This rate suggests that while the market is not extremely tight, it is still relatively competitive, and businesses may face some challenges in hiring. However, the moderate unemployment rate also implies that there is a pool of available workers, which can be beneficial for companies looking to staff up.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of +4.31% ranks at the 58th percentile, indicating moderate wage growth. This rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not extremely rapidly, and worker purchasing power is increasing. The moderate wage growth rate may attract businesses that want to balance labor costs with worker satisfaction.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of 6.80, which is below average, and a percentile rank of 39th, Salt Lake City-Murray is relatively expensive compared to its peers. The PSF of \$266/sqft, which has increased by 0.4% year-over-year, relative to average hourly earnings of \$39.12, contributes to this assessment. This means that businesses may need to offer wage premiums to attract talent, as the city's affordability is not a major advantage.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force has contracted by -1.05% year-over-year, ranking at the 36th percentile. This decline in labor force supply may pose a structural headwind for hiring, as the pool of available workers is shrinking. Businesses may need to adapt their recruitment

strategies to attract workers from other areas or invest in training and development programs.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is +23.54%, ranking at the 78th percentile. This increase in permits suggests that housing supply is expanding, which may improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce. The rising permits also signal developer confidence in the market, which can be beneficial for businesses looking to establish or expand operations.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 45 days, with a year-over-year increase of +2.3%. This relatively moderate days on market, ranking at the 50th percentile, suggests that the housing market is neither extremely competitive nor extremely slow. For workers relocating to this city, the market is relatively accessible, with homes selling at a moderate pace.

Office Economy

With an office/professional worker share ranking at the 94th percentile, Salt Lake City-Murray has a deep talent pool suited for tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions. The city's strong professional sector makes it an attractive location for businesses in these industries, but it may be less suitable for companies with primarily industrial or logistics-based operations.

The Salt Lake City-Murray metro area offers businesses a strong labor demand, a deep professional talent pool, and an expanding housing supply. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the relatively expensive cost of living, which may require wage premiums to attract talent. Overall, this city is well-suited for businesses that value a robust labor market and a highly skilled workforce, but may need to carefully consider compensation packages to remain competitive.

Las Vegas

Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas

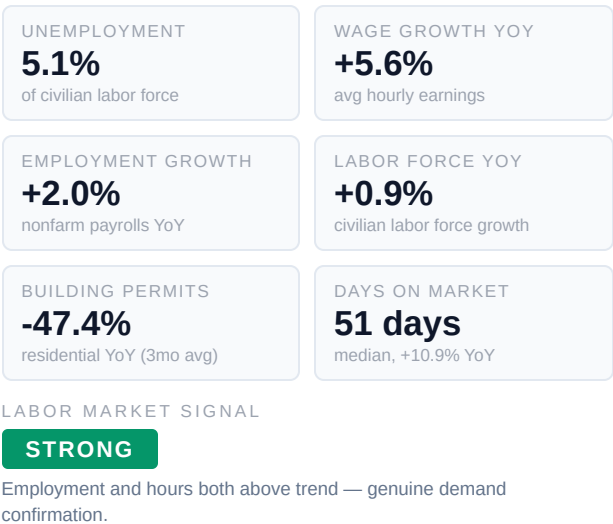
B+

ABOVE AVERAGE
58.8th percentile
Rank 11 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas metro area has earned an overall grade of B+ with a composite score ranking at the 58.8th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with a top-tier composite score of 94th percentile, and its robust office economy, ranking at the 86th percentile. The labor demand is driven by a 2.04% year-over-year employment growth rate and a 0.024% deviation in weekly hours above its own trend.

Labor Demand

The combination of a 2.04% employment growth rate and a 0.024% increase in weekly hours above trend signals genuine demand expansion in the Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas metro area. This indicates that the city is experiencing a period of job growth, with hours worked also increasing, suggesting a strong and vibrant labor market. The labor demand composite score of 7.18 further reinforces this assessment, ranking at the 94th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas stands at 5.10%, which corresponds to a below-average percentile rank of 22nd. This suggests that the labor market has some slack, making it relatively easier for businesses to hire compared to tighter markets. However, the practical implication for a business trying to hire here is that while there may be a larger pool of potential candidates, the overall labor market conditions are not as favorable as in other cities.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas is 5.63%, ranking at the 70th percentile, indicating a moderate to fast pace of wage increases. This implies that employer labor costs are rising, but worker purchasing power is also increasing, which can have positive effects on local consumer demand. The wage growth rate suggests a relatively strong labor market where workers have some bargaining power.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of \$264/sqft to \$33.16/hr, resulting in a ratio of 7.96, and a percentile rank of 45th, Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas is near the median in terms of affordability compared to its peers. The fact that PSF is decreasing by 2.2% year-over-year is a positive sign for affordability. This means that the city offers a relatively neutral environment for talent attraction, neither requiring significant wage premiums to compensate for high costs nor offering a substantial advantage in terms of affordability.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas is growing at a rate of 0.95% year-over-year, ranking at the 84th percentile. This indicates that the workforce supply is expanding, which is a positive sign for businesses looking to hire, as it suggests a growing pool of potential candidates. The implication for hiring capacity is favorable, with a larger and increasing labor force available.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is -47.38%, ranking at the 0th percentile, indicating a sharp decline in housing supply expansion. This signals a potential future affordability issue and a tightening of the housing market, which could impact the city's ability to attract and accommodate a growing workforce. The significant drop in building permits is a concern for future workforce accommodation and affordability.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 51 days, with a year-over-year increase of 10.9%, ranking at the 80th percentile. This suggests a slower market, which can be more accessible for workers relocating to the city, as they have more time to find a home. However, in the context of a strong job market, this could also indicate a healthy normalization of the housing market.

Office Economy

With an office and professional worker share composite score of 3.66, ranking at the 86th percentile, Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas has a deep talent pool suited for tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions. This city is well-suited for businesses that rely on professional and office sectors, offering a significant advantage in terms of accessing specialized labor.

The Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas metro area offers a business a strong labor market with genuine demand expansion, a growing labor force, and a deep professional talent pool. However, the single biggest risk or constraint a decision-maker should factor in is the sharp decline in residential building permits, which signals potential future affordability issues and a tightening housing market, posing a challenge for workforce accommodation and attraction.

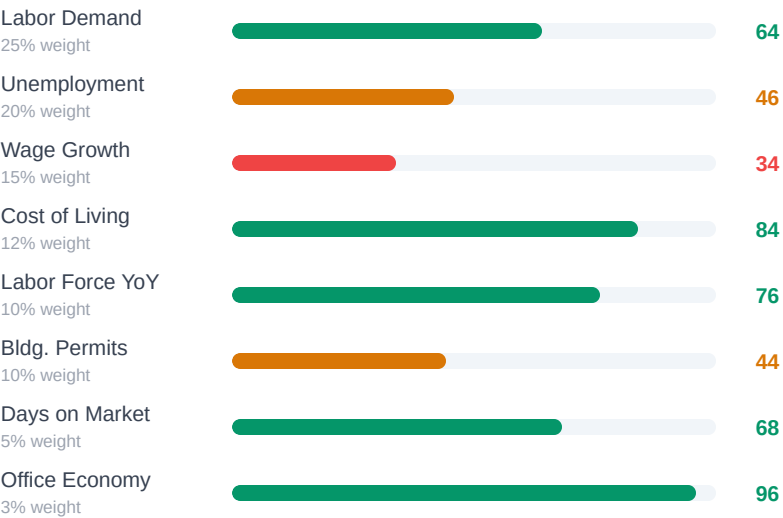
Dallas

Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington

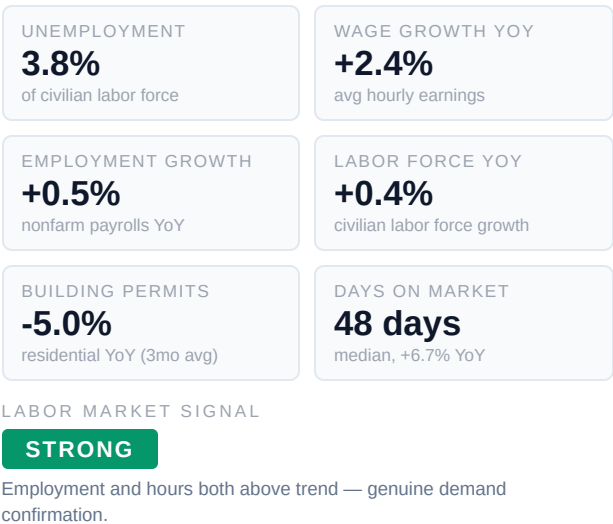
B+

ABOVE AVERAGE
58.6th percentile
Rank 12 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington metro area has earned an overall grade of B+ with a composite score ranking at the 58.6th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with a composite score at the 64th percentile, and its highly affordable cost of living, ranked at the 84th percentile. The labor demand is driven by a combination of employment growth and hours worked above trend, signaling genuine demand expansion.

Labor Demand

The Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington metro area has seen employment growth of 0.51% year-over-year and weekly hours 0.186% above its own 12-month trend. This combination signals genuine demand expansion, as both jobs and hours worked are increasing, indicating a strong and growing labor market. The labor demand composite score of 5.20 is at the 64th percentile, further reinforcing the notion of a robust labor market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington is 3.80%, ranking at the 46th percentile, indicating a near-median level of unemployment. This suggests that the labor market has some slack, making it relatively easier for businesses to hire compared to tighter markets. However, this also means that local consumer demand may not be as strong as in areas with lower unemployment rates.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington is 2.44%, which is below average, ranking at the 34th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate implies that labor costs for employers are increasing, but at a slower pace, and worker purchasing power is growing, albeit not as quickly as in other metros. This could be seen as a relatively stable cost environment for businesses.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of \$203/sqft to \$37.61/hr, and a year-over-year decrease of 1.9% in PSF, Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington is highly affordable, ranking at the 84th percentile. This means that the city has a significant talent attraction advantage, as workers can afford a higher quality of life without requiring wage premiums. The falling PSF relative to wages is a key driver of this high affordability score.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington has grown by 0.41% year-over-year, ranking at the 76th percentile, indicating an expanding workforce supply. This positive growth rate suggests that the labor pool is increasing, providing a favorable environment for hiring and business expansion.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is -4.95%, ranking at the 44th percentile, indicating a tightening housing supply. This decline in permits suggests that future affordability and workforce accommodation may be at risk, as the supply of new housing is not keeping pace with demand.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 48 days, with a year-over-year increase of 6.7%, ranking at the 68th percentile. This indicates a relatively slower market, making it more accessible for workers relocating to the city, as they have more time to find a home. However, this also suggests a normalization of the market, rather than a highly competitive environment.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington is ranked at the 96th percentile, indicating a very deep talent pool suited for tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions. This city is well-suited for businesses requiring specialized knowledge-economy roles, but may be less ideal for those with more industrial or logistics-dominant needs.

In conclusion, Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington offers businesses a strong labor market with genuine demand expansion, a highly affordable cost of living, and a deep professional talent pool. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the tightening housing supply, which may impact future affordability and workforce accommodation, potentially limiting the city's ability to attract and retain talent in the long term.

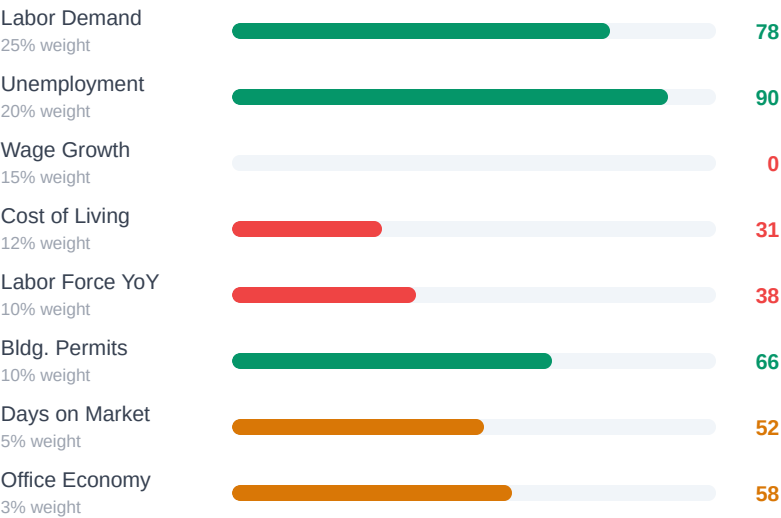
Birmingham

Birmingham

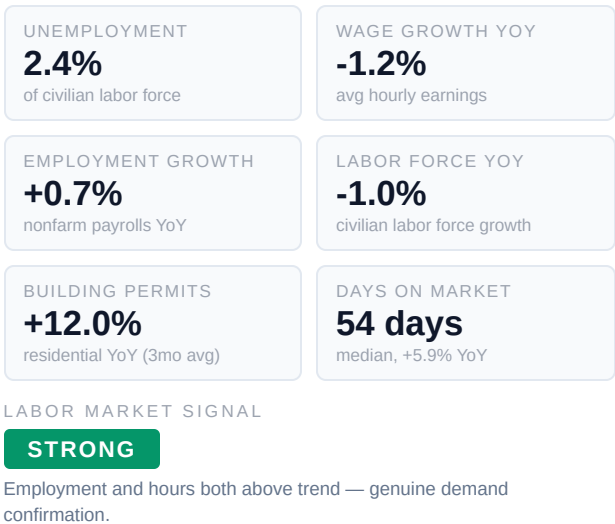
B+

ABOVE AVERAGE
55.9th percentile
Rank 13 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Birmingham has earned an overall grade of B+ with a composite score ranking it at the 55.9th percentile among 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with a composite score at the 78th percentile, and its low unemployment rate, at 2.40% and ranked at the 90th percentile. These metrics suggest a city with a tight labor market and genuine demand expansion.

Labor Demand

Birmingham's employment growth rate is +0.66% year-over-year, combined with a +0.680% deviation in weekly hours from its own 12-month trend. This combination signals genuine demand expansion, as hours are running above trend during a period of job growth. The labor demand composite score of 5.90 further supports this interpretation, indicating a strong and growing labor market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Birmingham is 2.40%, ranking at the 90th percentile and indicating a very tight labor market. This means that businesses trying to hire in this city will face significant competition for talent and may need to offer higher wages to attract workers. The low unemployment rate suggests that the labor market has little slack, making it challenging for companies to find and hire qualified employees.

Wage Growth

Wage growth in Birmingham is -1.22% year-over-year, indicating stagnant or even declining wages. This slow wage growth will keep labor costs flat for employers, but it also means that workers will have weak bargaining power and limited purchasing power. The implication for businesses is a stable cost environment, but one that may not be attractive to workers seeking better compensation.

Cost of Living

Birmingham has a cost of living score at the 31st percentile, with a price-to-salary ratio of \$161/sqft to \$32.72/hr, or 4.92. This indicates that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers. The stable year-over-year change in PSF (+0.0% YoY) does not suggest any significant improvement in affordability. As a result, businesses may need to offer wage premiums to attract talent to this city, as its cost of living is not particularly competitive.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Birmingham is shrinking at a rate of -1.03% year-over-year. This contraction in labor force supply will create a structural headwind for hiring, making it even more challenging for businesses to find qualified workers in an already tight labor market. The implication is that companies may need to invest in training and development programs to build the talent they need.

Building Permits

Residential building permits in Birmingham are increasing at a rate of +12.01% year-over-year. This expansion in housing supply is a positive signal for future affordability and workforce accommodation, suggesting that the city may become more attractive to workers and businesses in the long term. The growing supply of housing will help to mitigate some of the pressure on the labor market and cost of living.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Birmingham is 54 days, with a year-over-year increase of +5.9%. This suggests a relatively balanced market, neither extremely competitive nor extremely slow. For workers relocating to this city, the housing market is accessible, but not overly favorable to buyers. The rising DOM indicates a healthy normalization of the market, rather than a demand erosion.

Office Economy

Birmingham's professional and office worker share is at the 58th percentile, indicating a moderately deep talent pool. This city is best suited for businesses that can thrive in a mixed economy with a moderate presence of professional and office sectors. It may not be the ideal location for businesses requiring a highly specialized or abundant tech/finance/consulting talent pool, but it can support a variety of industries with its diverse workforce.

In conclusion, Birmingham offers businesses a strong labor demand and a tight labor market, but also presents challenges such as slow wage growth and a relatively high cost of living. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the shrinking labor force supply, which will require businesses to adapt their hiring and talent development strategies to succeed in this market. Despite these challenges, the city's expanding housing supply and balanced housing market are positive signals for its long-term attractiveness to workers and businesses.

San Diego

San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad

B

AVERAGE

54.7th percentile

Rank 14 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand		70
25% weight		
Unemployment		50
20% weight		
Wage Growth		90
15% weight		
Cost of Living		12
12% weight		
Labor Force YoY		22
10% weight		
Bldg. Permits		50
10% weight		
Days on Market		56
5% weight		
Office Economy		74
3% weight		

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT 4.1% of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY +6.8% avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH +0.6% nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY -1.5% civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS +0.2% residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET 39 days median, +2.6% YoY
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL STRONG Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking in the 54.7th percentile among 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its strong labor demand and high wage growth, at 70th and 90th percentiles, respectively. The city's economic character is defined by these two metrics, with employment growth at 0.64% year-over-year and weekly hours 0.303% above trend. This combination signals genuine demand expansion, with jobs being added and hours increasing.

Labor Demand

The San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad metro area has an employment growth rate of 0.64% year-over-year and weekly hours 0.303% above trend, indicating a strong labor market with genuine demand expansion. This combination signals that the city is experiencing an increase in jobs and working hours, which is a positive indicator for businesses looking to expand or relocate. The labor demand composite score of 5.50 places the city in the 70th percentile, above average.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad is 4.10%, which is near the median, ranking in the 50th percentile. This indicates a relatively balanced labor market, neither too tight nor too slack, which means businesses may face moderate competition for talent. With an unemployment rate at this level, businesses can expect to find qualified candidates, but may still need to offer competitive wages and benefits to attract top talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad is 6.85%, placing the city in the 90th percentile, indicating fast and rising labor costs for employers. This strong wage growth is good for worker purchasing power, as employees will have more disposable income to spend on goods and services. However, for businesses, this means that labor costs will be increasing, which could impact profitability.

Cost of Living

San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad has a cost of living ratio of \$604/sqft to \$43.04/hr, with a percentile rank of 12th, indicating that the city is relatively expensive. The PSF has decreased by 4.0% year-over-year, but the city still ranks as one of the more expensive places to live. This means that businesses may need to offer wage premiums to attract and retain talent, as the high cost of living could be a deterrent for some employees.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad has contracted by 1.52% year-over-year, ranking in the 22nd percentile, indicating a shrinking labor pool. This contraction in the labor force supply means that businesses may face structural headwinds when trying to hire, as there may be fewer qualified candidates available. This could lead to increased competition for talent and upward pressure on wages.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits in San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad is 0.17%, ranking in the 50th percentile, indicating a relatively stable housing market. This slow growth in building permits suggests that the housing supply is not expanding rapidly, which could lead to future affordability issues and constraints on workforce accommodation. However, the current pace of permit issuance is not indicative of a severe supply squeeze.

Days on Market

The median days on market in San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad is 39 days, with a year-over-year increase of 2.6%, ranking in the 56th percentile. This indicates a relatively balanced housing market, neither too hot nor too cold, which means that workers relocating to the city may face a moderately competitive market. The rising days on market suggests a healthy normalization of the housing market, rather than a demand erosion.

Office Economy

San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad has a deep professional talent pool, with an office/professional worker share of 3.28, ranking in the 74th percentile. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, which require a high concentration of specialized knowledge workers. However, the city may be less suitable for businesses in industrial or logistics-dominant sectors, which require a different type of workforce.

The San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad metro area offers businesses a strong labor market with genuine demand expansion and high wage growth, making it an attractive location for companies in the professional services sector. However, the city's high cost of living and shrinking labor force supply are significant constraints that businesses should factor into their decision-making, as they may need to offer wage premiums to attract and retain talent.

San Francisco

San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont

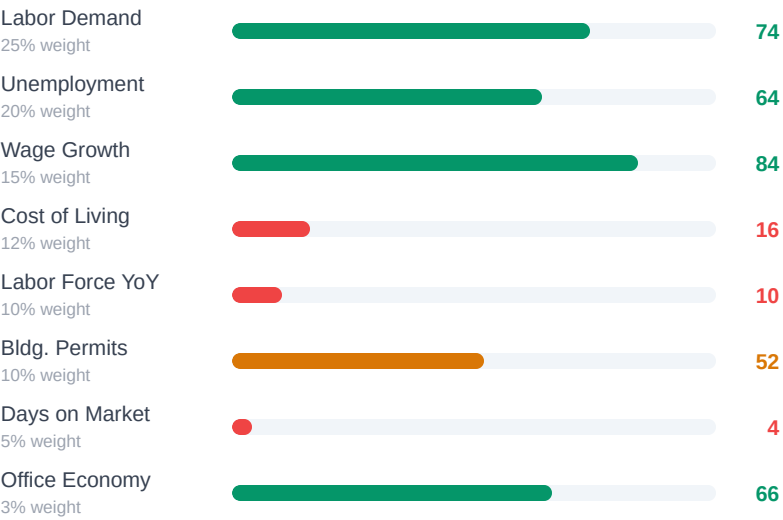
B

AVERAGE

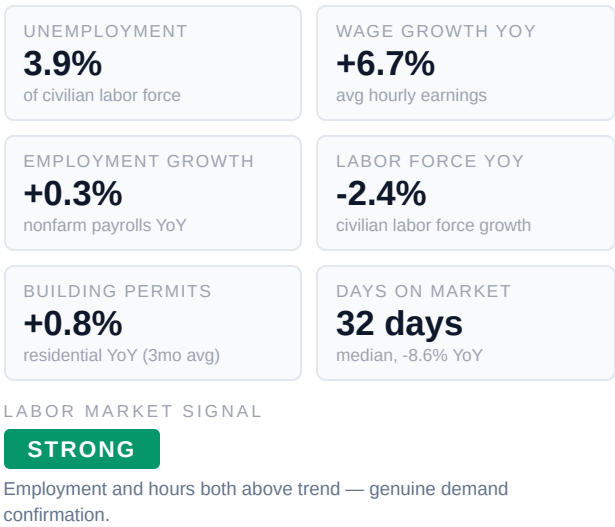
54.2th percentile

Rank 15 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking in the 54.2th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its strong labor demand and high wage growth, at 74th and 84th percentiles, respectively. The city's economic character is defined by these two metrics, with employment growth at +0.34% year-over-year and weekly hours 1.065% above trend. This combination signals genuine demand expansion, with jobs being added and hours worked above the city's own 12-month baseline.

Labor Demand

The San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont metro area has an employment growth rate of +0.34% year-over-year and weekly hours 1.065% above trend, indicating genuine demand expansion. This signals that the city is experiencing an increase in jobs and hours worked, which is a positive indicator for businesses looking to locate in the area. The combination of these two metrics suggests that the city's labor market is strong and growing.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in the San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont metro area is 3.90%, which is relatively low and indicates a tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring and retaining workers, as the pool of available labor is limited. As a result, businesses may need to offer competitive wages and benefits to attract and retain top talent.

Wage Growth

The San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont metro area has experienced wage growth of +6.70% year-over-year, which is relatively high and indicates a strong labor market. This rapid wage growth may lead to increased labor costs for employers, but it also means that workers have more purchasing power and are likely to be more productive. As a result, businesses may need to factor in higher labor costs when considering locating in the area.

Cost of Living

The San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont metro area has a cost of living score that ranks in the 16th percentile, with a price-to-salary ratio of \$664/sqft to \$50.65/hr, or 13.11. This indicates that the city is relatively expensive, which may make it difficult for businesses to attract talent without offering wage premiums. However, the fact that the price per square foot is falling by 3.5% year-over-year may help to improve affordability in the future.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in the San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont metro area has contracted by -2.44% year-over-year, indicating a shrinking labor pool. This may create structural headwinds for hiring, as the supply of available workers is decreasing. As a result, businesses may need to consider alternative locations or strategies for attracting and retaining talent.

Building Permits

The San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont metro area has experienced a +0.83% year-over-year increase in residential building permits, which is near the median. This suggests that housing supply is expanding, but at a moderate pace. As a result, the city's affordability and workforce accommodation may improve in the future, but it is unlikely to have a significant impact in the short term.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in the San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont metro area is currently 32 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -8.6%. This indicates a relatively fast-paced market, which may make it challenging for relocating workers to find housing. However, the fact that the market is slowing down slightly may help to create a more balanced environment for buyers and sellers.

Office Economy

The San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont metro area has a deep professional talent pool, with an office economy score that ranks in the 66th percentile. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, and consulting sectors, which require a high concentration of specialized workers. However, the city may be less suitable for businesses in industries that require a large workforce or have significant logistics requirements.

The San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont metro area offers businesses a strong labor market with high demand and rapid wage growth, but it also presents challenges such as a tight labor market and high cost of living. The single biggest risk or constraint for businesses considering locating in the area is the shrinking labor pool, which may create structural headwinds for hiring and require alternative strategies for attracting and retaining talent. Overall, businesses must carefully weigh the benefits and drawbacks of locating in the San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont metro area and consider factors such as labor costs, talent attraction, and housing affordability when making their decision.

Seattle

Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue

B

AVERAGE

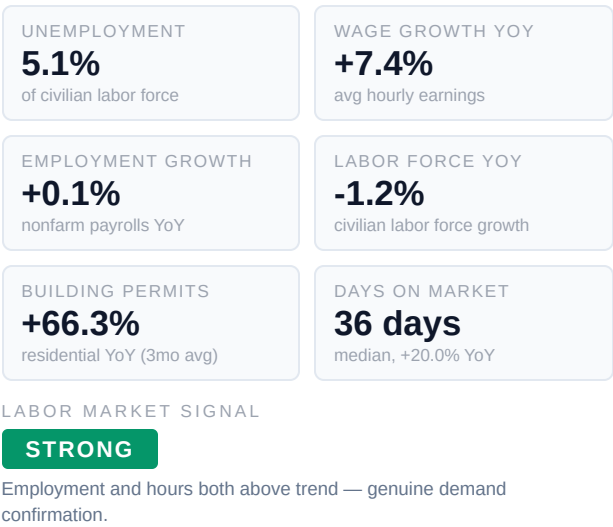
54.1th percentile

Rank 16 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking in the 54.1th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its top-tier wage growth and strong building permits expansion. The city's economic character is most defined by its 7.37% year-over-year wage growth and a 66.30% increase in building permits, signaling a thriving economy with expanding housing supply. These metrics suggest a city with strong labor market dynamics and a growing professional workforce.

Labor Demand

The Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue area has an employment growth rate of 0.08% and weekly hours 0.670% above its own trend, indicating genuine demand expansion as hours are running above trend during a period of job growth. This combination signals that the labor market is experiencing an increase in jobs and working hours, suggesting a healthy and growing economy. The labor demand composite score of 5.08 further supports this, ranking in the 60th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue is 5.10%, ranking in the bottom tier at the 2nd percentile, which means the market is extremely tight with very low unemployment. This tight labor market implies that businesses may face challenges in hiring, with more wage pressure as workers have greater bargaining power. The low unemployment rate suggests that the city's labor market has little slack, making it harder for companies to find and recruit talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue is 7.37%, ranking in the top tier at the 96th percentile, indicating fast and rising labor costs for employers. This strong wage growth is good for worker purchasing power, as employees see significant increases in their earnings. However, for employers, this means a rapidly changing cost environment that may impact profitability and competitiveness.

Cost of Living

Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue has a cost of living score with a PSF of \$452/sqft, which has decreased by 3.6% year-over-year, compared to average hourly earnings of \$47.57/hr, resulting in a ratio of 9.50, ranking in the 41st percentile. This suggests that the city is near the median in terms of affordability, neither extremely expensive nor highly affordable compared to its peers. The decreasing PSF relative to wages is a positive sign for talent attraction, as it may not require significant wage premiums to compensate for the cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue has contracted by 1.17% year-over-year, ranking in the 30th percentile, indicating a shrinking labor pool. This contraction implies a structural headwind for hiring, as the supply of potential workers is decreasing, which could

exacerbate the challenges of finding talent in an already tight labor market.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue has increased by 66.30% year-over-year, ranking in the top tier at the 90th percentile, signaling a significant expansion in housing supply. This rapid growth in permits suggests that developer confidence is high, and future housing supply is expected to increase, which could improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue is 36 days, with a year-over-year increase of 20.0%, ranking in the top tier at the 98th percentile. This indicates a slower market where homes are sitting longer before being sold, which could be beneficial for relocating workers as it provides a more accessible and less competitive housing market.

Office Economy

Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue has a deep professional talent pool, with an office/professional worker share composite score ranking in the top tier at the 84th percentile. This suggests that the city is well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors that require a knowledgeable and specialized workforce. However, it may be less suited for industries that are more industrial or logistics-dominant.

The Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue metro area offers businesses a unique combination of strong wage growth, expanding housing supply, and a deep professional talent pool, making it an attractive location for companies in the knowledge economy. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the extremely tight labor market, which may pose significant challenges in hiring and retaining talent, necessitating strategic planning and potentially higher wage offerings to compete in this market.

Philadelphia

Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington

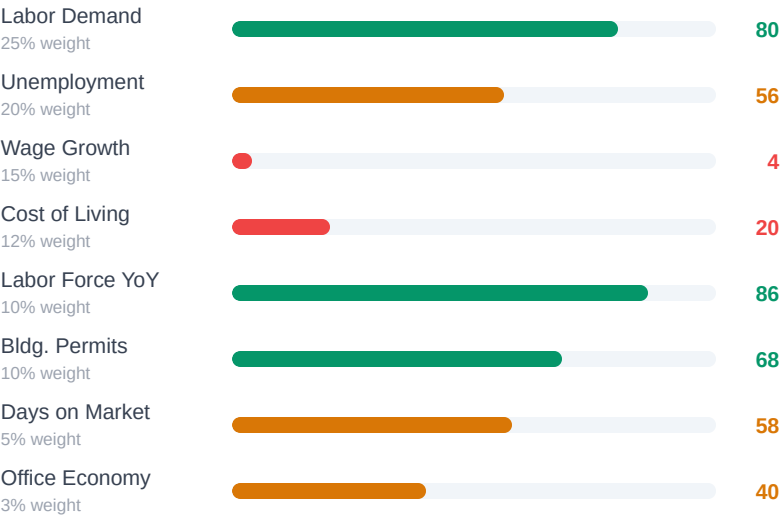
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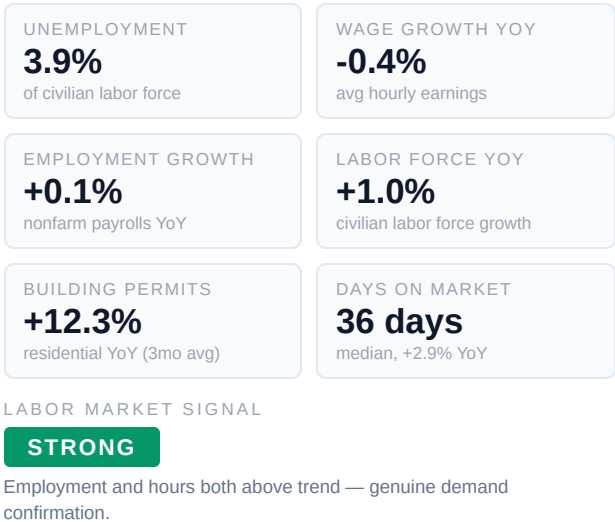
53.7th percentile

Rank 17 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking in the 53.7th percentile among 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its strong labor demand and labor force growth, scoring in the 80th and 86th percentiles, respectively. The city's labor demand composite score of 5.92, combining a +0.12% employment growth rate and a +1.451% weekly hours deviation from its own trend, signals genuine demand expansion. This is further supported by a labor force growth rate of +1.02% year-over-year.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of +0.12% and weekly hours deviation of +1.451% from its own trend indicate a genuine demand expansion in the labor market. This combination suggests that the city is experiencing an increase in jobs and hours worked, signaling a strong labor market. The labor demand composite score of 5.92 reinforces this, placing the city in the top tier for labor demand.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 3.90% places the city near the median in terms of labor market tightness, ranking in the 56th percentile. This rate suggests that while the market is not extremely tight, it still presents some challenges for businesses looking to hire, as there is a moderate level of competition for available workers. However, it does not indicate an overly competitive market that would significantly drive up wages.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of -0.37% is in the bottom tier, ranking in the 4th percentile, indicating stagnant wage growth. This slow wage growth environment suggests that labor costs for employers are not increasing rapidly, but it also means that worker purchasing power is not growing significantly. For businesses, this could mean a relatively stable labor cost environment but may also reflect weaker bargaining power for workers.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of \$233/sqft to \$32.82/hr, resulting in a ratio of 7.10, and ranking in the 20th percentile, the city is less affordable compared to its peers. The fact that the PSF is not falling year-over-year (with a +0.0% change) does not help improve affordability. This relatively low affordability score may require businesses to offer wage premiums to attract talent, as the city's cost of living is above average.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is growing at a rate of +1.02% year-over-year, indicating an expanding workforce supply. This positive growth rate suggests that the city has a structural advantage in terms of hiring capacity, as the pool of potential workers is increasing. This can be

beneficial for businesses looking to expand or establish operations in the area.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is +12.30%, indicating an expansion in housing supply. This increase in building permits suggests that developer confidence is strong, and the future housing supply is likely to improve, which could lead to better affordability and easier accommodation for the workforce. This is a positive signal for future workforce attraction and retention.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 36 days, with a year-over-year increase of +2.9%. This indicates a slightly slower market than in the previous year. For workers relocating to this city, the market is still relatively competitive but not overly challenging, suggesting a balanced environment for homebuyers and sellers.

Office Economy

The share of jobs in professional and office sectors, with a composite score of 2.38, places the city in the near median range, ranking in the 40th percentile. This suggests a moderately deep talent pool suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, but it may not be as competitive as cities with a higher concentration of these industries. The city is less suited for industries that require a large, specialized workforce outside of these sectors.

The Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington metro area offers businesses a strong labor demand and growing labor force, which are significant advantages for companies looking to expand or relocate. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's relatively low affordability and stagnant wage growth, which may require wage premiums to attract and retain talent, potentially increasing labor costs over time.

Tampa

Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater

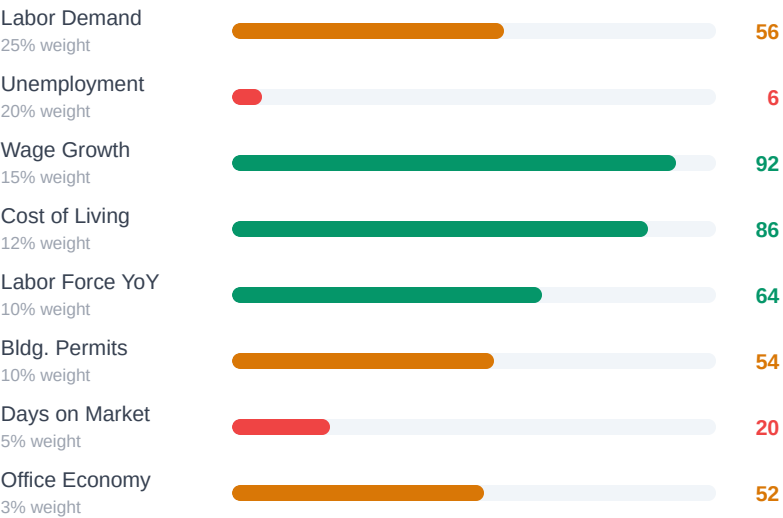
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AVERAGE

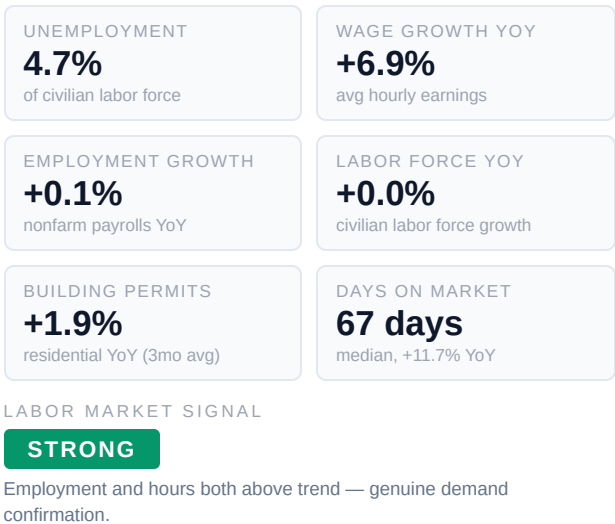
53.6th percentile

Rank 18 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking 53.6th percentile among 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its strong wage growth and affordable cost of living. The city's economic character is defined by a wage growth rate of +6.90% YoY and a cost of living ratio of \$241/sqft to \$37.36/hr, resulting in a top-tier affordability score. These metrics suggest a city with a competitive labor market and attractive living costs.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate is +0.12% YoY, combined with a +0.409% deviation in weekly hours from the city's own trend, signaling a genuine demand expansion. This combination indicates that the city is experiencing modest job growth, with hours worked above the trend, suggesting that businesses are increasing their workforce and workload. The labor demand composite score of 4.88 places the city near the median, indicating a stable but not exceptionally strong labor market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate is 4.70%, ranking in the bottom tier at the 6th percentile, indicating a tight labor market with limited slack. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is relatively small, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent. The low unemployment rate also suggests that workers may have more bargaining power.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate is +6.90%, placing the city in the top tier at the 92nd percentile, indicating fast and rising labor costs for employers. This strong wage growth is good for worker purchasing power, as employees can afford more goods and services, but it may pose challenges for businesses trying to control labor costs. The rapid wage growth suggests a competitive labor market where businesses must offer attractive compensation packages to retain and attract talent.

Cost of Living

The city has a cost of living ratio of \$241/sqft to \$37.36/hr, with a top-tier affordability score of 86th percentile, indicating that it is more affordable relative to peers. The fact that PSF is falling by -3.2% YoY suggests that housing costs are becoming more manageable, making the city an attractive location for talent without requiring significant wage premiums. This affordability advantage can be a major draw for businesses looking to relocate or expand.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is growing at a rate of +0.02% YoY, placing the city above average at the 64th percentile, indicating a slowly expanding workforce supply. This modest growth suggests that the city's labor pool is increasing, but at a slow pace, which may not keep

up with demand from growing businesses. The implication is that hiring capacity may be limited, and businesses may need to invest in training and development to attract and retain talent.

Building Permits

The city is experiencing a +1.87% YoY increase in residential building permits, placing it near the median at the 54th percentile, indicating a modest expansion of housing supply. This growth suggests that developer confidence is present, and future housing supply is likely to increase, which can improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce. However, the moderate pace of growth may not be enough to meet demand, potentially leading to future affordability challenges.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 67 days, with a +11.7% YoY increase, placing the city below average at the 20th percentile, indicating a relatively fast-paced market. This means that homes are selling quickly, making it challenging for relocating workers to find housing, and potentially driving up prices. The rising DOM suggests a competitive market, but the relatively low absolute level of days on market indicates that the city's housing market is still relatively accessible.

Office Economy

The city has an office economy percentile rank of 52nd, indicating a near-median depth of professional talent pool, suited for a mix of industries, but not exceptionally strong in tech, finance, or consulting. The city's economy is likely to be more diverse, with a mix of industrial, logistics, and office sectors, making it a good fit for businesses that require a broad range of skills and talents.

The Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater metro area offers businesses a competitive labor market, attractive living costs, and a growing workforce, making it an appealing location for relocation or expansion. However, the single biggest risk or constraint is the tight labor market, which may pose challenges for hiring and retaining talent, and the moderate pace of housing supply growth, which may lead to future affordability challenges.

Los Angeles

Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim

B

AVERAGE

53.3th percentile

Rank 19 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand 25% weight		86
Unemployment 20% weight		28
Wage Growth 15% weight		60
Cost of Living 12% weight		6
Labor Force YoY 10% weight		20
Bldg. Permits 10% weight		96
Days on Market 5% weight		62
Office Economy 3% weight		60

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT 4.8% of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY +4.8% avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH +1.8% nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY -1.6% civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS +80.0% residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET 47 days median, +4.4% YoY
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL GROWING Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking in the 53.3th percentile among 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its top-tier labor demand and building permits growth. The city's economic character is defined by its strong employment growth of 1.83% year-over-year and a labor demand composite score of 6.14, which ranks in the 86th percentile. Additionally, the significant increase in building permits, up 79.98% year-over-year, suggests a robust expansion in housing supply.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of 1.83% year-over-year, combined with a weekly hours deviation of -0.727% from the city's own trend, signals a genuine demand expansion, as jobs are being added and hours are running above trend. This indicates a strong labor market where businesses are likely to find a talented and engaged workforce. The labor demand composite score of 6.14 further reinforces this assessment, ranking in the top tier at the 86th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim stands at 4.80%, which ranks in the 28th percentile, indicating a market with some slack. This means that businesses may find it slightly easier to hire in this market compared to tighter labor markets, although wage pressure might be somewhat mitigated. However, the relatively higher unemployment rate compared to other metros could also suggest weaker local consumer demand.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of 4.84% is above average, ranking in the 60th percentile. This signifies moderate to fast wage growth, which implies rising labor costs for employers but also stronger purchasing power for workers. As wages continue to rise, businesses may need to adjust their compensation packages to remain competitive in the market.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of \$667/sqft to \$41.74/hr, resulting in a ratio of 15.98, and a percentile rank of 6th, Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim is relatively expensive. The PSF has decreased by 3.0% year-over-year, but the city remains in the bottom tier for affordability. This suggests that attracting talent without offering wage premiums could be challenging due to the high cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force has contracted by -1.55% year-over-year, indicating a shrinking labor pool. This contraction implies a structural headwind for hiring, as the supply of potential workers is decreasing. Businesses may face challenges in finding the right talent in a market where the labor force is not expanding.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits is up 79.98%, signaling a significant expansion in housing supply. This increase suggests that developer confidence is high, and future housing supply is likely to improve, which could lead to better affordability and easier workforce accommodation in the long term.

Days on Market

Homes are currently sitting on the market for a median of 47 days, with a year-over-year increase of 4.4%. This indicates a slightly slower market, ranking in the 62nd percentile. For workers relocating to this city, the market might be considered relatively accessible, as homes are not selling as quickly as in hotter markets.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers is 2.96, with the city ranking in the 60th percentile for its office economy. This suggests a deep enough talent pool for businesses in tech, finance, consulting, and HQ operations, making Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim a suitable location for knowledge-economy businesses. However, it might be less ideal for industries dominated by industrial or logistics roles.

In conclusion, Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim offers businesses a strong labor demand environment and a significant expansion in housing supply, which could improve affordability and workforce accommodation. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's relatively high cost of living and shrinking labor force, which could make talent attraction and hiring more challenging without appropriate compensation strategies.

New York

New York Newark-Jersey City

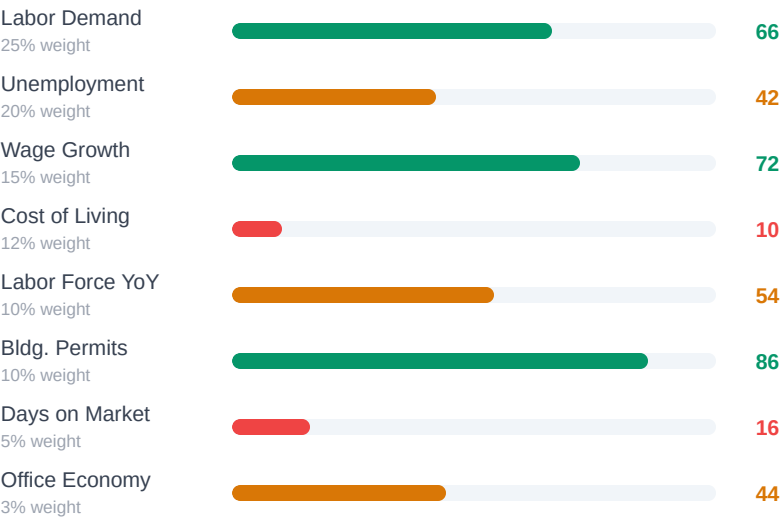
B

AVERAGE

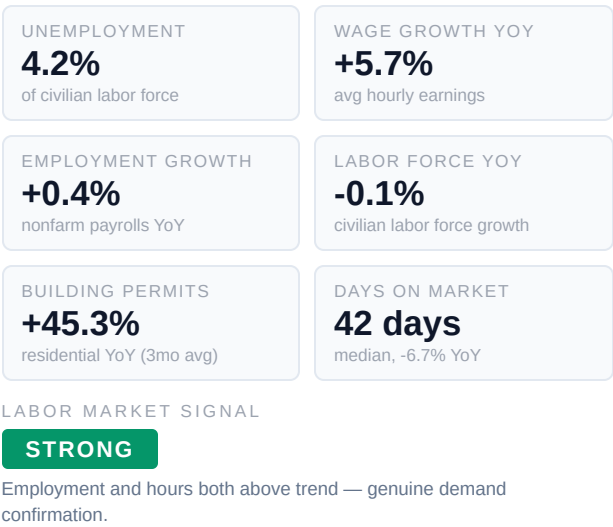
53.0th percentile

Rank 20 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The New York Newark-Jersey City metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking in the 53.0th percentile among 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its above-average labor demand and strong wage growth, at 66th and 72nd percentiles, respectively. The city's labor market is characterized by a 0.39% year-over-year employment growth rate and a 0.456% deviation in weekly hours above its own trend. These metrics suggest a city with genuine demand expansion, as both jobs and hours worked are increasing.

Labor Demand

The New York Newark-Jersey City metro area has a labor demand composite score of 5.30, driven by a 0.39% year-over-year employment growth rate and a 0.456% deviation in weekly hours above its own trend. This combination signals genuine demand expansion, as both jobs and hours worked are increasing, indicating a strong labor market. The 66th percentile rank for labor demand suggests that the city is outperforming most of its peers in terms of job creation and labor utilization.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in the New York Newark-Jersey City metro area is 4.20%, ranking in the 42nd percentile, indicating a near-median level of unemployment. This suggests that the labor market has some slack, making it slightly easier for businesses to hire compared to cities with tighter labor markets. However, the relatively low unemployment rate still implies some competition for talent, and businesses may need to offer competitive wages to attract the best candidates.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in the New York Newark-Jersey City metro area is 5.68%, ranking in the 72nd percentile, indicating strong wage growth. This suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but worker purchasing power is also increasing, which can be beneficial for businesses that rely on local consumer demand. The fast wage growth may require businesses to adjust their compensation packages to remain competitive.

Cost of Living

The cost of living in the New York Newark-Jersey City metro area is relatively high, with a PSF of \$532/sqft and an earnings ratio of 12.94, ranking in the 10th percentile. This means that the city is one of the more expensive places to live, which can make it challenging to attract talent without offering wage premiums. The -0.2% year-over-year change in PSF suggests that housing costs are not rising as quickly as wages, but the city's affordability remains a concern.

Labor Force Growth

The labor force in the New York Newark-Jersey City metro area is growing at a rate of -0.14% year-over-year, ranking in the 54th percentile, indicating a near-median level of labor force growth. This suggests that the supply of workers is not expanding rapidly, which can create structural headwinds for hiring. Businesses may need to invest in training and development programs to attract and retain talent in this market.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in the New York Newark-Jersey City metro area is increasing by 45.32% year-over-year, ranking in the 86th percentile, indicating a rapid expansion of housing supply. This suggests that developer confidence is high, and the future housing supply is expected to increase, which can improve affordability and make it easier for workers to relocate to the area.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in the New York Newark-Jersey City metro area is 42 days, with a year-over-year change of -6.7%, ranking in the 16th percentile. This indicates a fast-paced housing market, where homes are selling quickly, making it challenging for relocating workers to find affordable housing. The low percentile rank suggests that the market is highly competitive, and businesses may need to offer relocation assistance to attract talent.

Office Economy

The New York Newark-Jersey City metro area has a professional and office worker share of 2.40, ranking in the 44th percentile, indicating a near-median level of depth in the professional talent pool. This suggests that the city is suited for businesses that require a mix of office and industrial workers, but may not be the best fit for companies that rely heavily on specialized professional services.

The New York Newark-Jersey City metro area offers businesses a strong labor market with genuine demand expansion and strong wage growth, but also presents challenges such as a high cost of living and a competitive housing market. The single biggest risk or constraint for businesses considering this location is the affordability of housing and the potential need to offer wage premiums to attract and retain talent.

San Jose

San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara

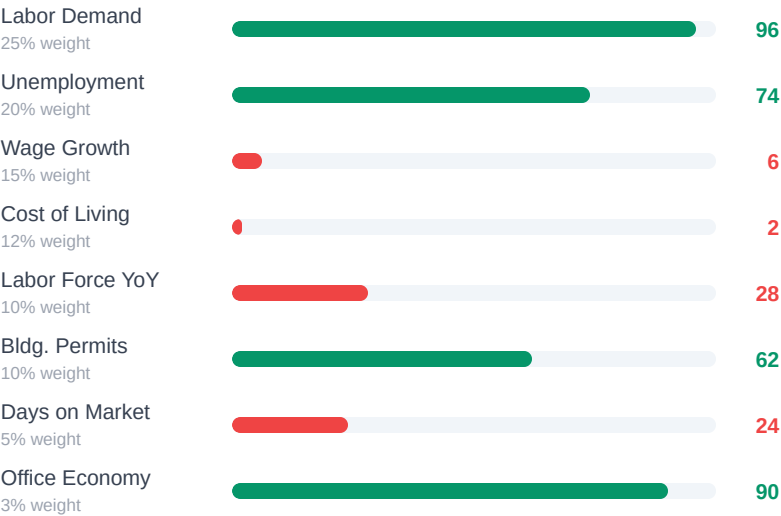
B

AVERAGE

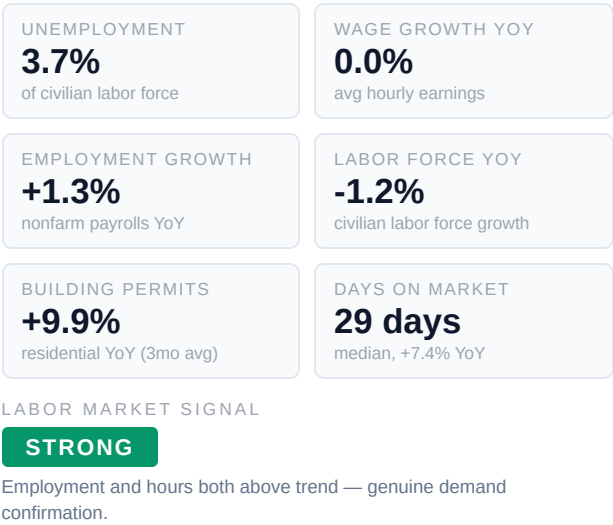
52.8th percentile

Rank 21 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking in the 52.8th percentile among 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its exceptional labor demand and deep office economy. The city's labor demand composite score of 7.35, combining a 1.32% employment growth rate and a 1.205% weekly hours deviation above trend, signals a genuine demand expansion. This, coupled with its high share of professional and office workers, defines the city's current economic character.

Labor Demand

The San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area exhibits a strong labor demand, with a 1.32% employment growth rate and weekly hours 1.205% above its own 12-month trend. This combination signals a genuine demand expansion, indicating that the city is adding jobs and workers are putting in more hours, a sign of a thriving economy. The labor demand composite score of 7.35 places the city in the top tier, at the 96th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara stands at 3.70%, which is relatively low and places the city at the 74th percentile. This tight labor market implies that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is smaller, potentially leading to upward pressure on wages. However, it also suggests a strong local economy with high demand for labor.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in the San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area is 0.00%, indicating stagnant wages. This slow wage growth environment means that labor costs for employers are not increasing, but it also signifies weak bargaining power for workers and potentially less purchasing power. The 6th percentile rank in wage growth highlights the city's challenge in this area.

Cost of Living

San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara has a cost of living score that places it in the bottom tier, at the 2nd percentile, due to its high price per square foot of \$844 and a ratio of PSF to hourly earnings of 15.59. Although the PSF is decreasing by 3.0% year-over-year, the city remains expensive relative to wages. This expense could hinder talent attraction, as businesses may need to offer wage premiums to offset the high cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara is shrinking at a rate of -1.19% year-over-year, indicating a contracting labor supply. This decline suggests that the city may face structural headwinds in hiring, as the pool of potential workers is decreasing. The 28th percentile rank in labor force growth underscores the challenge of finding and retaining talent in this market.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara has increased by 9.92% year-over-year, signaling an expansion in housing supply. This growth in permits suggests that developer confidence is strong, and the future housing supply is likely to improve, which could enhance affordability and make the city more attractive for workforce accommodation. The 62nd percentile rank in building permits growth indicates a positive trend for future affordability.

Days on Market

Homes in San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara are currently sitting on the market for a median of 29 days, with a year-over-year increase of 7.4%. This indicates a slightly slower market, which could make it more accessible for relocating workers to find housing. However, the 24th percentile rank suggests that the market remains competitive, and workers may still face challenges in finding suitable housing quickly.

Office Economy

The San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area has a deep professional and office worker talent pool, ranking at the 90th percentile. This makes the city highly suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors that require specialized knowledge-economy talent. Conversely, it may be less ideal for industries dominated by industrial or logistics roles.

The San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area offers businesses a unique combination of strong labor demand and a deep talent pool in professional and office sectors, making it an attractive location for certain industries. However, the city's high cost of living and stagnant wage growth pose significant challenges, particularly in terms of talent attraction and retention, which decision-makers must carefully consider when evaluating this location for their business operations.

Houston

Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands

B

AVERAGE

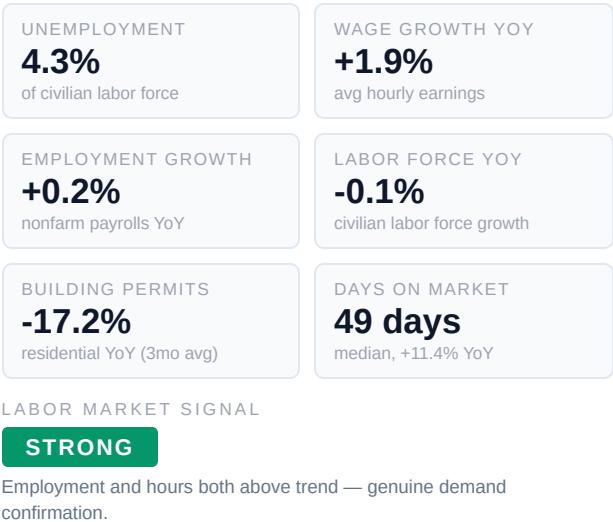
52.3th percentile

Rank 22 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking 52.3th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its above-average labor demand and highly affordable cost of living, as evidenced by a 96th percentile cost of living score. The city's labor demand composite score of 5.18, combining a +0.22% employment growth rate and a +0.569% weekly hours deviation from trend, suggests genuine demand expansion. Additionally, the cost of living, with a PSF of \$173/sqft and a -2.3% YoY change, versus \$36.90/hr, presents a favorable ratio of 4.69.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of +0.22% and weekly hours deviation of +0.569% from the city's own trend indicate genuine demand expansion, as hours are running above trend during a period of job growth. This combination signals a healthy labor market where businesses are adding jobs and workers are putting in more hours, suggesting strong economic activity. The labor demand composite score of 5.18 further reinforces this interpretation, placing the city in the 62nd percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 4.30% is below average, ranking in the 30th percentile, which means the labor market has some slack but is not overly loose. This rate implies that while it may not be extremely difficult to hire, there is still a manageable pool of potential employees, and businesses may face some competition for talent. However, the relatively low unemployment rate suggests that wage pressure might be moderate.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of +1.85% is below average, ranking in the 26th percentile, indicating moderate to slow wage growth. This suggests that labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly, which could be beneficial for businesses looking to control expenses. However, for workers, this means their purchasing power is not increasing as quickly as in other metros.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living score in the 96th percentile, Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands is highly affordable relative to its peers, thanks to a PSF of \$173/sqft that is decreasing by -2.3% YoY, compared to hourly earnings of \$36.90. This affordability is a significant talent attraction advantage, as businesses can recruit without needing to offer substantial wage premiums to offset high living costs.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is growing at a rate of -0.05% year-over-year, which is near the median, ranking in the 58th percentile. This slight contraction in labor force supply suggests a potential structural headwind for hiring, as the pool of available workers is not expanding.

Businesses may need to compete more intensely for a smaller pool of new entrants into the workforce.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is -17.22%, indicating a tightening in housing supply. This sharp decline suggests that future affordability and workforce accommodation might be at risk, as the supply of new housing units is not keeping pace with demand. This could lead to increased housing costs and reduced attractiveness for relocating workers.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 49 days, with an 11.4% year-over-year increase, placing it in the 88th percentile. This slower market means that homes are sitting longer before being sold, which could be beneficial for workers relocating to the area, as they have more time to find a suitable home. However, this also indicates a less competitive housing market.

Office Economy

With an office/professional worker share composite score ranking in the 80th percentile, Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands has a deep talent pool suited for tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions. This makes the city an attractive location for businesses in these sectors but less ideal for those in industrial or logistics-dominant economies.

The Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands metro offers businesses a unique combination of affordable living, a deep professional talent pool, and genuine labor demand expansion, making it an attractive location for certain types of businesses. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the tightening housing supply, signaled by a sharp decline in building permits, which could erode the city's affordability advantage and make it less attractive for relocating workers over time.

Orlando

Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford

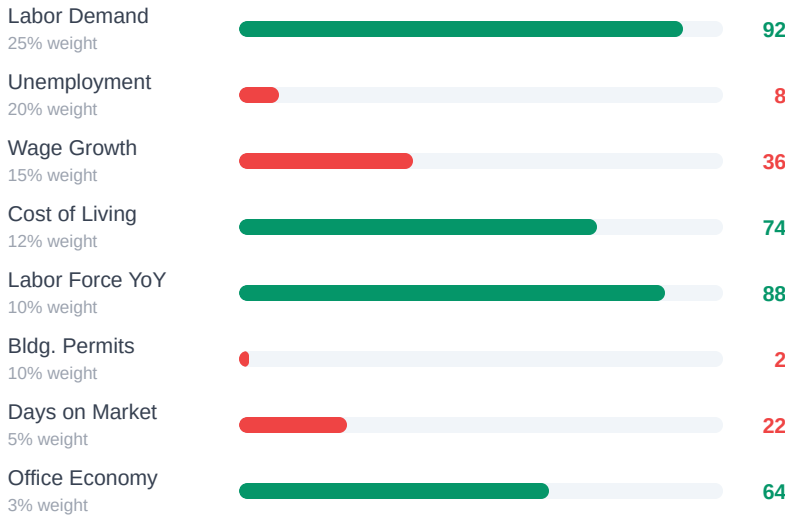
B

AVERAGE

50.8th percentile

Rank 23 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

4.5%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+2.8%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

+1.1%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY

+1.1%

civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS

-40.8%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

70 days

median, +7.7% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking 50.8th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its strong labor demand and labor force growth, which are at 92nd and 88th percentiles, respectively. The city's economic character is defined by its top-tier employment growth rate of 1.08% and weekly hours deviation of +1.057%, indicating genuine demand expansion. With a labor demand composite score of 6.87, the city is experiencing a significant increase in job creation.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of 1.08% and weekly hours deviation of +1.057% signal genuine demand expansion, as hours are running above trend during a period of job growth. This combination indicates that the city is experiencing a strong increase in labor demand, with businesses hiring more workers and existing employees working more hours. The labor demand composite score of 6.87 is in the top tier, at the 92nd percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 4.50% is relatively high, ranking at the 8th percentile, indicating a market with some slack. This means that businesses may find it easier to hire workers, as there is a larger pool of available labor. However, the higher unemployment rate also suggests weaker local consumer demand, which could impact businesses that rely on local spending.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of 2.81% is below average, ranking at the 36th percentile, indicating moderate wage growth. This means that employer labor costs are rising, but at a slower pace, and worker purchasing power is increasing, but not rapidly. The moderate wage growth suggests a relatively stable labor cost environment.

Cost of Living

The city has a cost of living percentile rank of 74th, with a PSF of \$224/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$33.47/hr, resulting in a ratio of 6.69. This indicates that the city is more affordable than many of its peers, with a lower cost of living. The fact that PSF is falling by 3.5% YoY relative to wages suggests that the city is becoming even more affordable, which is a talent attraction advantage.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is growing at a rate of 1.07% year-over-year, ranking at the 88th percentile, indicating an expanding workforce supply. This means that businesses have a growing pool of potential workers to hire from, making it easier to find talent. The positive labor force growth rate is a significant advantage for businesses looking to expand their operations.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits is -40.79%, ranking at the 2nd percentile, indicating a sharp decline in housing supply. This suggests that the city may face a supply squeeze in the future, which could impact affordability and workforce accommodation. The decline in building permits is a concern for businesses that rely on a steady supply of housing for their workers.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 70 days, with a year-over-year increase of 7.7%, ranking at the 22nd percentile. This indicates a slower market, where homes are taking longer to sell. For workers relocating to the city, this means a more accessible and less competitive housing market, making it easier to find a home.

Office Economy

The city has an office economy percentile rank of 64th, with a share of professional and office workers of 2.98. This indicates a deep talent pool in professional and office sectors, making the city well-suited for tech, finance, and consulting businesses. However, the city may be less suited for industrial or logistics-dominant businesses.

The Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford metro area offers businesses a strong labor market with genuine demand expansion and a growing workforce supply. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the sharp decline in building permits, which could lead to a supply squeeze and impact affordability and workforce accommodation in the future.

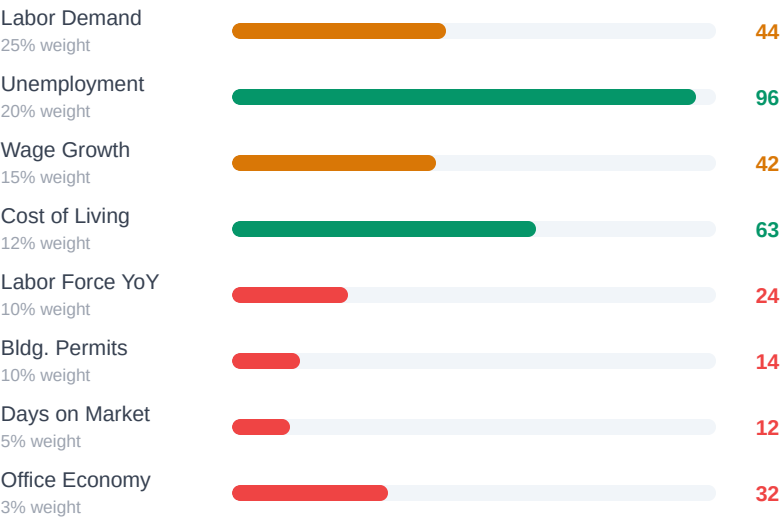
Columbus

Columbus

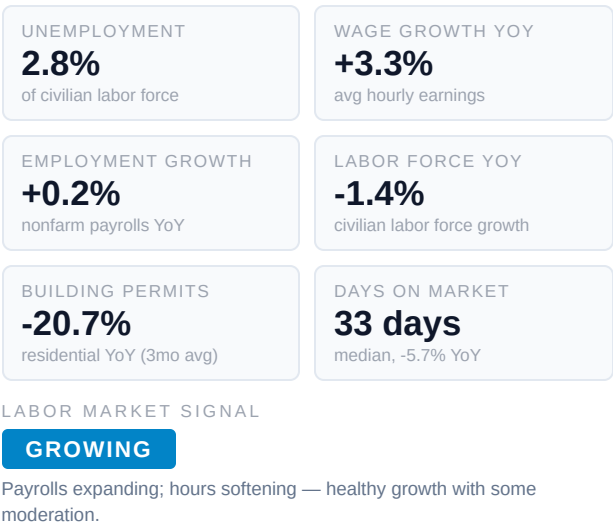
B-

BELOW AVERAGE
49.5th percentile
Rank 24 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Columbus, with an overall grade of B- and a composite score ranking it at the 49.5th percentile among 50 US metros, is characterized by its low unemployment rate of 2.80% and a labor demand composite score of 4.36, which places it near the median. The city's economic character is also defined by its below-average labor force growth and bottom-tier building permits growth. Specifically, the labor demand and unemployment metrics suggest a complex labor market.

Labor Demand

Columbus has an employment growth rate of +0.22% and weekly hours deviation of -0.246% from its own trend, indicating a near-median labor demand composite score. This combination signals a modest expansion in jobs, but with hours worked below trend, suggesting some level of survivor squeeze where remaining workers may be absorbing the load of eliminated roles. This scenario implies that while there is some job growth, the labor market is not as strong as the employment growth rate alone might suggest.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Columbus is 2.80%, ranking it in the top tier at the 96th percentile, indicating a very tight labor market. This low unemployment rate means that businesses may face significant challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is small, leading to potential wage pressure. For a business trying to hire in Columbus, this tight market implies that attracting and retaining talent will be highly competitive.

Wage Growth

Columbus experiences a year-over-year wage growth rate of +3.26%, placing it near the median at the 42nd percentile. This moderate wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively so, and worker purchasing power is increasing, albeit not at a rapid pace. The implication is that businesses will need to adjust their compensation packages to keep pace with the market, but the pressure is not extreme.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of \$207/sqft to \$34.44/hr, Columbus ranks at the 63rd percentile in terms of affordability, indicating it is slightly above average in cost. However, the key factor is the year-over-year direction, with PSF decreasing by -0.5%, which slightly improves affordability. This means Columbus has a moderate talent attraction advantage without needing significant wage premiums, as the cost of living, while not the lowest, is manageable relative to earnings.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Columbus is shrinking at a rate of -1.44% year-over-year, placing it below average at the 24th percentile. This contraction in labor force supply implies a structural headwind for hiring, as the pool of potential workers is decreasing. Businesses looking to expand or establish operations in Columbus will need to consider strategies to attract workers from other areas or invest in workforce development.

Building Permits

Columbus has seen a significant decline in residential building permits, with a year-over-year change of -20.69%, ranking it in the bottom tier at the 14th percentile. This sharp decrease signals a tightening in future housing supply, which could lead to affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce. The implication for businesses is that relocating workers may face a competitive and potentially expensive housing market.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Columbus is 33 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -5.7%, placing it in the bottom tier at the 12th percentile. This fast-paced market means that homes are selling quickly, which can be challenging for relocating workers trying to find housing. The competitive housing market suggests that businesses may need to offer relocation assistance or flexible timing for starts to help new hires secure housing.

Office Economy

Columbus has a professional and office worker share that ranks below average at the 32nd percentile. This indicates that while there is some depth to the professional talent pool, it is not as pronounced as in other cities. Columbus is less suited for businesses requiring a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech, finance, or consulting, but may be more appropriate for industries with different workforce needs.

In conclusion, Columbus offers a business environment with a tight labor market and moderate wage growth, suggesting both opportunities and challenges. The single biggest risk or constraint for a decision-maker considering Columbus is the shrinking labor force and the tightening housing supply, which could exacerbate hiring difficulties and talent retention challenges.

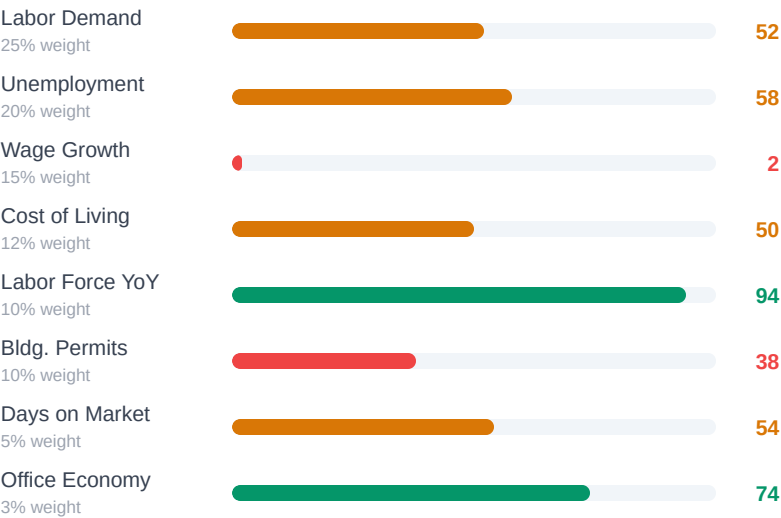
Cleveland

Cleveland

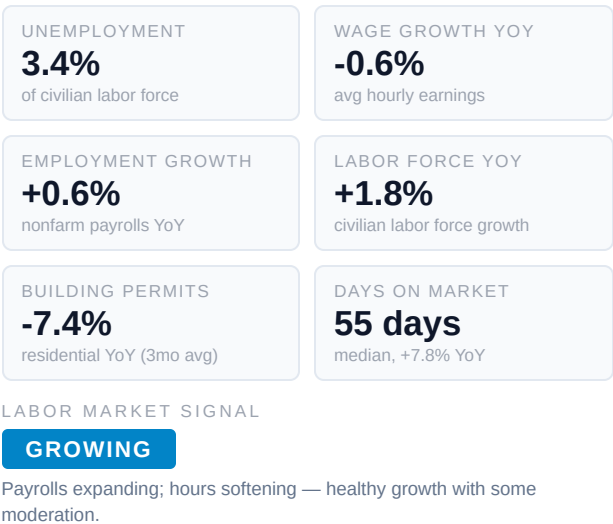
B-

BELOW AVERAGE
49.0th percentile
Rank 25 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Cleveland earns an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it at the 49.0th percentile among 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its labor force growth, which is expanding at a rate of 1.80% year-over-year, and its wage growth, which is declining at a rate of -0.55% year-over-year. These two metrics signal a city with a growing workforce but stagnant wages.

Labor Demand

Cleveland's employment growth rate is 0.57% year-over-year, while weekly hours are deviating -0.363% from its own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a labor market with modest job growth but hours worked are below trend, indicating a potential survivor squeeze where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles. The labor demand composite score of 4.73 ranks near the median at the 52nd percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Cleveland is 3.40%, ranking near the median at the 58th percentile. This rate indicates a labor market with some slack, making it relatively easier for businesses to hire compared to tighter markets. However, the practical implication for a business trying to hire here is that while it may be easier to find candidates, the market is not so loose as to depress wages significantly.

Wage Growth

Cleveland's year-over-year wage growth rate is -0.55%, placing it in the bottom tier at the 2nd percentile. This stagnant wage growth signals flat labor costs for employers but weak bargaining power for workers. The implication for employer labor costs is a stable expense environment, but for workers, it means limited purchasing power growth.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of \$143/sqft to \$33.75/hr, giving a ratio of 4.24, Cleveland ranks near the median at the 50th percentile in terms of affordability. However, the PSF is increasing by 13.5% year-over-year, which could erode affordability over time. This means the city is currently neither particularly attractive nor deterrent in terms of cost of living for talent, as it does not offer a significant advantage without wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Cleveland is growing at a rate of 1.80% year-over-year, ranking in the top tier at the 94th percentile. This expanding labor force supply is a positive sign for businesses looking to hire, as it indicates a growing pool of potential workers. The implication for hiring capacity is favorable, with a structural advantage in terms of workforce availability.

Building Permits

Residential building permits in Cleveland are decreasing by 7.43% year-over-year, ranking below average at the 38th percentile. This decline in permits signals a tightening housing supply, which could lead to decreased affordability and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce. The future affordability and workforce attraction potential of the city may be at risk due to this supply squeeze.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Cleveland is 55 days, with a year-over-year increase of 7.8%. This indicates a market that is slowing down, making it slightly more accessible for relocating workers to find housing. However, the market remains relatively competitive, and the rising days on market could signal a normalization rather than a significant easing of the housing market.

Office Economy

Cleveland's share of jobs in professional and office sectors ranks above average at the 74th percentile. This deep talent pool makes the city well-suited for businesses in tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions that require specialized knowledge workers. Conversely, it may be less ideal for industries dominated by industrial or logistics roles.

In conclusion, Cleveland offers businesses a growing labor force and a currently accessible labor market, but it also presents challenges such as stagnant wage growth and a tightening housing supply. The single biggest risk or constraint for a decision-maker to factor in is the potential for decreased affordability and workforce attraction due to the supply squeeze in housing, which could impact the city's long-term competitiveness and ability to accommodate business growth.

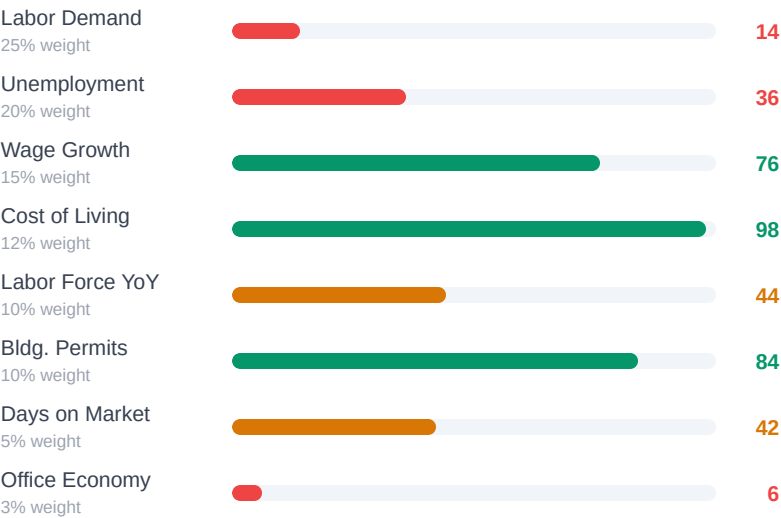
Memphis

Memphis

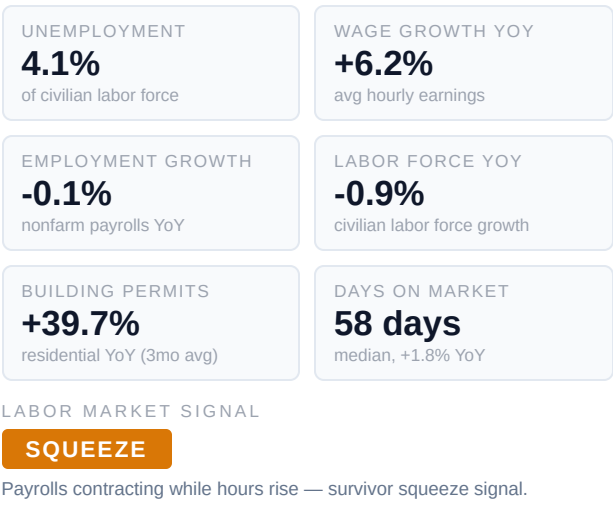
B-

BELOW AVERAGE
48.9th percentile
Rank 26 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The city of Memphis has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it 48.9th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with a composite score of 2.65 ranking it in the bottom tier at the 14th percentile, and its high wage growth, with a year-over-year change of +6.18% ranking it above average at the 76th percentile. These metrics suggest a complex economic environment with both challenges and opportunities.

Labor Demand

Memphis has an employment growth rate of -0.11% and a weekly hours deviation of +1.898% from its own trend. The combination of these metrics signals a survivor squeeze, where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles, rather than genuine demand expansion. This suggests that the city's labor market is not experiencing strong growth.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Memphis is 4.10%, ranking it below average at the 36th percentile. This indicates that the market has some slack, making it slightly easier for businesses to hire compared to tighter labor markets. However, the relatively low unemployment rate still suggests that businesses may face some competition for talent.

Wage Growth

Memphis has a year-over-year wage growth rate of +6.18%, ranking it above average at the 76th percentile. This fast wage growth suggests that employer labor costs are rising, but it also indicates strong worker purchasing power. Businesses should be prepared for increasing labor costs, but may also benefit from a more affluent local consumer base.

Cost of Living

Memphis has a cost of living score ranking it in the top tier at the 98th percentile, with a price-to-salary ratio of \$155/sqft to \$32.45/hr, or 4.78. The city's PSF is also falling by -6.1% year-over-year, making it more affordable relative to wages. This high affordability score means that Memphis has a talent attraction advantage, as workers can maintain a high standard of living without requiring large wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Memphis is growing at a rate of -0.89% year-over-year, ranking it near the median at the 44th percentile. This indicates that the labor force supply is contracting, which may pose a structural headwind for hiring in the city. Businesses should be prepared to compete for a shrinking pool of workers.

Building Permits

Memphis has a year-over-year change in building permits of +39.70%, ranking it in the top tier at the 84th percentile. This suggests that housing supply is expanding, which should improve affordability and accommodation for the workforce in the future. Rising building permits are a positive signal for businesses considering relocation to the city.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Memphis is 58 days, with a year-over-year increase of +1.8%. This ranks the city near the median at the 42nd percentile. The relatively slow market suggests that workers relocating to the city may have a more accessible and less competitive housing market, which could be an advantage for businesses trying to attract talent.

Office Economy

Memphis has an office economy score ranking it in the bottom tier at the 6th percentile, with a share of professional and office workers at 0.58. This suggests that the city's talent pool is not particularly deep in professional and office sectors, making it less suited for businesses in tech, finance, or consulting. However, the city may be more attractive to businesses in industrial or logistics sectors.

The city of Memphis offers businesses a unique combination of high wage growth, low cost of living, and expanding housing supply, making it an attractive location for companies looking to reduce labor costs and improve worker affordability. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for businesses considering relocation to Memphis is the low labor demand and contracting labor force supply, which may pose challenges for hiring and talent acquisition in the city.

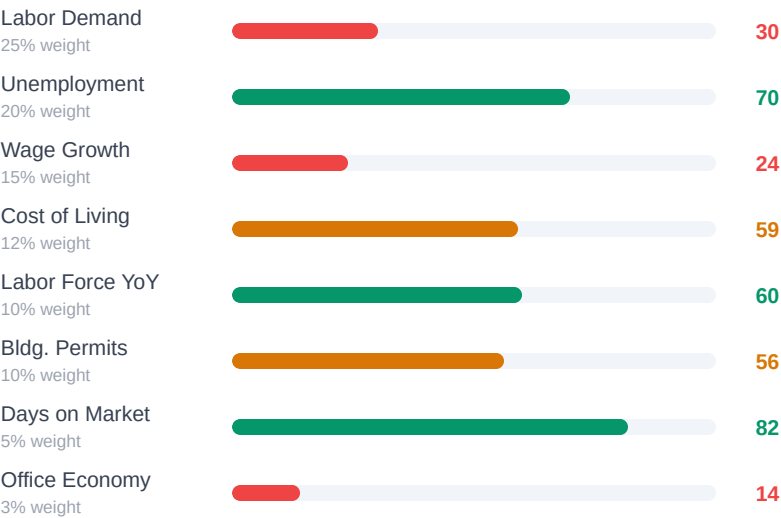
St. Louis

St. Louis

B-

BELOW AVERAGE
48.3th percentile
Rank 27 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

St. Louis has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it 48.3th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its below-average labor demand, with a composite score of 3.63, and its above-average unemployment rate of 3.60%, which ranks in the 70th percentile. These metrics suggest a city with a relatively tight labor market but struggling to create new job opportunities.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in St. Louis is -0.48% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating -0.025% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, indicating that the city is not experiencing genuine demand expansion. Instead, it may be facing a period of job losses or stagnation.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in St. Louis is 3.60%, ranking in the 70th percentile, which means the market is relatively tight. This tightness implies that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is smaller, and wage pressure may be higher. As a result, companies may need to offer competitive salaries to attract top talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in St. Louis is +1.80%, which is below average, ranking in the 24th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not rapidly, and worker purchasing power is increasing, albeit slowly. This may impact businesses' ability to retain and attract workers, as they may need to adjust their compensation packages accordingly.

Cost of Living

St. Louis has a cost of living ratio of \$166/sqft to \$37.52/hr, with a percentile rank of 59th, indicating that the city is near the median in terms of affordability. This means that St. Louis is neither extremely affordable nor expensive, and businesses may not need to offer significant wage premiums to attract workers. However, the city's affordability may not be a major talent attraction advantage.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in St. Louis is growing at a rate of +0.01% year-over-year, which is above average, ranking in the 60th percentile. This slow but positive growth rate suggests that the workforce supply is expanding, albeit slowly, which may help businesses find the talent they need. However, the slow growth rate may not be enough to meet the demands of rapidly expanding companies.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in St. Louis is increasing by +4.06% year-over-year, which is near the median, ranking in the 56th percentile. This moderate growth rate suggests that housing supply is expanding, which may improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce. However, the growth rate is not rapid enough to significantly impact the city's affordability in the short term.

Days on Market

The median days on market in St. Louis is 42 days, with a year-over-year increase of +7.7%, ranking in the 82nd percentile. This means that homes are sitting on the market for a relatively long time, indicating a slower and more buyer-friendly market. For workers relocating to St. Louis, this may be a competitive advantage, as they may have more time to find and purchase a home.

Office Economy

St. Louis has a relatively shallow professional talent pool, ranking in the 14th percentile. This suggests that the city is not well-suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech, finance, or consulting companies. Instead, St. Louis may be more suitable for industries with fewer specialized roles, such as logistics or manufacturing.

In conclusion, St. Louis offers businesses a relatively tight labor market with moderate wage growth, but its below-average labor demand and slow labor force growth may pose challenges for companies looking to expand. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's limited professional talent pool, which may make it difficult to attract and retain top talent in certain industries.

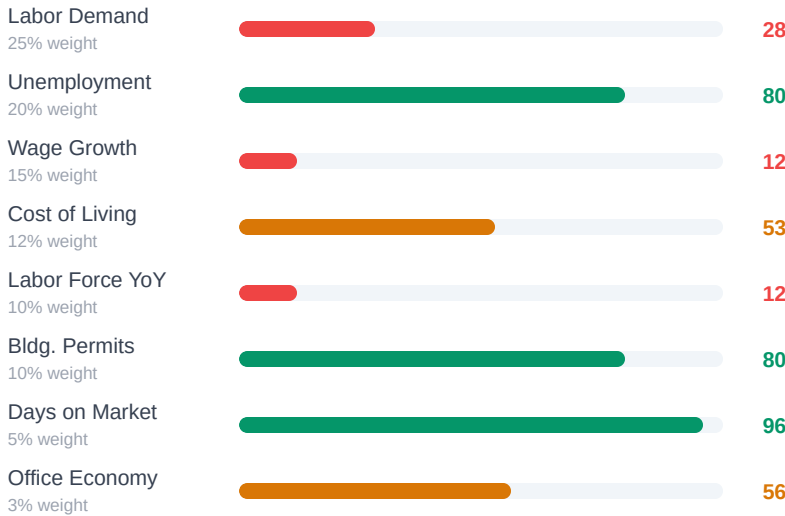
Denver

Denver-Aurora-Centennial

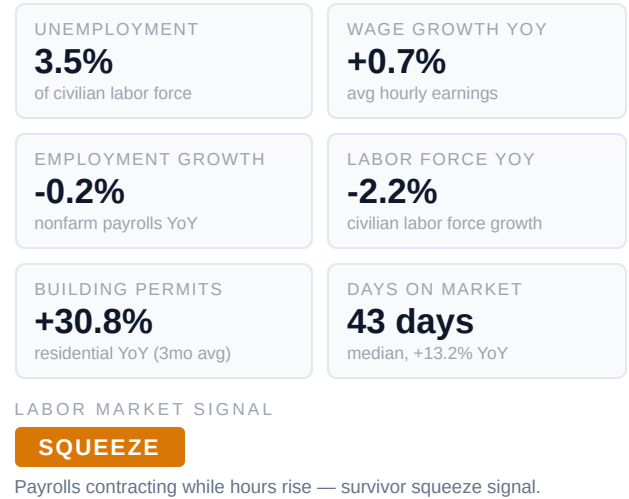
B-

BELOW AVERAGE
46.8th percentile
Rank 28 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Denver-Aurora-Centennial metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it 46.8th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with a composite score in the 28th percentile, and its tight unemployment market, with a rate of 3.50% ranking in the 80th percentile. The combination of these metrics suggests a challenging environment for businesses looking to hire and expand.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Denver-Aurora-Centennial is -0.24% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating from the trend by +0.467%. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, indicating that the city is experiencing a decline in job growth, and the slight increase in hours worked may be due to a survivor squeeze, where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Denver-Aurora-Centennial is 3.50%, which ranks in the 80th percentile, indicating a tight labor market with little slack. This means that businesses trying to hire in this city will face significant competition for talent, leading to potential wage pressure and difficulties in finding qualified candidates.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Denver-Aurora-Centennial is +0.74%, which is in the bottom tier, ranking 12th percentile. This stagnant wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly, but it also implies weak bargaining power for workers, which may impact their purchasing power and overall economic well-being.

Cost of Living

Denver-Aurora-Centennial has a cost of living ratio of \$290/sqft to \$42.65/hr, with a percentile rank of 53rd, indicating a near-median affordability level. The fact that PSF is falling by -3.3% year-over-year relative to wages is a positive sign, but the city's affordability is still not a major advantage, meaning that businesses may not be able to attract talent without offering wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Denver-Aurora-Centennial is shrinking at a rate of -2.22% year-over-year, which is in the bottom tier, ranking 12th percentile. This contraction in labor force supply poses a significant structural headwind for hiring, making it challenging for businesses to find and recruit new talent.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Denver-Aurora-Centennial is increasing by +30.79% year-over-year, which ranks in the top tier, 80th percentile. This expansion in housing supply is a positive sign, indicating that the city is likely to experience improving affordability and a more accommodating environment for its workforce in the future.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Denver-Aurora-Centennial is 43 days, with a year-over-year increase of +13.2%, ranking in the top tier, 96th percentile. This slower market means that workers relocating to this city will have a more accessible and less competitive housing market, which can be an advantage for businesses looking to attract talent.

Office Economy

Denver-Aurora-Centennial has an office economy percentile rank of 56th, indicating a near-median depth of professional talent pool. This city is relatively well-suited for businesses that require a moderate level of specialized office skills, but it may not be the best fit for companies that demand a very deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech or finance hubs.

The Denver-Aurora-Centennial metro area offers businesses a unique combination of a tight labor market and expanding housing supply, which may lead to improving affordability and a more attractive environment for talent. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's low labor demand and shrinking labor force, which poses significant challenges for hiring and expansion, and may require businesses to offer competitive wages to attract and retain talent.

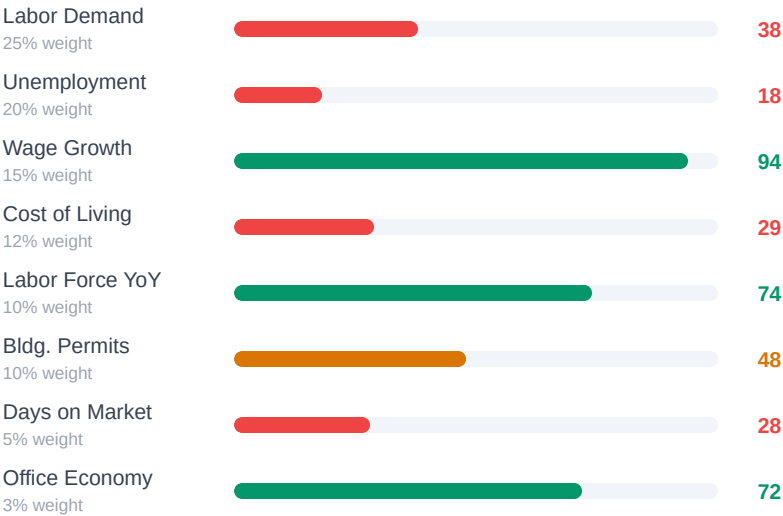
Miami

Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach

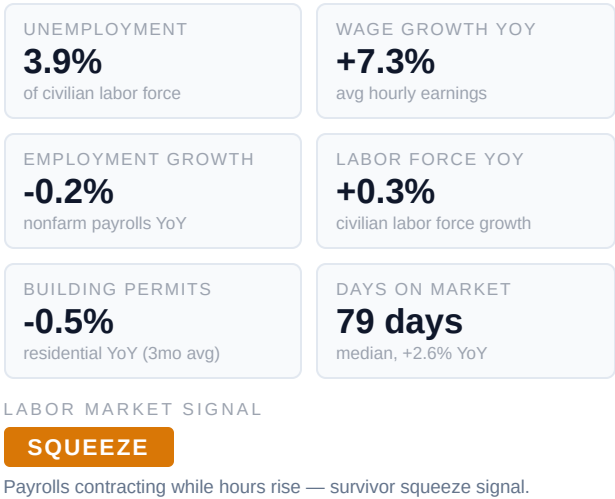
B-

BELOW AVERAGE
46.4th percentile
Rank 29 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it 46.4th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its high wage growth rate of 7.30% year-over-year and its low unemployment rate of 3.90%, which signals a tight labor market. The combination of these metrics suggests that while the city has strong wage growth, its labor market is highly competitive.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach is -0.25% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating 0.166% above the city's own 12-month trend. This combination signals a survivor squeeze, where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles, rather than genuine demand expansion. The labor demand composite score of 3.78 ranks below average at the 38th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach is 3.90%, ranking at the 18th percentile, which indicates a very tight labor market with little slack. This means that businesses trying to hire in this city will face significant competition for talent and may need to offer higher wages to attract workers. The tight labor market implies that hiring will be challenging and may drive up labor costs.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach is 7.30%, ranking at the 94th percentile, which is exceptionally high. This rapid wage growth implies that employer labor costs will rise quickly, but it also means that workers will have strong purchasing power. The high wage growth rate is a double-edged sword, benefiting workers but increasing costs for businesses.

Cost of Living

Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach has a cost of living score that ranks at the 29th percentile, with a price-to-salary ratio of \$358/sqft to \$34.04/hr, or 10.52. Although the price per square foot is decreasing by 1.4% year-over-year, the city remains relatively expensive compared to its peers. This means that attracting talent without offering wage premiums may be challenging due to the high cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach is growing at a rate of 0.35% year-over-year, ranking above average at the 74th percentile. This indicates that the workforce supply is expanding, which is a positive sign for businesses looking to hire in the area. The growing labor force implies that hiring capacity should improve over time.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits in Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach is -0.50%, ranking near the median at the 48th percentile. This slight decline in building permits suggests that housing supply may not be expanding quickly enough to meet demand, potentially leading to future affordability issues and constraints on workforce accommodation.

Days on Market

The current median days on market for homes in Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach is 79 days, with a year-over-year increase of 2.6%. This indicates a slightly slower market, which could make it more accessible for relocating workers to find housing. However, the days on market percentile rank is below average at the 28th percentile, suggesting that the market is still relatively competitive.

Office Economy

Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach has an office economy score ranking at the 72nd percentile, indicating a deep talent pool in professional and office sectors. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in tech, finance, consulting, and headquarters operations, but less ideal for industries with primarily industrial or logistics roles.

The Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach metro area offers businesses a unique combination of high wage growth and a tight labor market, making it an attractive location for companies that can navigate these conditions. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the high cost of living, which may require wage premiums to attract and retain talent, potentially offsetting the benefits of the city's strong wage growth and deep professional talent pool.

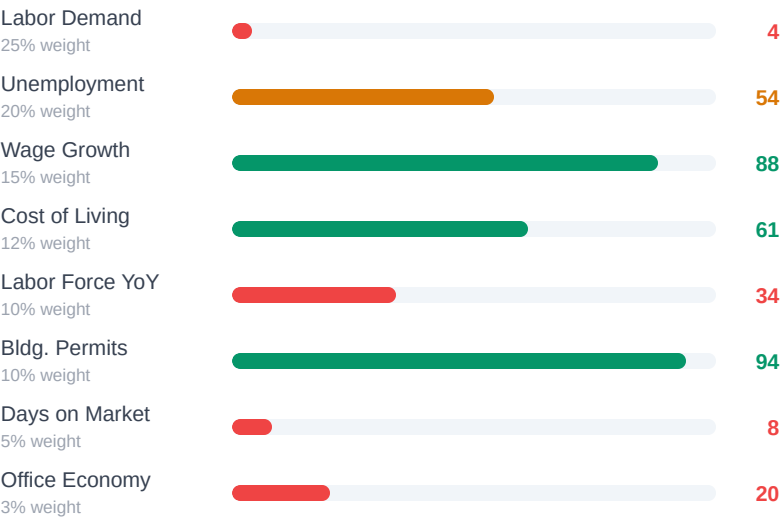
Virginia Beach

Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk

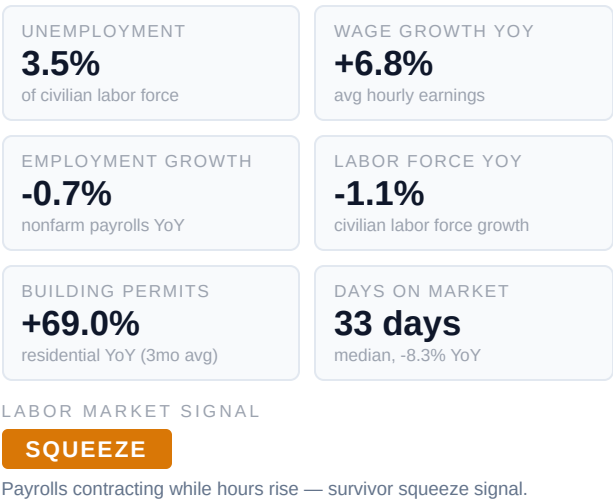
B-

BELOW AVERAGE
46.1th percentile
Rank 30 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it at the 46.1th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its weak labor demand, with a labor demand composite score in the bottom tier at the 4th percentile, and strong wage growth, with a year-over-year increase of 6.78% in hourly earnings. The combination of these metrics suggests a complex economic environment.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in this metro area is -0.73% year-over-year, and weekly hours are 2.049% above the city's own trend. This combination signals a survivor squeeze, where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles, rather than genuine demand expansion. The labor demand composite score of 1.78 is in the bottom tier, indicating a challenging environment for businesses looking to expand their workforce.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in this metro area is 3.50%, which is near the median at the 54th percentile. This suggests that the labor market has some slack, making it slightly easier for businesses to hire compared to tighter markets. However, the relatively low unemployment rate still indicates some competition for talent, and businesses may need to offer competitive wages to attract workers.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in this metro area is 6.78%, which is in the top tier at the 88th percentile. This rapid wage growth signals rising labor costs for employers, but also increasing purchasing power for workers. Businesses should be prepared for higher labor costs, but may also benefit from a more affluent local consumer base.

Cost of Living

The cost of living in this metro area is above average, with a PSF of \$224/sqft and an earnings ratio of 6.32, ranking it at the 61st percentile. This means that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers, which could make it harder to attract talent without offering wage premiums. The fact that PSF is rising 1.8% year-over-year relative to wages further exacerbates the affordability challenge.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in this metro area is shrinking at a rate of -1.08% year-over-year, which is below average at the 34th percentile. This contraction in labor supply signals a structural headwind for hiring, making it more challenging for businesses to find the talent they need. As the labor force shrinks, businesses may need to offer more competitive wages or benefits to attract workers.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in this metro area is increasing by 69.04% year-over-year, which is in the top tier at the 94th percentile. This rapid expansion of housing supply signals improving affordability and a more accommodating environment for workers. As housing supply increases, businesses may find it easier to attract and retain talent.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in this metro area is 33 days, with a year-over-year decrease of 8.3%. This fast-paced market makes it challenging for relocating workers to find housing, as homes are selling quickly. The low days on market ranking at the 8th percentile indicates a competitive housing market that may require workers to act quickly to secure a home.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in this metro area is relatively low, ranking at the 20th percentile. This suggests that the city has a less deep talent pool in these sectors, making it less suited for businesses that require a high concentration of tech, finance, or consulting talent. However, the city may be more suitable for businesses in other sectors, such as logistics or manufacturing.

The Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk metro area offers businesses a complex economic environment with strong wage growth, but also significant challenges in labor demand and affordability. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the shrinking labor force, which may require businesses to offer more competitive wages or benefits to attract and retain talent.

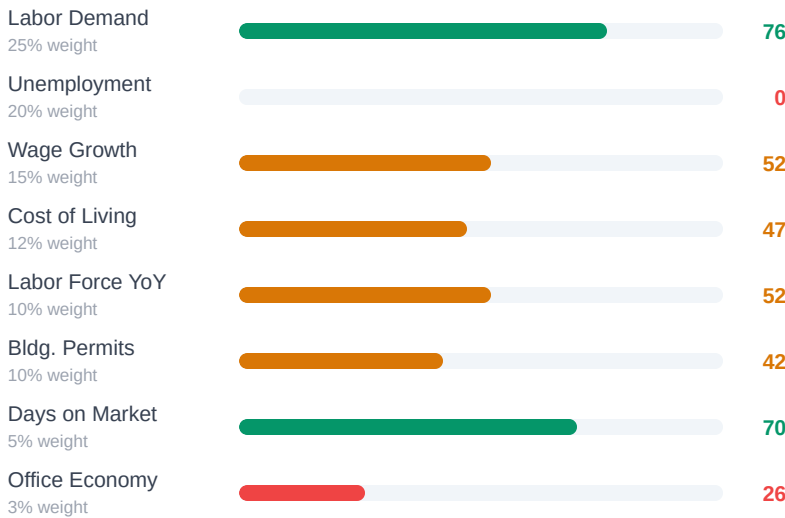
Fresno

Fresno

B-

BELOW AVERAGE
46.1th percentile
Rank 31 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT
8.1%
of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY
+4.2%
avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH
+1.7%
nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY
-0.2%
civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS
-6.9%
residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET
52 days
median, +10.6% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The city of Fresno has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it at the 46.1th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its high labor demand composite score, which ranks at the 76th percentile, and its low unemployment rate, which, despite being 8.10%, actually indicates a challenging hiring environment due to its ranking at the 0th percentile. These metrics suggest a city with strong job growth but significant competition for labor.

Labor Demand

Fresno's employment growth rate is 1.67% year-over-year, and its weekly hours deviation from trend is -0.768%, indicating a genuine demand expansion despite the slight decrease in hours worked. This combination signals that the city is adding jobs at a rate above the national average, with a labor demand composite score of 5.87. The negative hours deviation may suggest some efficiency in labor utilization.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Fresno is 8.10%, ranking at the 0th percentile, which indicates a very tight labor market with little slack. This tight market implies that businesses trying to hire in Fresno will face significant competition for workers, potentially driving up wages. The low unemployment rate suggests that workers have more bargaining power.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Fresno is 4.17%, ranking near the median at the 52nd percentile. This moderate wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are increasing, but not at an alarming rate. Workers in Fresno are seeing their purchasing power increase, which can be beneficial for local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

Fresno has a cost of living score ranking at the 47th percentile, with a price per square foot of \$261 and average hourly earnings of \$33.53, resulting in a ratio of 7.78. The city's PSF is decreasing by 0.8% year-over-year, making it relatively more affordable compared to its peers. This affordability can be a talent attraction advantage, as workers may not require significant wage premiums to maintain their standard of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Fresno is growing at a rate of -0.20% year-over-year, indicating a slight contraction in the labor pool. This negative growth rate suggests that the supply of workers is not expanding, which could pose a structural headwind for hiring and business expansion in the city.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits in Fresno is -6.89%, indicating a tightening of the housing supply. This decrease in permits suggests that developer confidence may be waning, and the future housing supply might not keep pace with demand, potentially leading to affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Fresno is 52 days, with a year-over-year increase of 10.6%. This increase indicates a slowing market, which can be beneficial for workers relocating to the city as it becomes more accessible. However, in the context of a strong job market, this slowing could also signal a healthy normalization rather than demand erosion.

Office Economy

Fresno's professional and office worker share ranks at the 26th percentile, indicating a relatively shallow talent pool in these sectors. The city is less suited for businesses requiring deep knowledge-economy talent, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms, but might be more appropriate for industries with different workforce requirements.

The city of Fresno offers businesses a unique combination of strong labor demand and moderate wage growth, but it also presents significant challenges, including a very tight labor market and potential future affordability issues due to a tightening housing supply. The single biggest risk or constraint for a decision-maker considering Fresno as a business location is the difficulty in hiring and retaining workers due to the competitive labor market, which could drive up labor costs and impact business operations.

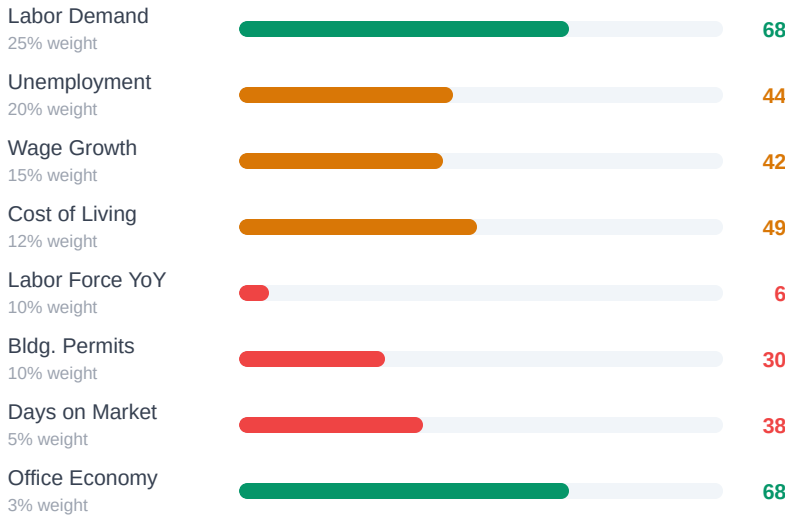
Phoenix

Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler

B-

BELOW AVERAGE
45.5th percentile
Rank 32 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT
3.8%
of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY
+3.3%
avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH
+0.6%
nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY
-2.5%
civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS
-16.5%
residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET
60 days
median, +3.5% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it at the 45.5th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its labor demand, with a composite score ranking at the 68th percentile, and its labor force growth, which is contracting at a rate of -2.53% year-over-year. The labor demand metrics, including employment growth and weekly hours, signal a genuine demand expansion.

Labor Demand

The Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler metro area has an employment growth rate of +0.62% year-over-year and a weekly hours deviation of +0.193% from its own trend, indicating a genuine demand expansion. This combination signals that the city is adding jobs and workers are putting in more hours, suggesting a strong labor market. The labor demand composite score of 5.36 ranks at the 68th percentile, further supporting the notion of a robust labor market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler is 3.80%, ranking at the 44th percentile, indicating a near-median level of unemployment. This suggests that the market has some slack, making it slightly easier for businesses to hire. However, the relatively low unemployment rate also means that businesses may face some wage pressure.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler is +3.26%, ranking at the 42nd percentile, indicating moderate wage growth. This rate of wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but at a manageable pace. Workers in the area are also seeing an increase in their purchasing power.

Cost of Living

The cost of living in Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler, with a price-to-salary ratio of \$271/sqft vs \$37.62/hr, ranks at the 49th percentile, indicating a near-median level of affordability. The fact that the PSF is falling by -1.8% year-over-year relative to wages makes the city more attractive for talent without requiring significant wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler is contracting at a rate of -2.53% year-over-year, ranking at the 6th percentile. This indicates that the labor force supply is shrinking, which could pose a structural headwind for hiring in the area. Businesses may face challenges in finding qualified workers.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits in Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler is -16.51%, ranking at the 30th percentile, indicating a tightening of housing supply. This suggests that future affordability and workforce accommodation may be at risk, as the supply of new housing is not keeping pace with demand.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler is 60 days, with a year-over-year increase of +3.5%. This indicates a slightly slower market, which could make it more accessible for relocating workers to find housing. However, the market is still relatively competitive.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler ranks at the 68th percentile, indicating a deep talent pool. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors. However, it may be less suitable for industries with more industrial or logistics-oriented economies.

The Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler metro area offers businesses a strong labor market with genuine demand expansion, but the single biggest risk or constraint is the contracting labor force, which could pose challenges for hiring and workforce growth. Despite this, the city's moderate wage growth, near-median affordability, and deep professional talent pool make it an attractive location for certain types of businesses. Overall, decision-makers should carefully weigh the benefits and risks of locating in this city.

Providence

Providence-Warwick

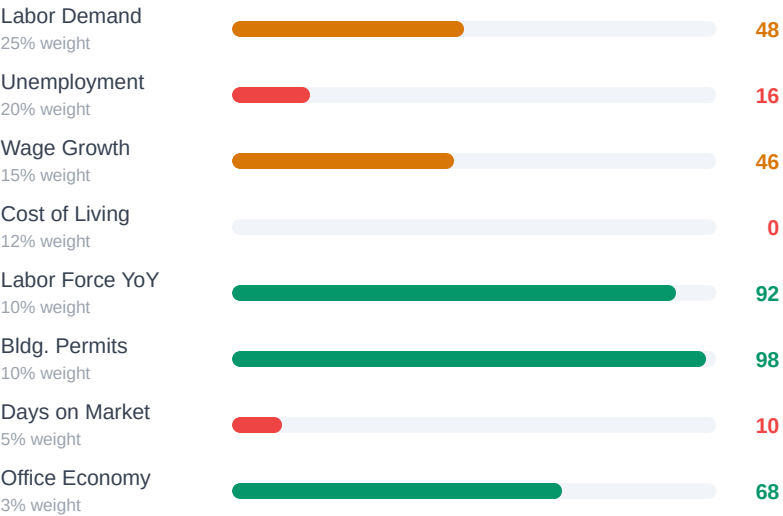
C+

POOR

43.6th percentile

Rank 33 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Providence-Warwick metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it 43.6th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its low unemployment rate of 4.30% and its high cost of living, with a PSF to wages ratio of 9.95. The labor demand composite score of 4.64, near the median, also plays a significant role in shaping the city's economic landscape.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Providence-Warwick is +0.60% year-over-year, while weekly hours are deviating -0.502% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a moderate labor demand expansion, as the job growth is positive but hours are slightly below trend, indicating some slack in the labor market. This suggests that while there is some genuine demand for labor, it is not overly strong.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Providence-Warwick is 4.30%, ranking in the bottom tier at the 16th percentile. This indicates a relatively tight labor market with some slack, making it moderately challenging for businesses to hire. The practical implication for a business trying to hire in this city is that it may face some competition for talent, but not to the extent that it would in a market with even lower unemployment.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Providence-Warwick is +3.51%, ranking near the median at the 46th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively so. At the same time, worker purchasing power is increasing, which can have a positive impact on local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

Providence-Warwick has a cost of living percentile rank of 0, indicating that it is one of the most expensive cities relative to peers, with a PSF to wages ratio of 9.95 and a PSF increase of +9.0% year-over-year. This means that the city is at a significant disadvantage when it comes to talent attraction, as businesses may need to offer wage premiums to compensate for the high cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Providence-Warwick is growing at a rate of +1.69% year-over-year, ranking in the top tier at the 92nd percentile. This indicates that the labor force supply is expanding, which is a positive sign for businesses looking to hire in the city. The implication is that the city has a growing pool of potential workers, making it easier for businesses to find the talent they need.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Providence-Warwick has increased by +137.37% year-over-year, ranking in the top tier at the 98th percentile. This suggests that housing supply is expanding rapidly, which is a positive sign for future affordability and workforce accommodation. As the housing supply increases, it is likely to put downward pressure on housing costs, making the city more attractive to workers and businesses.

Days on Market

The current median days on market in Providence-Warwick is 30 days, with a year-over-year change of +0.0%, ranking in the bottom tier at the 10th percentile. This indicates a very competitive market, where homes are selling quickly. For a worker relocating to this city, this means that the housing market is challenging, and they may need to act quickly to secure a home.

Office Economy

Providence-Warwick has an office economy percentile rank of 68, indicating a deeper professional talent pool than average. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, but less suited for industrial or logistics-dominant businesses. The city's professional workforce share of 3.14 suggests a strong foundation for knowledge-economy businesses.

The Providence-Warwick metro area offers businesses a growing labor force and expanding housing supply, but its high cost of living and competitive housing market are significant drawbacks. The single biggest risk or constraint for a decision-maker to factor in is the need to offer wage premiums to attract and retain talent in this expensive city, which could increase labor costs and impact profitability.

Chicago

Chicago-Naperville-Elgin

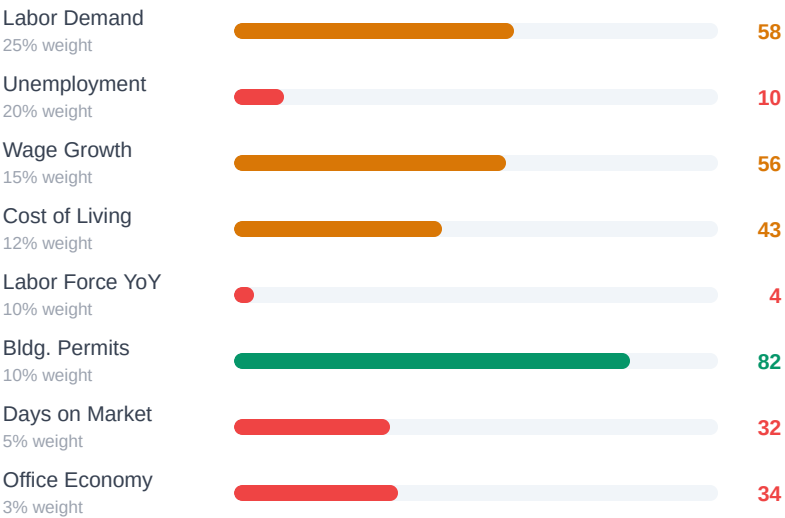
C+

POOR

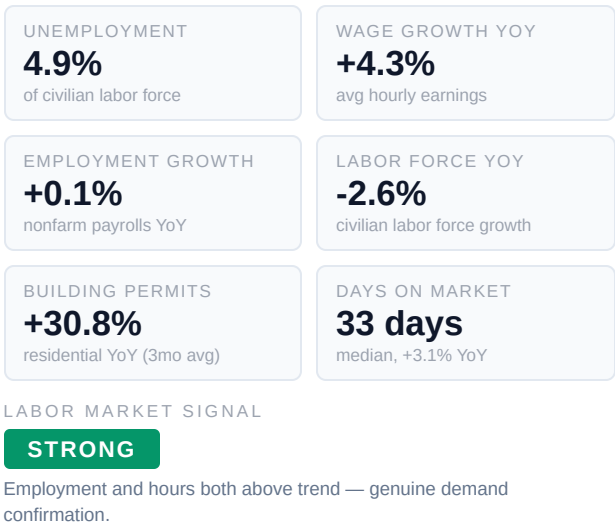
41.3th percentile

Rank 34 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Chicago-Naperville-Elgin metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it 41.3th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its low unemployment rate of 4.90% and its negative labor force growth rate of -2.60% YoY, indicating a tight labor market with a shrinking workforce. The combination of these metrics suggests that while there is demand for labor, the supply of workers is constrained.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin is +0.08% YoY, and weekly hours are deviating +0.475% from the city's own 12-month baseline, resulting in a labor demand composite score of 4.89, which ranks near the median at 58th percentile. This combination signals a genuine demand expansion, albeit a modest one. The positive hours deviation indicates that existing workers are taking on more hours, which is a sign of a growing economy.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin is 4.90%, ranking in the bottom tier at 10th percentile, indicating a very tight labor market with little slack. This means that businesses trying to hire in this city will face significant competition for workers, leading to upward pressure on wages. As a result, companies may need to offer higher salaries to attract and retain talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin is +4.27%, ranking near the median at 56th percentile, indicating moderate wage growth. This rate of wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively so, while worker purchasing power is increasing. As a result, businesses can expect to pay more for labor over time, but workers will have more disposable income to spend.

Cost of Living

Chicago-Naperville-Elgin has a cost of living ratio of \$220/sqft to \$37.11/hr, with a PSF increase of +1.4% YoY, ranking near the median at 43rd percentile in terms of affordability. This means that the city is neither particularly affordable nor expensive relative to its peers. However, the rising PSF suggests that affordability may be decreasing over time, which could make it harder to attract talent without offering wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin is shrinking at a rate of -2.60% YoY, ranking in the bottom tier at 4th percentile, indicating a significant contraction in the workforce. This decline in labor force supply will make it even harder for businesses to find

workers, exacerbating the existing tight labor market conditions. As a result, companies may need to consider alternative locations or strategies to access the talent they need.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin is increasing by +30.83% YoY, ranking in the top tier at 82nd percentile, indicating a significant expansion in housing supply. This growth in permits suggests that housing affordability may improve in the future, making it easier for workers to relocate to the city. As a result, businesses can expect a more accessible and affordable housing market for their employees.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin is currently 33 days, with a +3.1% YoY increase, ranking below average at 32nd percentile. This means that the housing market is relatively competitive, but not extremely so, making it accessible for relocating workers to find homes. However, the rising days on market suggests that the market may be normalizing, giving buyers a bit more time to make decisions.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin is 1.98, ranking below average at 34th percentile, indicating a relatively shallow talent pool for tech, finance, and consulting businesses. This city is best suited for businesses that do not require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as industrial or logistics companies. However, businesses that rely on specialized office workers may find it challenging to attract and retain talent in this city.

The Chicago-Naperville-Elgin metro area offers businesses a tight labor market with moderate wage growth, but also a shrinking workforce and a relatively competitive housing market. The single biggest risk or constraint for businesses considering this location is the limited labor force supply, which may require companies to offer higher wages or consider alternative locations to access the talent they need. Overall, businesses must carefully weigh the pros and cons of locating in this city, considering both the benefits of a growing economy and the challenges of a constrained labor market.

Indianapolis

Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood

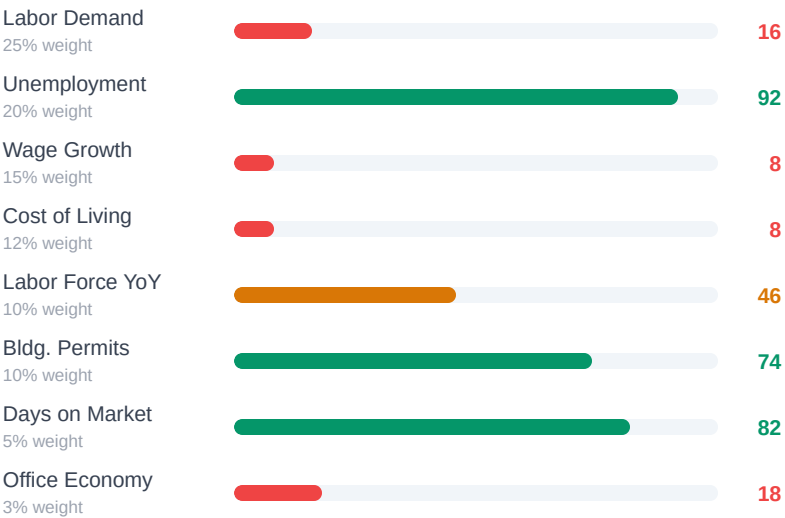
C+

POOR

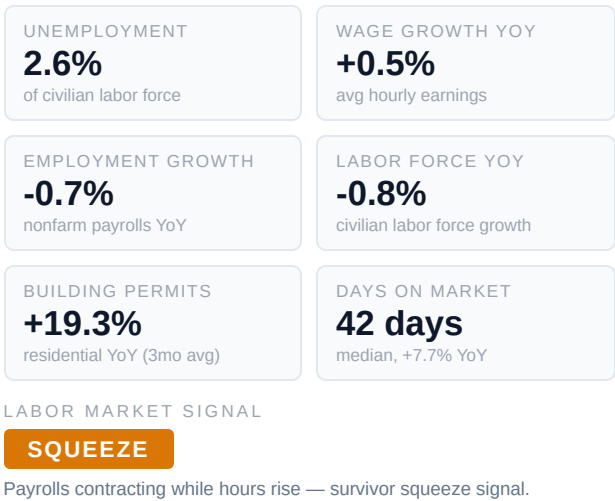
41.2th percentile

Rank 35 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it 41.2th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with a composite score in the bottom tier, and its tight unemployment market, with a rate of 2.60%. The combination of these metrics suggests a challenging environment for businesses looking to hire and expand.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood is -0.72% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating 0.621% above the city's own 12-month baseline. However, the combination of these metrics signals a contraction in labor demand, rather than genuine demand expansion, as hours are above trend during a period of job losses, indicating a survivor squeeze. This suggests that remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood is 2.60%, which is in the top tier, ranking 92nd percentile. This indicates a very tight labor market with little slack, making it challenging for businesses to hire new employees. As a result, businesses may face upward pressure on wages to attract and retain talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood is +0.46%, which is in the bottom tier, ranking 8th percentile. This stagnant wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly, but it also implies weak bargaining power for workers and limited growth in worker purchasing power. This may impact the overall attractiveness of the city to businesses and workers alike.

Cost of Living

Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood has a cost of living score in the bottom tier, with a ratio of \$168/sqft to \$32.75/hr, resulting in a score of 8th percentile. This means that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers, which may make it less attractive for talent attraction without offering wage premiums. The fact that PSF is rising 5.0% year-over-year relative to wages further exacerbates the affordability issue.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood is contracting at a rate of -0.76% year-over-year, which is near the median. This suggests that the workforce supply is shrinking, creating a structural headwind for hiring and business expansion. As a result, businesses may need to consider alternative locations or strategies to access the talent they need.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood is increasing by 19.26% year-over-year, which is above average, ranking 74th percentile. This expansion in housing supply is a positive signal for future affordability and workforce accommodation, as it may help to alleviate some of the pressure on the housing market and make the city more attractive to workers.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood is 42 days, with a year-over-year increase of 7.7%, ranking 82nd percentile. This suggests a slower market, which may be more accessible for workers relocating to the city, as they have more time to find and secure a home. However, this may also indicate a weakening demand for housing, which could have implications for the local economy.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood is relatively low, ranking 18th percentile. This suggests that the city may not have a deep talent pool for businesses in the tech, finance, or consulting sectors, making it less suited for these types of companies. However, it may be more attractive for businesses in other industries, such as logistics or manufacturing.

In conclusion, Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood offers a challenging business environment, with low labor demand, tight unemployment, and stagnant wage growth. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the shrinking labor force supply, which may limit the city's attractiveness for businesses looking to hire and expand. Despite some positive signals, such as expanding housing supply, the overall economic character of the city suggests that businesses may need to carefully consider their location decisions and strategies for accessing the talent they need.

San Antonio

San Antonio-New Braunfels

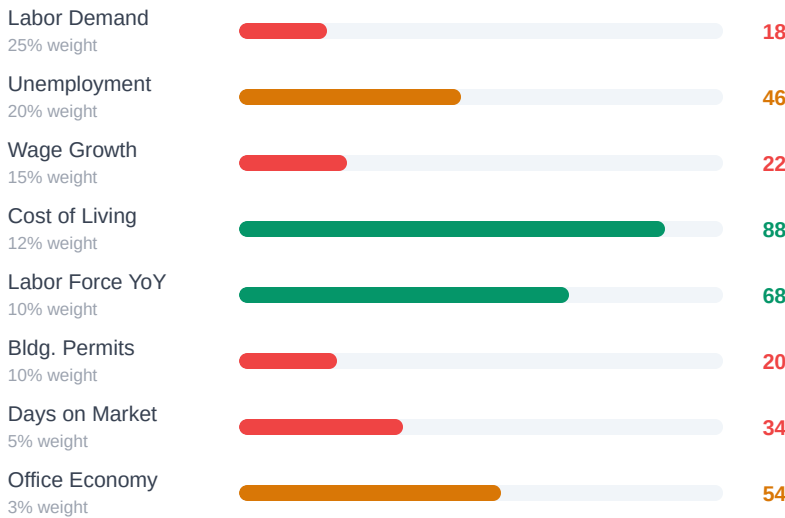
C+

POOR

39.7th percentile

Rank 36 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

3.8%
of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+1.6%
avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

+0.0%
nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY

+0.1%
civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS

-19.1%
residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

57 days
median, -1.7% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The San Antonio-New Braunfels metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it 39.7th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with a composite score in the bottom tier, and its highly affordable cost of living, ranked in the top tier at the 88th percentile. The labor demand metrics, including a mere 0.04% employment growth rate and -1.862% weekly hours deviation from trend, signal a weak labor market.

Labor Demand

The San Antonio-New Braunfels metro area has experienced a sluggish labor market, with employment growth of only 0.04% year-over-year and weekly hours 1.862% below its own trend. This combination signals a labor market contraction, rather than genuine demand expansion or survivor squeeze. The low labor demand composite score of 2.86, ranked in the bottom tier at the 18th percentile, reinforces this assessment.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in San Antonio-New Braunfels stands at 3.80%, ranking near the median at the 46th percentile. This indicates a labor market with some slack, rather than being extremely tight. For a business trying to hire in this city, the relatively moderate unemployment rate suggests that finding talent may be somewhat easier than in tighter labor markets, but may not be as straightforward as in areas with higher unemployment rates.

Wage Growth

Wage growth in the San Antonio-New Braunfels metro area has been below average, with a year-over-year increase of 1.63% in hourly earnings, ranking in the 22nd percentile. This moderate wage growth rate implies that labor costs for employers are rising, but not as quickly as in other areas, and worker purchasing power is increasing, albeit slowly. The slow wage growth may help keep labor costs in check for businesses, but it also means workers have less bargaining power.

Cost of Living

San Antonio-New Braunfels is relatively affordable, with a cost of living score ranked in the top tier at the 88th percentile. The city's price-to-salary ratio is \$173/sqft (with prices falling 5.0% year-over-year) to \$31.85/hr, resulting in a ratio of 5.43. This high affordability ranking means that the city has a talent attraction advantage, as workers can maintain a good standard of living without requiring significant wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in San Antonio-New Braunfels has grown 0.11% year-over-year, ranking above average at the 68th percentile. This positive growth rate indicates that the workforce supply is expanding, which is a positive sign for businesses looking to hire in the area. The growing labor force suggests that the city has the potential to support hiring needs, at least in terms of the sheer number of available workers.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in San Antonio-New Braunfels has decreased by 19.15% year-over-year, ranking below average at the 20th percentile. This decline in permits suggests that the housing supply is tightening, which could lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce. The sharp drop in building permits is a concern for businesses that rely on a steady supply of housing for their employees.

Days on Market

Homes in San Antonio-New Braunfels currently sit on the market for a median of 57 days, with a year-over-year decrease of 1.7%. This relatively fast pace of home sales, ranked below average at the 34th percentile, indicates a competitive market that may be challenging for relocating workers to find housing. The quick turnover in the housing market suggests that workers may face stiff competition when looking for a place to live.

Office Economy

The professional and office sectors in San Antonio-New Braunfels account for a share of jobs ranked near the median at the 54th percentile. This suggests a moderately deep talent pool, suitable for businesses that require specialized office workers, but not as strong as in cities with a more prominent knowledge economy. The city is likely well-suited for businesses that do not rely heavily on tech, finance, or consulting talent, but may not be the best fit for companies that require a highly specialized office workforce.

The San Antonio-New Braunfels metro area offers businesses an affordable cost of living and a growing labor force, but its low labor demand and tightening housing supply are significant concerns. The single biggest risk for a decision-maker to factor in is the potential for future affordability issues and workforce accommodation challenges, driven by the sharp decline in residential building permits, which could offset the city's current advantages and make it less attractive for businesses and workers alike.

Baltimore

Baltimore-Columbia-Towson

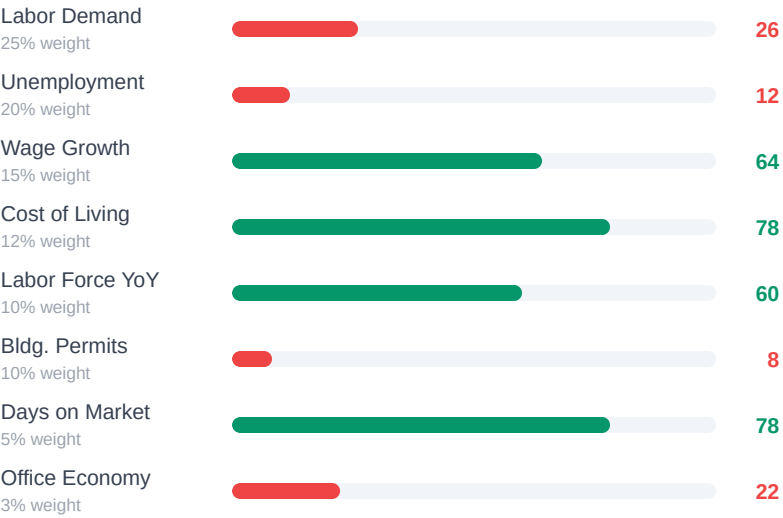
C+

POOR

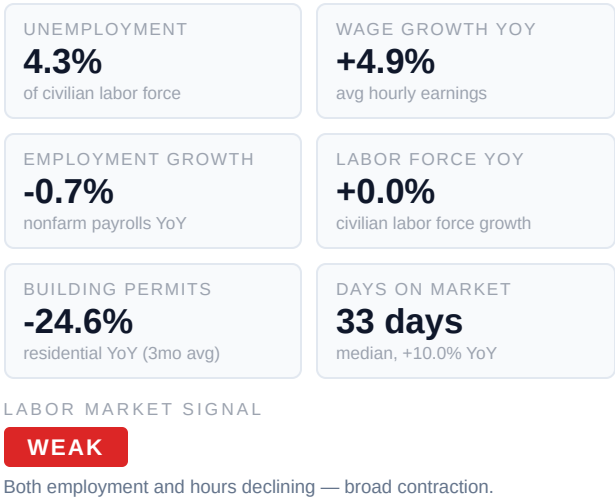
39.2th percentile

Rank 37 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Baltimore-Columbia-Towson metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it 39.2th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its below-average labor demand, with a composite score of 3.26, and its high cost of living affordability, ranking in the 78th percentile. The labor demand and cost of living metrics are the most influential in shaping the city's economic landscape, with employment growth at -0.74% and a cost of living ratio of \$221/sqft to \$36.90/hr.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Baltimore-Columbia-Towson is -0.74%, and weekly hours are deviating -0.249% from the city's own 12-month baseline, signaling a contraction in labor demand. This combination indicates a lack of genuine demand expansion, as hours are below trend during a period of job losses, suggesting a survivor squeeze where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles. The labor demand composite score of 3.26 ranks in the 26th percentile, further emphasizing the below-average labor market conditions.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Baltimore-Columbia-Towson is 4.30%, ranking in the 12th percentile, indicating a relatively loose labor market with some slack. This means that businesses may find it easier to hire workers, but the local consumer demand may be weaker due to the higher unemployment rate. The practical implication for a business trying to hire in this city is that they may have a larger pool of potential candidates to choose from.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Baltimore-Columbia-Towson is +4.92%, ranking in the 64th percentile, indicating relatively fast wage growth. This implies that employer labor costs are rising, and worker purchasing power is increasing. As a result, businesses may need to factor in higher labor costs, but workers will have more disposable income to spend in the local economy.

Cost of Living

Baltimore-Columbia-Towson has a cost of living ratio of \$221/sqft to \$36.90/hr, with the PSF falling -1.3% year-over-year, making it more affordable relative to peers, ranking in the 78th percentile. This means that the city has a talent attraction advantage, as workers can afford to live and work in the area without requiring significant wage premiums. The falling PSF is a key driver of the high affordability score, making the city more attractive to businesses and workers alike.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Baltimore-Columbia-Towson is growing at a rate of +0.01% year-over-year, ranking in the 60th percentile, indicating a slowly expanding labor force supply. This means that the hiring capacity in the city is relatively stable, with a slightly increasing pool of potential workers. However, the slow growth rate may not be enough to keep up with demand in certain industries.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Baltimore-Columbia-Towson has decreased by -24.64% year-over-year, ranking in the 8th percentile, indicating a tightening housing supply. This signals that future affordability and workforce accommodation may be at risk, as the supply of new housing is not keeping up with demand. The sharp decline in building permits is a concern for businesses that rely on a steady supply of skilled workers.

Days on Market

The current median days on market in Baltimore-Columbia-Towson is 33 days, with a year-over-year increase of +10.0%, ranking in the 78th percentile. This means that the housing market is slowing down, making it more accessible for workers relocating to the city. The rising days on market indicates a more competitive market for buyers, but also suggests that the city's housing market is normalizing.

Office Economy

Baltimore-Columbia-Towson has a professional and office worker share of 1.60, ranking in the 22nd percentile, indicating a relatively shallow talent pool in these sectors. This means that the city is less suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms. However, the city may be more attractive to businesses in other industries, such as logistics or manufacturing.

The Baltimore-Columbia-Towson metro area offers businesses a relatively affordable cost of living and a slowly expanding labor force, but the biggest risk or constraint is the tightening housing supply and the below-average labor demand. Decision-makers should factor in the potential challenges of attracting and retaining skilled workers in a city with a shallow professional talent pool and a slowing labor market.

Oklahoma City

Oklahoma City

C

VERY POOR

37.2th percentile

Rank 38 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand		10
25% weight		
Unemployment		30
20% weight		
Wage Growth		80
15% weight		
Cost of Living		90
12% weight		
Labor Force YoY		2
10% weight		
Bldg. Permits		10
10% weight		
Days on Market		94
5% weight		
Office Economy		2
3% weight		

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT 3.6% of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY +6.2% avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH -1.0% nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY -3.0% civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS -24.3% residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET 49 days median, +13.9% YoY
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL SQUEEZE Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Oklahoma City has an overall grade of C, ranking 37.2th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its low labor demand and labor force growth, which are both in the bottom tier. The city's labor demand composite score is 2.28, with employment growth at -0.96% year-over-year, and its labor force growth is -3.01% year-over-year. These metrics define the city's current economic character as one with significant challenges in job market expansion and workforce supply.

Labor Demand

Oklahoma City's employment growth rate is -0.96% year-over-year, and weekly hours are 0.677% above the city's own trend, signaling a survivor squeeze where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles. This combination indicates that the job market is not expanding, and the increase in hours worked is likely due to the remaining workforce taking on more responsibilities. The labor demand composite score of 2.28 is in the bottom tier, reflecting the city's struggles with job growth.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Oklahoma City is 3.60%, which is below average, ranking in the 30th percentile. This indicates a relatively tight labor market, making it harder for businesses to hire and potentially leading to upward pressure on wages. As a result, companies may face challenges in finding and recruiting talent in this market.

Wage Growth

Oklahoma City has a year-over-year wage growth rate of 6.23%, which is in the top tier, ranking in the 80th percentile. This fast wage growth rate implies rising labor costs for employers, but it also means that workers have stronger purchasing power. As a result, businesses may need to consider the potential impact of increasing wages on their cost structure.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of \$173/sqft to \$33.90/hr, Oklahoma City is relatively affordable, ranking in the 90th percentile. The fact that PSF is falling by 0.6% year-over-year relative to wages further supports this affordability. This makes the city attractive for talent, as workers can maintain a good standard of living without requiring significant wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Oklahoma City is shrinking at a rate of -3.01% year-over-year, indicating a contracting labor pool. This decline in labor force growth poses a significant structural headwind for hiring, as the supply of potential workers is decreasing. Businesses may need to consider strategies to attract and retain talent in this environment.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Oklahoma City has decreased by 24.28% year-over-year, indicating a tightening housing supply. This sharp decline in building permits signals that future affordability and workforce accommodation may be at risk, as the supply of new housing is not keeping pace with demand.

Days on Market

Homes in Oklahoma City are currently sitting on the market for 49 days, with a year-over-year increase of 13.9%. This slower market, ranking in the 94th percentile, means that workers relocating to the city may find it more accessible to find a home, as the market is less competitive.

Office Economy

Oklahoma City has a relatively shallow professional talent pool, ranking in the 2nd percentile. This makes the city less suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms. However, it may be more suitable for industries with fewer specialized roles, such as industrial or logistics-dominant economies.

In conclusion, Oklahoma City offers a relatively affordable cost of living and a competitive wage growth environment, but it is constrained by a tight labor market, declining labor force growth, and a shrinking housing supply. The single biggest risk or constraint for businesses considering this location is the limited supply of skilled workers and the potential for future affordability issues, which could impact their ability to attract and retain talent.

Boston

Boston-Cambridge-Newton

C

VERY POOR

36.6th percentile

Rank 39 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand		36
25% weight		
Unemployment		20
20% weight		
Wage Growth		48
15% weight		
Cost of Living		24
12% weight		
Labor Force YoY		98
10% weight		
Bldg. Permits		18
10% weight		
Days on Market		2
5% weight		
Office Economy		60
3% weight		

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT of civilian labor force 3.9%	WAGE GROWTH YOY avg hourly earnings +3.7%
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH nonfarm payrolls YoY -0.4%	LABOR FORCE YOY civilian labor force growth +2.9%
BUILDING PERMITS residential YoY (3mo avg) -20.6%	DAYS ON MARKET median, -3.9% YoY 25 days
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL WEAK Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Boston-Cambridge-Newton metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 36.6th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a labor demand composite score of 3.73. This city's economic character is most defined by its below-average labor demand, with a -0.41% employment growth rate and -0.399% weekly hours deviation from its own trend, as well as its high labor force growth rate of +2.87% YoY. The combination of these metrics suggests a complex economic environment.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Boston-Cambridge-Newton is -0.41% YoY, and weekly hours are deviating -0.399% from the city's own 12-month trend. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, indicating that the city is experiencing a decline in job growth and hours worked. This suggests that businesses may face less competition for workers, but also may indicate a slowing economy.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Boston-Cambridge-Newton is 3.90%, which is below average, ranking in the 20th percentile. This indicates a relatively tight labor market, making it harder for businesses to hire workers and potentially leading to upward pressure on wages. As a result, businesses may need to offer competitive salaries to attract top talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Boston-Cambridge-Newton is +3.66%, which is near the median, ranking in the 48th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively so, and that workers have relatively stable purchasing power. This could be beneficial for businesses looking to balance labor costs with worker satisfaction.

Cost of Living

Boston-Cambridge-Newton has a cost of living score that ranks in the 24th percentile, with a PSF of \$497/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$46.24/hr, resulting in a ratio of 10.75. This indicates that the city is relatively expensive, which could make it challenging for businesses to attract talent without offering wage premiums. The fact that PSF is falling -1.6% YoY is a positive sign, but the city's overall affordability remains a concern.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Boston-Cambridge-Newton is growing at a rate of +2.87% YoY, which is in the top tier, ranking in the 98th percentile. This suggests that the workforce supply is expanding, providing businesses with a growing pool of potential workers. This could be beneficial for companies looking to hire and expand their operations.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Boston-Cambridge-Newton has decreased by -20.56% YoY, which is in the bottom tier, ranking in the 18th percentile. This indicates that housing supply is tightening, which could lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce. This may be a concern for businesses that rely on a stable and affordable housing market for their employees.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Boston-Cambridge-Newton is 25 days, with a YoY decrease of -3.9%. This suggests that the housing market is highly competitive, with homes selling quickly. This could make it challenging for relocating workers to find affordable housing, potentially impacting a business's ability to attract and retain talent.

Office Economy

Boston-Cambridge-Newton has a deep professional talent pool, with an office economy score ranking in the 60th percentile. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, which require a high concentration of specialized workers. However, the city may be less suitable for industries that require a large workforce in industrial or logistics roles.

The Boston-Cambridge-Newton metro area offers businesses a highly educated and growing workforce, but also presents challenges such as a tight labor market, high cost of living, and tightening housing supply. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's affordability issues, which could impact a business's ability to attract and retain top talent without offering significant wage premiums.

Milwaukee

Milwaukee-Waukesha

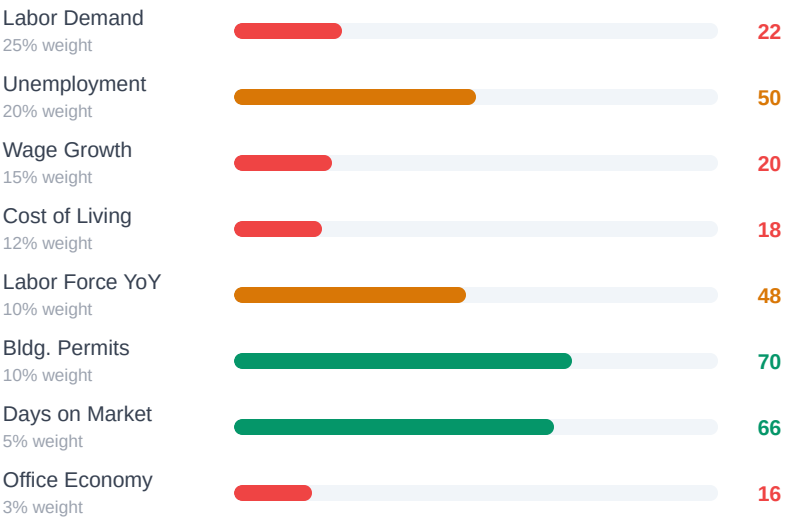
C

VERY POOR

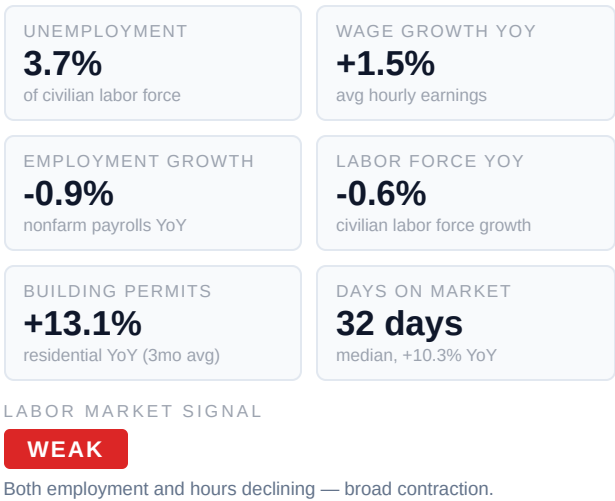
36.3th percentile

Rank 40 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Milwaukee-Waukesha metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 36.3th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a labor demand composite score of 3.03, which is below average at the 22th percentile. This city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand and high cost of living, with a PSF to wages ratio of 6.29, ranking in the bottom tier at the 18th percentile. The combination of -0.91% employment growth and -0.049% weekly hours deviation signals a contraction in labor demand.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate is -0.91% and weekly hours are deviating -0.049% from the city's own trend, indicating a contraction in labor demand. This combination signals a lack of genuine demand expansion, with the labor market experiencing a slowdown. The low labor demand composite score of 3.03 further reinforces this notion.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate is 3.70%, which is near the median at the 50th percentile, indicating a relatively balanced labor market with neither significant slack nor tightness. This means that businesses trying to hire in this city will face moderate competition for talent, but not extreme pressure. The market is not particularly tight, so wage pressure is manageable.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate is +1.49%, which is below average at the 20th percentile, indicating stagnant wage growth. This slow wage growth means that employer labor costs are not rising rapidly, but worker purchasing power is also not increasing significantly. The implication is a flat cost environment, but with limited bargaining power for workers.

Cost of Living

The city has a cost of living score ranking in the bottom tier at the 18th percentile, with a PSF to wages ratio of 6.29, indicating that it is relatively expensive. The PSF is \$227/sqft and rising at +2.2% YoY, making it less affordable for talent to relocate without wage premiums. This high cost of living is a talent attraction disadvantage.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is growing at -0.58% year-over-year, which is near the median at the 48th percentile, indicating a slightly contracting labor pool. This means that the supply of workers is not expanding, creating a structural headwind for hiring. Businesses may face challenges in finding and recruiting talent in this shrinking labor pool.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is +13.09%, which is above average at the 70th percentile, indicating an expansion in housing supply. This rising permit activity signals that housing supply is expanding, which should improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce. The increase in building permits is a positive sign for future workforce attraction.

Days on Market

The median days on market is 32 days, with a +10.3% year-over-year increase, ranking above average at the 66th percentile. This means that homes are sitting on the market for a relatively longer period, indicating a slower and more accessible market for relocating workers. The rising days on market suggests a healthy normalization of the housing market.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers is ranked in the bottom tier at the 16th percentile, indicating a relatively shallow talent pool. This city is less suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms. Instead, it may be more suitable for industrial or logistics-dominant businesses.

The Milwaukee-Waukesha metro area offers a business a relatively slow-growing labor market with moderate unemployment and stagnant wage growth. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for a decision-maker is the high cost of living, which may require wage premiums to attract talent, making it a less competitive location for businesses seeking to relocate or expand.

Washington DC

Washington-Arlington-Alexandria

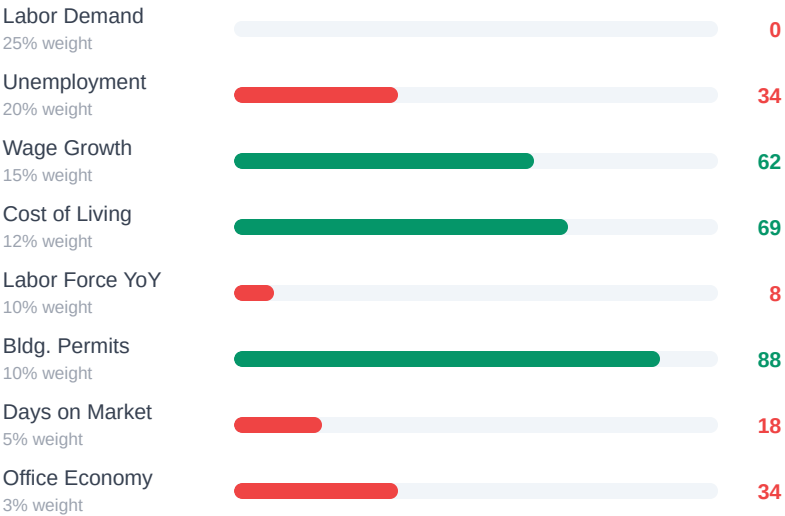
C

VERY POOR

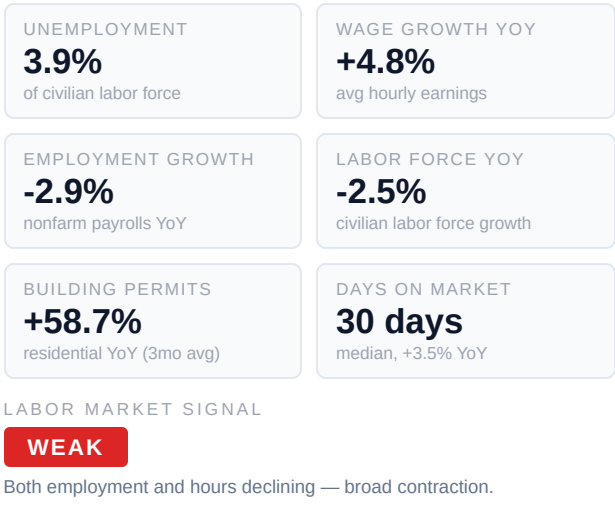
35.9th percentile

Rank 41 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Washington-Arlington-Alexandria metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 35.9th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score largely defined by its weak labor demand and slow labor force growth. The labor demand composite score of 1.50, combining a -2.86% employment growth rate and a -0.505% weekly hours deviation from trend, signals a contraction in job opportunities. This, coupled with a labor force growth rate of -2.52%, paints a challenging picture for businesses looking to expand or relocate in this area.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria is -2.86% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating -0.505% from the city's own 12-month baseline, indicating a clear contraction in labor demand. This combination signals a lack of genuine demand expansion, suggesting that the area is not adding jobs at a pace that would support business growth. The negative hours deviation alongside negative employment growth points to a straightforward contraction rather than a survivor squeeze.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria stands at 3.90%, placing it in the 34th percentile, which is below average. This rate indicates a relatively tight labor market, suggesting that there is less slack and potentially more competition for hiring. For a business trying to hire in this area, the implication is that it may face challenges in finding suitable candidates, potentially leading to higher wage offers to attract talent.

Wage Growth

Wage growth in the area is +4.85% year-over-year, ranking in the 62nd percentile, which is above average. This level of wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, which can be beneficial for worker purchasing power but may pose a challenge for businesses looking to keep costs under control. The relatively fast wage growth indicates a competitive labor market where workers have stronger bargaining power.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of \$310/sqft to \$44.71/hr, resulting in a ratio of 6.93, and considering the PSF is falling -3.1% year-over-year, Washington-Arlington-Alexandria ranks in the 69th percentile for affordability. This high percentile rank means the city is more affordable relative to its peers, which can be a significant advantage for talent attraction without needing to offer wage premiums. The falling PSF relative to wages is a key driver of this affordability.

Labor Force Growth

The labor force in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria is growing at a rate of -2.52% year-over-year, indicating a contraction in the supply of potential workers. This negative growth rate suggests that the labor pool is shrinking, posing a structural headwind for hiring and business expansion. Businesses may find it challenging to find new talent as the labor force contracts.

Building Permits

The area has seen a +58.73% year-over-year increase in residential building permits, placing it in the 88th percentile. This significant rise in permits signals that housing supply is expanding, which should improve affordability and accommodate workforce growth in the future. The increase in building permits is a positive indicator for future workforce attraction and retention.

Days on Market

Homes in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria are currently sitting on the market for 30 days, with a year-over-year increase of +3.5%. This increase in days on market, although still relatively fast at 30 days, suggests a slight normalization in the housing market. For a worker relocating to this city, the market remains competitive but is becoming slightly more accessible.

Office Economy

The share of jobs in professional and office sectors in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria places it in the 34th percentile, indicating a below-average depth of professional talent pool. This city is less suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech, finance, consulting, or HQ decisions, but may be more appropriate for industries with different workforce needs.

The Washington-Arlington-Alexandria metro area offers a mixed bag for businesses, with advantages in affordability and wage growth but significant challenges in labor demand and labor force growth. The single biggest risk or constraint for a decision-maker considering this location is the weak labor market conditions, which could hinder hiring and business expansion plans. Despite some positive indicators like increasing building permits, the overall economic character suggests caution and careful consideration of these factors before making a location decision.

Detroit

Detroit-Warren-Dearborn

C

VERY POOR

35.6th percentile

Rank 42 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand 25% weight		20
Unemployment 20% weight		22
Wage Growth 15% weight		30
Cost of Living 12% weight		51
Labor Force YoY 10% weight		56
Bldg. Permits 10% weight		40
Days on Market 5% weight		90
Office Economy 3% weight		48

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT of civilian labor force 4.4%	WAGE GROWTH YOY +2.3% avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH nonfarm payrolls YoY -0.9%	LABOR FORCE YOY -0.1% civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS residential YoY (3mo avg) -7.4%	DAYS ON MARKET 38 days median, +8.6% YoY
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL WEAK Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Detroit-Warren-Dearborn metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 35.6th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its below-average labor demand and unemployment rates, specifically -0.93% employment growth YoY and 4.40% unemployment rate. The city's economic character is defined by these metrics, indicating a challenging environment for businesses looking to expand or relocate. With a labor demand composite score of 3.00, ranking in the 20th percentile, the city faces significant headwinds in terms of job growth and hours worked.

Labor Demand

The Detroit-Warren-Dearborn metro area has an employment growth rate of -0.93% YoY and weekly hours deviation of -0.632% from its own 12-month baseline, signaling a contraction in labor demand. This combination indicates a lack of genuine demand expansion, with fewer jobs being added and hours worked below trend. As a result, businesses may face a challenging environment in terms of finding skilled workers and managing workload.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is 4.40%, ranking in the 22nd percentile, indicating a degree of slack in the labor market. While this may make it easier for businesses to hire, it also suggests weaker local consumer demand. However, the relatively high unemployment rate compared to other metros may provide some relief for businesses looking to staff their operations without excessive wage pressure.

Wage Growth

The YoY wage growth rate in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is +2.32%, ranking in the 30th percentile, indicating moderate wage growth. This rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but at a slower pace than in many other metros, which may help maintain profitability. Meanwhile, workers in the area will see some improvement in their purchasing power, although it may not be as strong as in other regions.

Cost of Living

Detroit-Warren-Dearborn has a cost of living score ranking in the 51st percentile, with a PSF of \$183/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$37.15/hr, resulting in a ratio of 4.93. This indicates that the city is near the median in terms of affordability, neither particularly expensive nor cheap compared to its peers. As a result, businesses may not need to offer significant wage premiums to attract talent, although the city's affordability advantage is not particularly strong.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is growing at a rate of -0.07% YoY, ranking in the 56th percentile, indicating a nearly stagnant labor force. This suggests that the supply of workers is not expanding, which may pose a structural headwind for hiring and business growth in the area. Businesses looking to expand their operations may need to consider strategies to attract workers from other regions or invest in training and development programs.

Building Permits

The YoY change in building permits in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is -7.41%, ranking in the 40th percentile, indicating a tightening of housing supply. This signals that future affordability and workforce accommodation may be at risk, as the supply of new housing units is not keeping pace with demand. As a result, businesses may need to consider the potential impact of rising housing costs on their employees' quality of life and their ability to attract and retain talent.

Days on Market

The current median days on market in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is 38 days, with a YoY increase of 8.6%, ranking in the 90th percentile. This indicates a slower market, where homes are taking longer to sell, making it more accessible for workers relocating to the city. However, this may also suggest a degree of softness in the local real estate market, which could have implications for businesses looking to attract talent or invest in the area.

Office Economy

The share of jobs in professional and office sectors in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is 2.54, ranking in the 48th percentile, indicating a moderate depth of professional talent pool. This suggests that the city is suited for businesses that require a mix of industrial and professional skills, but may not be the best fit for businesses that require a deep pool of specialized office or tech talent. As a result, businesses in the tech, finance, or consulting sectors may need to consider alternative locations with stronger professional talent pools.

The Detroit-Warren-Dearborn metro area offers businesses a relatively affordable cost of living and a moderate wage growth environment, but its below-average labor demand and stagnant labor force growth pose significant risks. The single biggest constraint for businesses considering relocation or expansion in this area is the challenging labor market, which may require significant investment in talent attraction and retention strategies to overcome.

Portland

Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro

C

VERY POOR

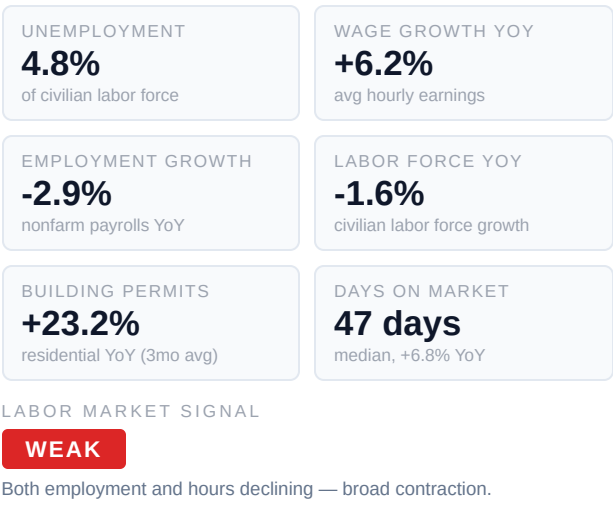
35.3th percentile

Rank 43 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 35.3th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its poor labor demand and labor force growth metrics, which are both in the bottom tier. The labor demand composite score of 1.50, combining a -2.85% employment growth rate and a -0.220% weekly hours deviation from trend, signals a contraction in labor demand. This, coupled with a labor force growth rate of -1.57%, defines the city's current economic character as one of shrinking workforce supply and diminishing job opportunities.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro is -2.85% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating -0.220% from the city's own 12-month baseline, indicating a clear contraction in labor demand rather than genuine demand expansion or survivor squeeze. This combination suggests that the city is experiencing a reduction in job openings and hours worked, which can lead to a surplus of labor. The labor demand composite score of 1.50 is in the bottom tier, reinforcing this interpretation.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro is 4.80%, which, although not extremely high, indicates some slack in the labor market, ranking in the bottom tier at the 12th percentile. This suggests that while it may not be extremely difficult to hire, the market does have some available labor, potentially mitigating some wage pressure. However, for businesses looking to hire, this rate implies a slightly easier staffing environment compared to tighter labor markets.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro is +6.21%, placing it in the above-average category at the 78th percentile. This rate of wage growth is relatively fast, implying rising labor costs for employers but also increased purchasing power for workers. Businesses should anticipate higher compensation costs, but the local workforce will have more disposable income, potentially benefiting consumer-facing industries.

Cost of Living

Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro has a cost of living score that ranks in the above-average percentile (65th percentile), with a PSF to earnings ratio of \$310/sqft to \$42.24/hr, or 7.34. Given that PSF is falling by -2.5% year-over-year, this indicates a relatively affordable environment compared to peer cities. This affordability could serve as a talent attraction advantage, as workers may not require significant wage premiums to maintain their standard of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro is shrinking at a rate of -1.57% year-over-year, indicating a contracting labor supply. This negative growth rate suggests that the pool of potential workers is decreasing, which could pose a structural headwind for businesses looking to hire and expand in the area.

Building Permits

The city is experiencing a +23.17% year-over-year increase in residential building permits, which is above average, ranking in the 76th percentile. This significant increase in permits suggests that housing supply is expanding, which could improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce in the future, mitigating potential housing-related challenges for relocating workers.

Days on Market

Homes in Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro are currently sitting on the market for a median of 47 days, with a year-over-year increase of +6.8%, ranking in the above-average percentile (74th percentile). This indicates a slightly slower market, which could make it more accessible for workers relocating to the city, as they may have more time to find suitable housing without facing extreme competition.

Office Economy

The share of jobs in professional and office sectors in Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro is relatively low, ranking in the bottom tier at the 8th percentile. This suggests that the city's talent pool, while present, is not as deep in professional and office skills as in other metros, making it less suited for businesses heavily reliant on tech, finance, consulting, or HQ operations, but potentially more favorable for industries with different skill requirements.

The Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro metro area offers a mix of affordability and rising wages, which could attract certain types of businesses, especially those not heavily dependent on a deep professional talent pool. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for a decision-maker considering this location is the shrinking labor force and poor labor demand, which could significantly hinder hiring and expansion plans, making it crucial to carefully weigh these factors against the city's advantages.

Grand Rapids

Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood

C

VERY POOR

34.5th percentile

Rank 44 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand		42
25% weight		
Unemployment		84
20% weight		
Wage Growth		38
15% weight		
Cost of Living		4
12% weight		
Labor Force YoY		0
10% weight		
Bldg. Permits		4
10% weight		
Days on Market		6
5% weight		
Office Economy		10
3% weight		

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT 3.6% of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY +3.0% avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH -0.1% nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY -7.0% civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS -30.9% residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET 30 days median, -3.2% YoY
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL WEAK Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 34.5th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a labor demand composite score of 4.16. This city's economic character is most defined by its low unemployment rate of 3.60% and its bottom-tier labor force growth rate of -6.97% YoY. The combination of these metrics suggests a tight labor market with limited workforce expansion.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate is -0.10% YoY, and weekly hours are deviating -0.605% from the city's own 12-month baseline, indicating a contraction in labor demand. This combination signals a survivor squeeze, where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles. The labor demand composite score of 4.16 is near the median, ranking 42nd percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate is 3.60%, ranking in the top tier at the 84th percentile, indicating a tight labor market with limited slack. This means that businesses trying to hire in this city will face significant competition for talent, leading to potential wage pressure. The low unemployment rate suggests that workers have strong bargaining power.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate is +2.97%, which is below average, ranking 38th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate implies that labor costs for employers are rising, but at a slower pace than in many other cities. Workers in this city will see some increase in purchasing power, but it may not be as strong as in other areas.

Cost of Living

The city has a cost of living ratio of 6.88, with a PSF of \$224/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$32.55/hr, ranking in the bottom tier at the 4th percentile. This means that the city is relatively expensive compared to peers, making it challenging to attract talent without offering wage premiums. The 8.7% YoY increase in PSF further exacerbates the affordability issue.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is contracting at a rate of -6.97% YoY, indicating a shrinking labor pool. This significant decline in labor force growth implies a structural headwind for hiring, making it challenging for businesses to find and retain talent. The limited workforce expansion will constrain business growth in this city.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is -30.86%, indicating a sharp decline in housing supply. This tightening of housing supply signals potential future affordability issues and workforce accommodation challenges, making it harder for workers to

relocate to this city.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 30 days, with a -3.2% YoY change, ranking in the bottom tier at the 6th percentile. This relatively fast market means that homes are selling quickly, making it competitive for relocating workers to find housing. However, the slight decrease in days on market may indicate a minor normalization in the housing market.

Office Economy

The city has a professional and office worker share of 0.84, ranking in the bottom tier at the 10th percentile, indicating a relatively shallow talent pool. This city is best suited for businesses that do not require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as industrial or logistics companies, and is less suited for tech, finance, or consulting firms.

The Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood metro area offers businesses a tight labor market with low unemployment, but this comes with significant challenges, including a shrinking labor force and limited workforce expansion. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's low labor force growth rate, which will require businesses to be highly competitive in attracting and retaining talent.

Sacramento

Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom

C

VERY POOR

34.3th percentile

Rank 45 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand		54
25% weight		
Unemployment		36
20% weight		
Wage Growth		14
15% weight		
Cost of Living		14
12% weight		
Labor Force YoY		16
10% weight		
Bldg. Permits		32
10% weight		
Days on Market		86
5% weight		
Office Economy		24
3% weight		

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT 4.5% of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY +1.1% avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH +0.4% nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY -1.7% civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS -13.7% residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET 41 days median, +7.9% YoY
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL GROWING Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 34.3th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score reflecting a mix of mediocre labor demand and high cost of living. The city's economic character is most defined by its low wage growth, at +1.14% year-over-year, and its high cost of living, with a PSF to wages ratio of 9.01. These metrics signal a challenging environment for businesses looking to attract and retain talent.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom is +0.44% year-over-year, while weekly hours are -0.101% below trend, indicating a moderate labor demand expansion. This combination signals genuine demand expansion, albeit at a slow pace. The labor demand composite score of 4.81 is near the median, suggesting a balanced but unremarkable job market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom is 4.50%, ranking below average at the 36th percentile. This indicates a moderate level of slack in the labor market, making it relatively easier for businesses to hire compared to tighter markets. However, the unemployment rate is not low enough to suggest a highly competitive market for workers.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom is +1.14%, ranking in the bottom tier at the 14th percentile. This slow wage growth suggests a flat cost environment for employers, but also implies weak bargaining power for workers. As a result, businesses may not face significant pressure to increase wages, but workers may not have strong purchasing power.

Cost of Living

Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom has a cost of living percentile rank of 14, indicating a relatively expensive city. The PSF to wages ratio is 9.01, with PSF at \$344/sqft and wages at \$38.20/hr. This high cost of living may make it challenging for businesses to attract talent without offering wage premiums, as the city's affordability is below average compared to peers.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom is contracting at a rate of -1.68% year-over-year, ranking in the bottom tier at the 16th percentile. This decline in labor force supply suggests a structural headwind for hiring, making it more challenging for businesses to find and retain workers.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom has decreased by -13.71% year-over-year, ranking below average at the 32nd percentile. This decline in building permits suggests a tightening housing supply, which may lead to decreased affordability and increased competition for workforce accommodation in the future.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom is 41 days, with a year-over-year increase of +7.9%, ranking in the top tier at the 86th percentile. This slower market suggests a more accessible and less competitive environment for workers relocating to the city, as homes are taking longer to sell.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom is below average, ranking at the 24th percentile. This suggests a relatively shallow talent pool for businesses in the tech, finance, or consulting sectors, making the city less suited for these types of companies. However, the city may be more suitable for industrial or logistics-dominant businesses.

The Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom metro area offers businesses a relatively slow-paced labor market with moderate unemployment, but also presents challenges such as high cost of living and slow wage growth. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's declining labor force supply, which may limit hiring capacity and require businesses to offer competitive wages to attract and retain talent.

Louisville

Louisville-Jefferson County

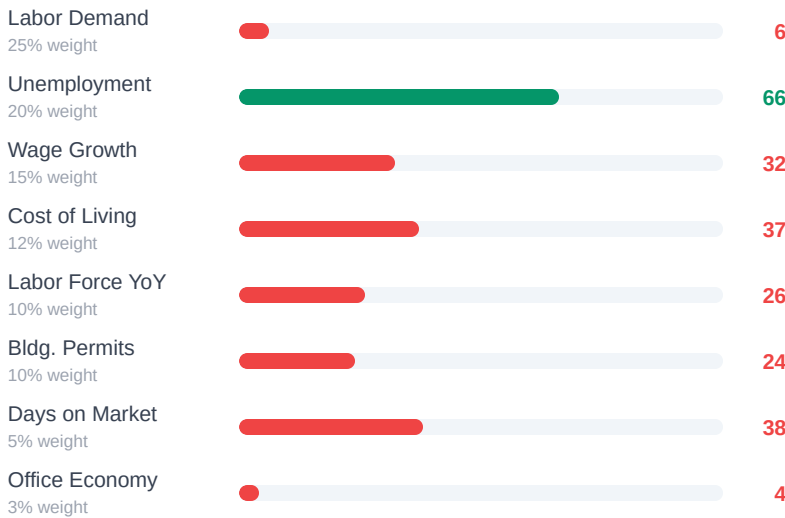
C-

CRITICAL

30.9th percentile

Rank 46 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

4.0%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+2.3%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

-0.8%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY

-1.4%

civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS

-18.6%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

38 days

median, 0.0% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Louisville-Jefferson County metro area has an overall grade of C- with a composite score ranking it 30.9th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its labor demand and unemployment metrics, with a labor demand composite score of 1.91 ranking in the bottom tier at the 6th percentile, and an unemployment rate of 4.00% ranking above average at the 66th percentile. Specifically, the employment growth rate of -0.80% and weekly hours deviation of +1.270% are key indicators of the city's current economic state.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Louisville-Jefferson County is -0.80%, indicating a contraction in job growth, while the weekly hours deviation is +1.270%, signaling that remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles, a phenomenon known as survivor squeeze. This combination suggests that the city is not experiencing genuine demand expansion. The labor demand composite score of 1.91 ranks in the bottom tier at the 6th percentile, further emphasizing the city's struggling labor market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Louisville-Jefferson County is 4.00%, ranking above average at the 66th percentile, which means the market has some slack. For a business trying to hire in this city, the relatively higher unemployment rate implies that it may be easier to find candidates, but it also suggests weaker local consumer demand. However, the unemployment rate is not extremely high, so businesses may still face some competition for top talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Louisville-Jefferson County is +2.34%, ranking below average at the 32nd percentile, indicating moderate wage growth. This rate suggests that employer labor costs are rising, but not extremely quickly, and worker purchasing power is increasing, but not at a rapid pace. As a result, businesses may need to balance their labor costs with the need to attract and retain talent in a moderately growing wage environment.

Cost of Living

Louisville-Jefferson County has a cost of living score ranking below average at the 37th percentile, with a PSF to earnings ratio of \$180/sqft to \$31.28/hr, resulting in a ratio of 5.75. This means the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers. The lack of affordability may make it challenging for businesses to attract talent without offering wage premiums, as the city's cost of living is not particularly competitive.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Louisville-Jefferson County is shrinking at a rate of -1.41% year-over-year, ranking below average at the 26th percentile. This contraction in labor force supply implies that businesses may face structural headwinds when trying to hire, as the pool of available workers is decreasing. As a result, companies may need to invest more in recruitment and training to find the talent they need.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Louisville-Jefferson County has decreased by -18.58% year-over-year, ranking below average at the 24th percentile. This decline in permits suggests that the housing supply is tightening, which may lead to decreased affordability and increased competition for housing in the future. This could pose a risk to businesses trying to attract and retain workers who need affordable housing options.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Louisville-Jefferson County is 38 days, with a year-over-year change of +0.0%, ranking below average at the 38th percentile. This means that homes are selling at a moderate pace, neither extremely fast nor slow. For workers relocating to this city, the housing market is relatively accessible, but not extremely competitive, making it easier for them to find and purchase a home.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Louisville-Jefferson County is 0.44, ranking in the bottom tier at the 4th percentile. This indicates a relatively shallow talent pool for businesses that require specialized office or professional skills. As a result, this city may be better suited for businesses that do not rely heavily on a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as industrial or logistics companies, rather than tech, finance, or consulting firms.

The Louisville-Jefferson County metro area offers businesses a relatively affordable labor market, but its struggling labor demand, shrinking labor force, and tightening housing supply pose significant risks. The single biggest constraint for decision-makers is the city's limited labor force growth and declining housing affordability, which may hinder businesses' ability to attract and retain top talent.

Riverside

Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario

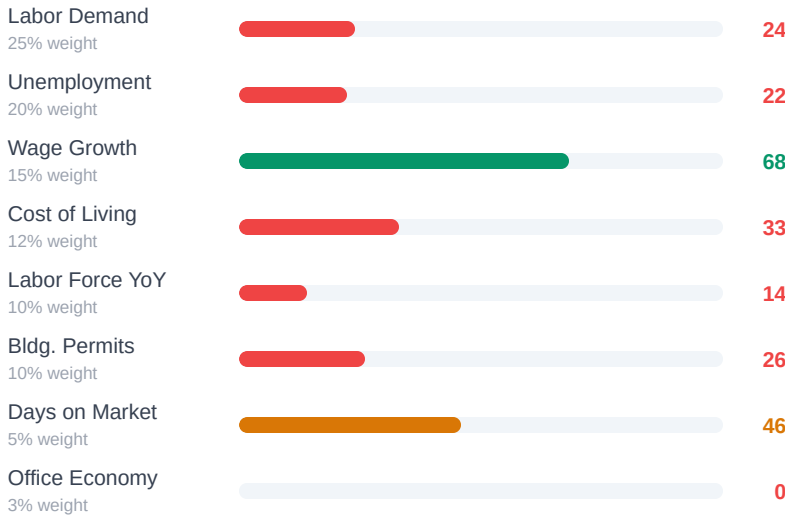
C-

CRITICAL

30.8th percentile

Rank 47 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

4.9%
of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+5.4%
avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

+0.0%
nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY

-2.2%
civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS

-18.1%
residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

56 days
median, +5.7% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario metro area has an overall grade of C- with a composite score ranking it 30.8th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its below-average labor demand, with a composite score of 3.03 ranking it in the 24th percentile, and its above-average wage growth of 5.40% year-over-year. The combination of low employment growth and declining weekly hours suggests a labor market with limited expansion.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario is a mere 0.01% year-over-year, while weekly hours are deviating -1.281% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a labor market that is not experiencing genuine demand expansion, but rather a potential survivor squeeze where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles. The labor demand composite score of 3.03, ranking in the 24th percentile, further supports this assessment.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario is 4.90%, ranking in the 22nd percentile, indicating a labor market with some slack. This means that businesses may find it relatively easier to hire in this market, but may also face weaker local consumer demand. The unemployment rate suggests that the market is not overly tight, giving employers some flexibility in their hiring decisions.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario is 5.40%, ranking in the 68th percentile, indicating a relatively fast pace of wage growth. This implies that employer labor costs are rising, but worker purchasing power is also increasing. The strong wage growth may attract workers to the area, but also poses a challenge for businesses looking to keep labor costs under control.

Cost of Living

Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario has a cost of living score ranking it in the 33rd percentile, with a price-to-salary ratio of \$337/sqft to \$35.23/hr, or 9.57. The fact that the PSF is falling -2.3% year-over-year is a key driver of the city's relatively affordable ranking. This means that the city may have a talent attraction advantage, as workers can afford to live in the area without requiring significant wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario is shrinking at a rate of -2.20% year-over-year, ranking in the 14th percentile. This indicates that the labor force supply is contracting, posing a structural headwind for hiring in the area. Businesses may face challenges in finding qualified workers, as the pool of available labor is decreasing.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario is declining at a rate of -18.08% year-over-year, ranking in the 26th percentile. This suggests that housing supply is tightening, which may lead to future affordability challenges and make it harder for workers to relocate to the area. The decline in building permits is a concern for businesses that rely on a steady supply of new housing to attract and retain workers.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario is currently 56 days, with a year-over-year increase of 5.7%, ranking in the 46th percentile. This indicates a relatively balanced market, where homes are not selling extremely quickly, but also not sitting on the market for too long. For workers relocating to the area, this suggests a moderately competitive market, where they may have some time to find a suitable home.

Office Economy

Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario has a very shallow professional talent pool, ranking in the 0th percentile. This makes the city less suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms. However, the city may be more suitable for businesses with industrial or logistics-oriented economies.

The Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario metro area offers businesses a relatively affordable cost of living and a labor market with some slack, but also poses significant challenges, including a shrinking labor force and tightening housing supply. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the limited labor force growth, which may make it difficult for businesses to find and retain qualified workers in the area.

Minneapolis

Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington

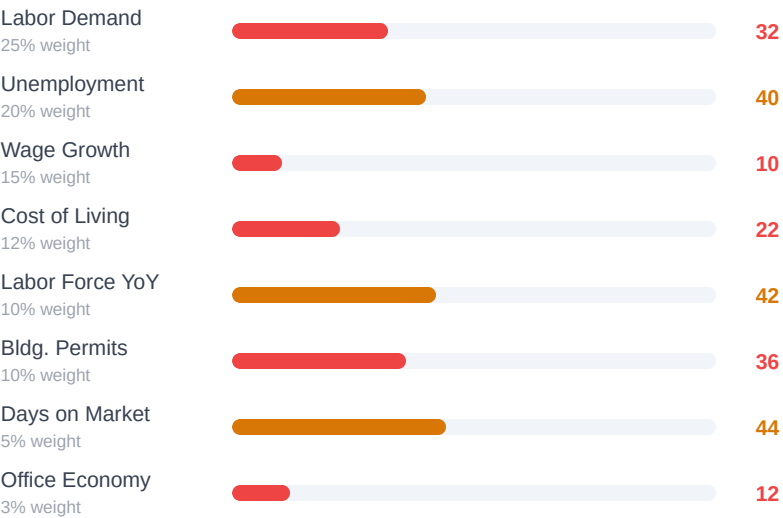
C-

CRITICAL

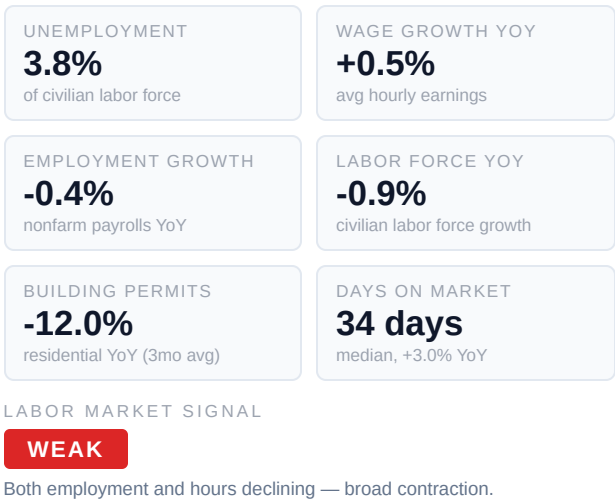
30.6th percentile

Rank 48 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington metro area has an overall grade of C- with a composite score ranking it 30.6th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its labor demand composite score of 3.68, ranking it in the 32nd percentile, and its wage growth rate of +0.51% year-over-year, placing it in the bottom tier at the 10th percentile. These metrics suggest a challenging environment for businesses looking to expand or relocate.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington is -0.44% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating -0.099% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, indicating that the city is not experiencing genuine demand expansion. Instead, it may be facing a period of payrolls contracting or hours below trend.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington is 3.80%, ranking it near the median at the 40th percentile. This suggests that the labor market has some slack, making it slightly easier for businesses to hire compared to tighter markets. However, the relatively low unemployment rate still implies some level of competition for talent, which could lead to moderate wage pressure.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington is +0.51%, placing it in the bottom tier at the 10th percentile. This stagnant wage growth environment means that labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly, but it also indicates weak bargaining power for workers. As a result, worker purchasing power is not increasing significantly.

Cost of Living

Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington has a cost of living score ranking it in the 22nd percentile, with a price per square foot of \$214 and average hourly earnings of \$39.19, resulting in a ratio of 5.46. This suggests that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers. The fact that PSF is falling -0.5% year-over-year is a positive sign, but overall, the city's affordability is a challenge, making it harder to attract talent without offering wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington is growing at a rate of -0.90% year-over-year, indicating that the labor force supply is contracting. This contraction poses a structural headwind for hiring, as businesses may face challenges in finding the talent they need to expand or maintain operations.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits in Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington is -11.97%, signaling a tightening of the housing supply. This decline in building permits suggests that future affordability and workforce accommodation may be at risk, as the supply of new housing units is not keeping pace with demand.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington is 34 days, with a year-over-year increase of 3.0%. This indicates a slightly slower market, which could be beneficial for relocating workers as it provides them with more time to find a home. However, the market is still relatively competitive, and workers may face some challenges in finding suitable housing.

Office Economy

Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington has an office economy score ranking it in the 12th percentile, indicating a relatively shallow professional talent pool. This city is best suited for businesses that do not require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as industrial or logistics-dominant companies. On the other hand, it may not be the ideal location for tech, finance, or consulting firms that rely heavily on specialized office workers.

The Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington metro area offers businesses a relatively stable environment with some slack in the labor market, but it also poses significant challenges, including a contracting labor force and stagnant wage growth. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's relatively expensive cost of living, which may require businesses to offer wage premiums to attract and retain talent, potentially increasing labor costs and affecting profitability.

Richmond

Richmond

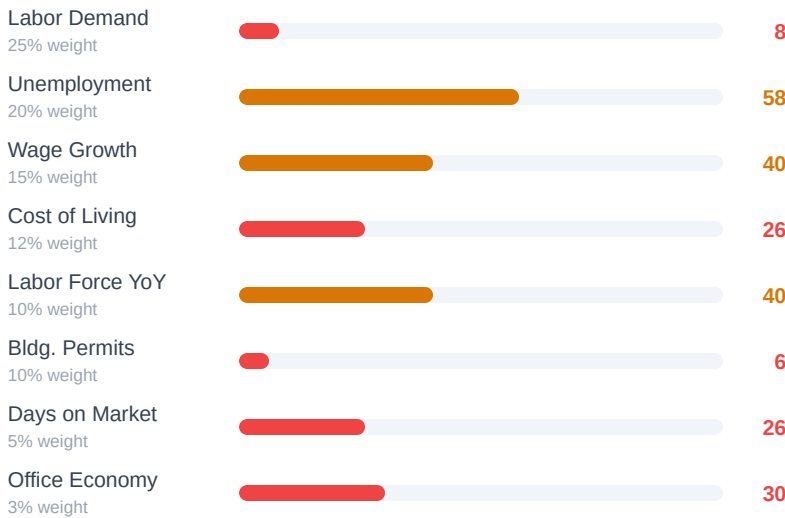
C-

CRITICAL

29.6th percentile

Rank 49 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

3.4%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+3.0%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

-0.5%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY

-0.9%

civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS

-28.1%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

36 days

median, -2.7% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Richmond metro area has an overall grade of C- with a composite score ranking it 29.6th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with a composite score in the bottom tier, and its declining building permits, which signal a potential housing supply squeeze. Specifically, the labor demand composite score of 2.22 and the -28.08% year-over-year change in building permits are key metrics that shape the city's economic landscape.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Richmond is -0.54% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating 1.323% above the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a survivor squeeze, where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles, rather than genuine demand expansion. The low labor demand composite score of 2.22, ranking in the bottom tier, reinforces this interpretation.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Richmond is 3.40%, which is near the median, ranking 58th percentile. This indicates a relatively balanced labor market, neither too tight nor too slack. For a business trying to hire in this city, the moderate unemployment rate means that hiring may not be excessively difficult, but it also may not be extremely easy, with some wage pressure possible.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Richmond is +3.03%, which is near the median, ranking 40th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively so, and worker purchasing power is increasing, but not dramatically. This pace of wage growth is neither exceptionally fast nor stagnant.

Cost of Living

Richmond has a cost of living score ranking 26th percentile, with a PSF of \$232/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$36.20/hr, resulting in a ratio of 6.41. This indicates that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers. The fact that PSF is rising 2.2% year-over-year relative to wages further reinforces this conclusion. As a result, attracting talent without offering wage premiums may be challenging due to the city's below-average affordability.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Richmond is shrinking at a rate of -0.93% year-over-year. This contraction in labor force supply poses a structural headwind for hiring, making it more difficult for businesses to find and recruit workers. The negative growth rate indicates that the workforce is not expanding, which may limit the city's ability to support business growth.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits in Richmond is -28.08%, indicating a sharp decline in housing supply expansion. This signals a potential supply squeeze building ahead, which could lead to decreased affordability and make it more challenging for the workforce to find accommodation. The falling permits suggest that developer confidence is waning, which may have long-term implications for the city's housing market and workforce attraction.

Days on Market

The current median days on market in Richmond is 36 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -2.7%. This relatively fast pace of home sales, combined with the declining trend, indicates a competitive market that may be challenging for relocating workers to find housing. The low days on market suggests that the housing market is still relatively hot, despite some signs of normalization.

Office Economy

Richmond's professional and office worker share ranks 30th percentile, indicating a relatively shallow talent pool in these sectors. This suggests that the city is less suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms. However, it may be more suitable for businesses with industrial or logistics-dominated economies.

The Richmond metro area offers a business a relatively balanced labor market and moderate wage growth, but it also poses significant challenges, including a declining labor force, a potential housing supply squeeze, and below-average affordability. The single biggest risk or constraint for a decision-maker to factor in is the city's low labor demand and declining building permits, which may limit the city's ability to support business growth and attract talent without offering significant wage premiums.

Jacksonville

Jacksonville

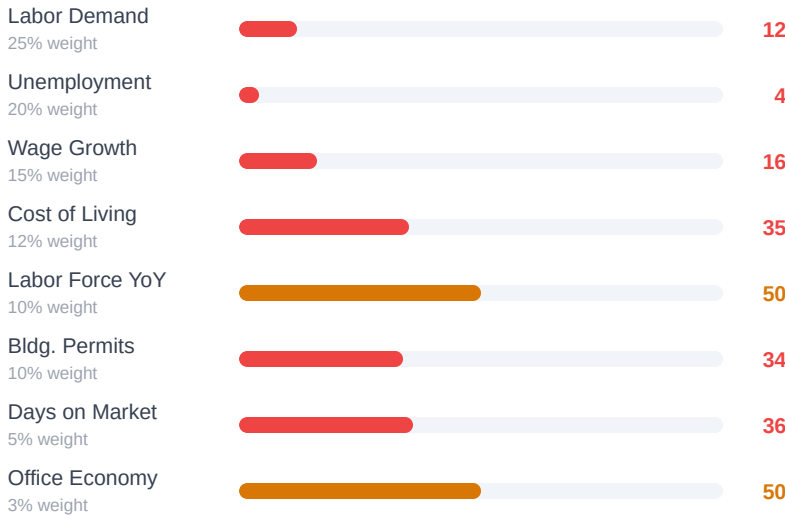
D

EMERGENCY

22.1th percentile

Rank 50 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

4.8%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+1.2%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

-0.4%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY

-0.5%

civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS

-12.0%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

59 days

median, -1.7% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The city of Jacksonville has an overall grade of D, ranking in the 22.1th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a labor demand composite score of 2.55. The city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand and high unemployment rate, with employment growth at -0.42% year-over-year and an unemployment rate of 4.80%. These metrics signal significant challenges for businesses looking to expand or relocate in the area.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Jacksonville is -0.42% year-over-year, and weekly hours are 1.167% above the city's own 12-month trend. This combination signals a survivor squeeze, where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles, rather than genuine demand expansion. The labor demand composite score of 2.55 is in the bottom tier, at the 12th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Jacksonville is 4.80%, which is in the bottom tier, at the 4th percentile. This indicates a tight labor market with significant slack, making it challenging for businesses to hire and retain workers. The high unemployment rate implies that businesses may face weaker local consumer demand.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Jacksonville is 1.23%, which is in the bottom tier, at the 16th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but at a slow pace, and worker purchasing power is not increasing significantly. The wage growth rate is not fast enough to drive significant economic expansion.

Cost of Living

Jacksonville has a cost of living score of 35th percentile, with a PSF of \$218/sqft, which is decreasing by 2.7% year-over-year, and an average hourly earnings of \$36.76/hr. This makes the city relatively affordable, with a ratio of 5.93 below average. The decreasing PSF and relatively low cost of living make Jacksonville an attractive location for talent without requiring significant wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Jacksonville is shrinking at a rate of -0.49% year-over-year, which is near the median, at the 50th percentile. This contraction in labor force supply implies that businesses may face structural headwinds in hiring and expanding their workforce. The shrinking labor pool may limit the city's ability to support business growth.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Jacksonville is decreasing by 12.00% year-over-year, which is below average, at the 34th percentile. This decline in building permits signals a tightening of housing supply, which may lead to decreased affordability and increased competition for housing in the future. The decrease in building permits may constrain workforce accommodation and limit the city's ability to attract new talent.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Jacksonville is 59 days, with a year-over-year decrease of 1.7%. This indicates a relatively fast-paced market, where homes are selling quickly. However, the decrease in days on market may signal a competitive market, making it challenging for relocating workers to find affordable housing.

Office Economy

Jacksonville has an office economy score at the 50th percentile, with a share of professional and office workers at 2.62. This indicates a moderate depth of professional talent pool, making the city suitable for businesses that require a mix of office and non-office workers. The city is relatively well-suited for businesses that are not heavily reliant on specialized office roles, such as logistics or industrial companies.

The city of Jacksonville offers businesses a relatively affordable cost of living and a moderate wage growth rate, but it is constrained by low labor demand, high unemployment, and a shrinking labor force. The single biggest risk or constraint for businesses considering relocation to Jacksonville is the limited availability of skilled workers and the potential for decreased affordability due to tightening housing supply.